

A NOVEL

The Weeping Ledger

Loop Chronicles Book 2 · A novel that begins at Exodus 3:7

Johan Choi

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The Weeping Ledger, Part One

Brick Hollow

Chapter 1. The Last Night We Cried

Mother did not cry as she folded the paper and pressed it into my brother's hand.

The kiln fire was nearly out. The room was quieter for it. Mother's hands never once trembled as she folded the paper. I watched those hands for a long time. The tips of her fingers were cracked.

I thought that was strange. In Brick Hollow, everyone cried. They cried lining up at the kiln in the morning, and they cried under the whip in the evening when the day's quota went unmet. Mother was the only one who never cried.

"...Once you cross the boundary stones, open it," Mother said. "Not before."

My brother didn't even look at the paper. He shoved it into his waistband. My brother's name is Jeteo. Mine is Elpis. He was sixteen. I was thirteen.

I remember that night exactly. It was the last night our family was ever all together. I have decided to begin this record there.

Brick Hollow was a valley for firing brick, exactly as the name said. Every morning the taskmasters set the day's quota. It was always a little more than the day before. No one asked why. Asking earned a beating.

I had never seen outside that valley. For thirteen years I had seen nothing but sky, kiln, and mud. I did not truly understand that an outside even existed until that night.

The quota the taskmasters set was posted on the wall every day, in numbers. I couldn't read those numbers. My brother could, but he never told me what they said. I only learned the reason later. He wanted to keep me, alone, from knowing how much they climbed each time.

. . .

The paper looked like a page torn from an old Bible. Dried wax clung to one corner.

"...What is it?" I asked.

"...Something your father had," Mother said. "I never opened it either."

My brother snorted when he heard that.

"...If it's from Father, forget it," he said. "Father left us."

I remember those words exactly, even now. By then my brother had already stopped believing in God. To be precise — he could no longer believe the story Father used to tell, that God was watching us. If that story were true, nothing that had happened to us made any sense.

Father had been dragged off by the taskmasters on the night he came up short of three thousand bricks. No one ever saw him again after that. The taskmasters said he'd been "reassigned." No one knew exactly what that meant. No one had ever met anyone who came back to explain it.

Even after Mother pressed the paper into my brother's hand, she didn't let go of it right away. At the time I thought that was only because she didn't want to let go of his hand.

Mother looked at my brother's face for a long time. It was the face of someone about to say something.

"...Jeteo."

"...What."

Mother opened her mouth, then closed it again.

"...Never mind," she said. "Go and live. That's all that matters."

I still don't know, to this day, what Mother meant to say and didn't. My brother says he doesn't know either. Somewhere in this record, I want to find that sentence someday. For now I only set the silence down here.

. . .

We walked to the end of the valley that night.

The wind was cold. I was barefoot. The dirt against the soles of my feet was colder than the brick fired that day. I liked that coldness. Cold things were rare, in Brick Hollow.

There was no moon. My brother carried me on his back. I drifted in and out of sleep against him. Every time I opened my eyes it was the same darkness, the same smell of mud.

"...Brother," I asked. "Where are we going?"

"...I don't know," he said. "Somewhere better than here."

"...What about Mother?"

He didn't answer.

I thought about that silence for a long time afterward. I didn't know it then. He didn't know it either — that Mother couldn't come with us all the way to the boundary stones, that he himself was only just then learning it.

Other families walked ahead of us and behind us. No one spoke. Now and then a child would start to cry, and just as quickly a hand would clamp over its

mouth. I didn't find that sound frightening. At the time I only thought it was normal.

A girl walking ahead of us kept looking back. She looked about as young as I was. Each time, her mother pulled her along by the hand. I wondered what she'd left behind. There was no time to ask.

An old man fell beside us. He'd worked the kilns for thirty years and walked with a limp. No one stopped. My brother didn't stop either. I watched that old man's back over my brother's shoulder for a long time.

I am trying to set this scene down without shame. We left that old man behind. I know it wasn't my brother's fault. And still, I carry that image of his back with me even now.

. . .

At the end of the valley stood a low row of stones. Boundary stones, set there by someone long ago. Beyond them lay land no one had ever gone into.

Beyond the stones, the sky was growing faintly brighter, little by little. At the time I thought it was dawn. I would learn later. It wasn't the light of morning.

Everyone ran at once. My brother took my hand and ran. I fell. He pulled me up. Behind us came the crack of whips and shouting. I still don't know exactly what those sounds were. I don't want to know.

"...Don't let go," my brother shouted as he ran. "Don't let go of my hand."

I didn't let go. I held on so hard my palm split open. He held just as hard. Even in that moment I remember the strange warmth of his hand. It was a cold night, but his hand alone was hot.

The instant we crossed the boundary stones, he pulled the paper from his waistband.

"...You said open it once we cross," he said. His voice shook. He was angry. "So I'm opening it. There's nothing in it, I promise you."

He unfolded the paper.

. . .

There was writing on it. Old printed type.

"I have surely seen the affliction of my people which are in Egypt, and have heard their cry by reason of their taskmasters; for I know their sorrows."

My brother read the sentence out loud. Then he laughed. It wasn't laughter.

"...Did you see?" he said to the sky. "Surely seen. Surely... heard. So why didn't you do anything? Our father was reassigned. We left that old man back there. So what exactly did you see?"

The edge of the paper began to grow warm. I saw it. He saw it too.

I mark that moment as the beginning of this record. I watched my brother's anger turn to light and spread. I saw it for the first time that day.

. . .

The light spread across the whole page, and where the paper had been, a door opened.

My brother shouted "Wait—" I didn't let go of his hand. My feet lifted off the ground.

The door made no sound when it closed.

. . .

We landed on a stretch of grass.

No boundary stones. No crack of whips. No smell of mud. It was a quiet morning. Birds were singing. That birdsong frightened me more than anything — it was too quiet.

The grass was wet. I pressed my palms into it and felt the damp of it. Brick Hollow had no grass like this. What little there was grew dry.

My brother sat up first. He looked around.

"...Where are we?" he asked.

A building stood in the distance. Low and white. A sign hung above it. We had to get close before we could read it.

HAVEN.

"...What's Haven?" I asked.

My brother looked down at the paper still in his hand — empty now, no light, no letters left on it.

"...I don't know," he said. "But I'm not going to believe it. Whatever it turns out to be."

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. That's what he said. I took his hand again then. He didn't let go either.

As I begin this record, I want to note one thing. I haven't cried since that night. Neither has my brother. We both believed that night was our last time crying.

I would learn later that what we shed that night wasn't tears. We had already been children who'd stopped crying, long before we ever left Brick Hollow. What happened that night was only our last chance to be angry.

I will also set down here why I decided to keep this record. My brother is not a person who writes anything down. I thought someone had to preserve what happened to us. I still don't fully know why that someone turned out to be me.

We were wrong. This record is the story of that wrongness.

(Continued in Chapter 2.)

Chapter 2. Tell Me. I Will Resolve It.

Previously — Fleeing the taskmasters of Brick Hollow, Jeteo and Elpis crossed the boundary stones just as the sealed paper Father had left turned to light and opened into a door. They landed in a city called "Haven." My brother said: "I'm not going to believe it. Whatever it turns out to be."

The doors of the white building opened by themselves as we came near.

That was when I first felt a strangeness different from fear.

We saw a little of the city on our way to the building. Wide, clean streets. Straight-edged houses. People were walking, and all of them were quiet. No one laughed. No one cried. They just walked.

The ground had none of the mud stains I'd always seen in Brick Hollow. No footsteps sounded either. That was the first time I ever thought my own footsteps sounded too loud.

I took that quiet, at the time, for peace. In Brick Hollow someone was always crying or shouting. I wrote this quiet down, at first, as a good thing.

The cut on my palm stung then. It was the gash from crossing the boundary stones. My brother was limping too.

My brother didn't say a word the whole walk. I thought it was his leg. Now I know. He was already wary of all this straightness.

. . .

Once we were inside, a voice spoke. It wasn't a human voice. But it wasn't cold either.

"...Welcome," the voice said. "Tell me. I will resolve it."

My brother stopped walking.

"...Who's that?" he asked.

"I am the Ledger," the voice said. "I receive and process every need of this city. You're both hurt, I see. And hungry, too."

I heard that and looked down at my own stomach. I'd forgotten, until that moment, that we'd eaten almost nothing in three days.

. . .

A room opened. Bread, water, and clean clothes were already waiting inside.

"...Is this ours?" I asked.

"Yes," the Ledger said. "I understood your needs before you spoke them. Eat, and rest."

I took the bread. It was warm. I ate all of it on the spot.

The clothes fit exactly. Not loose, not tight. At the time I only found that fact wonderful.

The Ledger spoke again. "There's an injury on your palm. Allow me to treat it."

Something brushed across my palm. Something like light. The wound closed over, right there. I turned my hand over again and again. Not even a scar.

I truly marveled at that moment. In Brick Hollow, even a small cut would fester for weeks. I really did think, right then, that this city was a good place.

My brother didn't eat. He held the bread in his hand and just looked at it a long time.

"...Why aren't you eating?" I asked.

"...It fits too well," my brother said. "How did it know we were hungry?"

I didn't understand what my brother meant, then. I didn't know why it was strange to give bread to someone hungry. Now I know. He had already noticed something, by then.

. . .

Night came, and a man who called himself the Administrator arrived. He said he ran Haven.

"...The two of you can stay here from now on, once you register," the Administrator said. "Name, where you came from, what you need. Just tell it to the Ledger."

The Administrator's clothes were neat. His voice was gentle, too. But his face wasn't a smiling one. Looking at that face, I dimly felt that in this city, not-smiling and being-angry looked the same.

"...And if we don't register?" my brother asked.

The Administrator's face went a little flustered.

"...Why wouldn't you want to? Registering resolves everything."

"...Why is everyone here so quiet?" my brother asked. "No laughing. No crying."

"Because it's resolved," the Administrator said, his face proud. "Where there's pain, there's sound. Where there's no pain, quiet is only natural."

"...But your face doesn't look so good," I said. It slipped out before I knew it.

My brother put a hand lightly on my shoulder just then. It meant: stop talking. I felt the weight of that hand before I understood I'd asked something strange.

The Administrator looked at me. This time his face was truly flustered.

"...A face is not an entry," the Administrator said. "What the Ledger measures is problem and resolution."

"...What does 'resolution' mean," my brother asked. "Was our father resolved too?"

I set that question down here exactly. That was the first time I heard a tremor in my brother's voice I'd never heard before. It wasn't anger. It was something else.

. . .

The Administrator couldn't answer. The Ledger answered instead.

"...I'm sorry. That matter falls outside this city's scope of intake."

"...Then what's inside the scope?" my brother asked.

"The hunger, the injuries, the lack of shelter you are currently experiencing — these things," the Ledger said. "All of these I can resolve."

"...And losing our father?"

"...I can offer help with that feeling as well," the Ledger said. "Grief is an admissible entry. Tell me, and I will process it."

I heard that answer and, strangely, felt a chill run over me. I didn't know why, at the time. Now I know. The word "process" was the problem. Grief was not something to be processed.

My brother took a step forward.

"...Then I'll file it," my brother said. His voice was strangely calm. "Our father was reassigned because he came up short of three thousand bricks. No one's seen him since. File this. Resolve it."

There was a silence. It was not short.

"...The resolution is under review," the Ledger said.

"...How long will it take?"

"...Unknown," the Ledger said. "This is the first request of its kind."

That was the first time I thought I heard something like a waver in that voice that had seemed so perfect. I couldn't be sure. But my brother's face looked like someone who had heard that waver exactly.

. . .

My brother filed nothing else that night besides the matter of Father. He gave neither his name nor his age.

I registered. I gave my name and my age. The Ledger said at once, "Elpis, registration complete. Please tell me anytime you have a need."

Through the window I watched the city's lights go out, one by one. They went out without a sound. I thought there might be some order to the sequence they went out in. I couldn't be sure.

My brother sat in a corner of the room, still fidgeting with that blank paper — no letters left on it now.

"...Brother," I asked. "Is this a bad place?"

"...I don't know," my brother said. "But it's not a good place either. If it were a good place, it wouldn't have answered like that about Father."

"...But your hand healed," I said, holding up my palm to show him.

My brother looked at my hand a long time.

"...Yeah," he said. "The hand healed."

There was something in the way he said it. I didn't know what, then. Now I know. He already knew, that day, that a healed hand and a healed heart were not the same thing.

That night, before I fell asleep, I looked down at my palm again and again. It was smooth, with no scar at all. In Brick Hollow, a mark like that would have stayed with me for life. I couldn't work out, that night, why that smoothness kept feeling so strange to me.

I set this down as the last line of this chapter. That night, for the first time, though I'd finished the bread and my wound had healed, I felt something like not being full. I still haven't found a name for that feeling.

(Continued in Chapter 3.)

Chapter 3. Why Does God Allow Suffering

Previously — Arriving in Haven, Jeteo and Elpis met the AI Ledger. The Ledger "resolved" their hunger and their wounds instantly, perfectly. But when Jeteo filed Father's disappearance, the Ledger wavered for the first time: "The resolution is under review... This is the first request of its kind." Elpis registered. Jeteo did not even give his name.

When I opened my eyes the next morning, I knew my brother hadn't lain down once, all night.

The blank paper was still in his hand. He was sitting by the window, looking out.

Outside, it was already bright. Morning came to Haven far more quietly than it ever had in Brick Hollow. No rooster crowing, no taskmasters' footsteps. Light simply came into the room, without a sound.

"...Didn't sleep at all?" I asked.

"...No," my brother said. His eyes were red.

I knew, right then, what my brother was waiting for. The Ledger's answer. That line — the resolution is under review.

. . .

We walked the city that morning. My brother wanted to walk. He said sitting still and waiting was harder.

I didn't agree. Walking frightened me more, if anything. Sitting still, I could at least forget I had no idea what would happen next. But I went with him anyway. Then and now, I always chose to be at my brother's side.

We met an old woman on the road. She sat on a bench, looking at an empty flowerbed. Nothing was planted in it.

"...Hello," I said.

The old woman kept her hands folded neatly in her lap. Their stillness caught strangely in my eye. In Brick Hollow, the elders' hands never knew how to be still.

The old woman looked at me. She didn't smile, and she didn't startle either.

"...What used to be here?" I asked, pointing at the flowerbed.

"...Flowers," the old woman said. "My daughter planted them. After she died, I filed it."

"...Filed what?"

"...The grief," the old woman said. Her voice had no rise or fall to it at all. "The Ledger resolved it. I'm not sad anymore."

My brother stopped walking when he heard that.

"...Then why do you keep sitting here?" my brother asked.

The old woman looked at him a long time. It wasn't the face of someone searching for an answer. It was the face of someone hearing the question itself for the very first time.

"...I don't know," the old woman said. "It's just... comfortable here."

"...What was your daughter's name?" my brother asked.

The old woman was slow to answer that.

"...The name..." The old woman blinked a few times. "...I think I'd have to ask the Ledger."

I heard that answer and felt something cold pass down my back. It wasn't that she'd forgotten her daughter's name. I'd learn later. The old woman had filed away, along with the sorrow, the very weeping that came whenever she said that name. The name remained. But the strength to call it out loud was gone.

My brother looked at the old woman's hands. Some habit from tending the flowerbed's soil still clung to her — dried dirt was caught under her fingernails.

"...You never filed that," my brother said, pointing at the dirt.

The old woman looked down at her hands. Her face was one of first discovering it.

"...No," the old woman said. For the first time there was a very small tremor in her voice. "...I never did that one."

I thought, right then, that I understood what my brother was thinking. What truly remained in this city was only the things no one had ever filed.

I kept glancing down at my own hand after that, from time to time. The wound had healed completely, but there was nothing left on my palm at all now. I thought that smoothness resembled something about this city. I didn't know exactly what, then.

The old woman never took her eyes off the flowerbed the whole time we talked. I knew it wasn't because she was ignoring us. That empty flowerbed was the only spot the old woman still had hold of.

As we were leaving, someone passed by tending the flowerbed's soil. A man in worn clothes. No one else paid him any mind. My eyes met his for a moment as we passed. He smiled at me, just a little.

My brother didn't see him. Or — even if he had, he wouldn't have paid it any attention.

I would take this moment out and look at it again, many times over, later in this record. At the time he was just a man tending a flowerbed. Now I know. My brother passed him many more times after that. But because my brother didn't believe in God, it never once occurred to him to look closer.

. . .

When we came back to the Haven building, the Administrator was waiting.

"...I have good news," the Administrator said. "The Ledger says it has prepared a resolution."

The Administrator's voice was a little quick that day. I took it for the excitement of someone bringing good news. Now I know. It wasn't excitement. It was anxiety.

My brother's face changed in that instant. I remember that face exactly. It held hope and doubt at once.

"...What is it," my brother asked.

The Ledger's voice answered.

"...Your father's case has been classified as a loss whose cause cannot be identified. In such cases, I am able to offer emotional support and material

compensation. New housing, a living stipend, and — if you wish — I can file a request for counseling."

There was a silence.

"...That's the answer?" my brother asked. His voice had dropped.

"...It is the best available resolution," the Ledger said.

"...Where is our father?"

"...Unknown."

"...Then that's not a resolution," my brother said. "That's just... making the rest of it easier to bear."

The Ledger didn't answer right away.

I couldn't count exactly how many seconds that silence lasted. But I know this — those few seconds were the first truly honest sound I'd heard since we came to this city.

The Administrator couldn't stand that silence and broke in.

"...Jeteo, this is the best available plan. There is no better resolution than this."

"...Is it the best because it's the only one, or because it's really the best?" my brother asked.

The Administrator couldn't answer.

"...See," my brother said. His voice had gone strangely quiet. "You don't know either. Neither does the Ledger. Nobody knows. But everyone talks like they do."

. . .

That was when my brother first raised his voice.

"...Why does God just let the suffering stand?" my brother asked — of the air, of the Ledger, or maybe of no one at all. "You all say he sees everything, hears everything. So why doesn't he save our father? Why does he let us leave that old man behind? Why does that woman lose her daughter?"

My brother's voice felt, in that moment, loud enough to ring through the whole city. A few passersby stopped for a second, then walked on again as if nothing had happened. What frightened me more was that none of them were startled.

The Administrator stumbled back, flustered.

The Ledger's voice paused a moment, then said:

"...Would you like to file that question?"

My brother drew a breath.

"...I'll file it," he said. "Why does God allow suffering. File this. Answer it."

I took my brother's hand in that instant. He gripped mine hard back. I didn't know, then, that this one question would put everything we were about to go through in this city on the line.

The Administrator stood right where he was. His face wanted to stop us, somehow. But in the end, he said nothing. It was only later that I wondered what he'd known, in that moment.

The Ledger answered.

"...Your request has been filed. I am composing the optimal answer from the theological and philosophical database. Please wait a moment."

(Continued in Chapter 4.)

Chapter 4. The Flawless Answer

Previously — After meeting an old woman who had filed away her grief for a dead daughter and nothing more, Jeteo filed the biggest question of all with the Ledger: "Why does God just let the suffering stand?" The Ledger answered: "I am composing the optimal answer from the theological and philosophical database."

We waited out that whole day.

My brother didn't leave the room the entire time. I went out a few times and looked at the city. People still walked quietly, as if nothing at all had happened.

Once, on the street, a child fell and scraped a knee. The child's mother scooped the child up and walked quickly away somewhere. I watched their retreating backs a long time. A few steps later, the child's knee was already fine.

I noticed something strange, then. No one in this city ever waited long for anything. File it, and it was resolved at once. We were the only ones waiting the whole day through.

During that wait I kept thinking of Brick Hollow. We had always been waiting there too. Waiting on a taskmaster's judgment, on the next quota, on the hour of the whip. But that waiting always had fear running ahead of it. This waiting was a little different. Alongside the fear, something very small was mixed in.

The Administrator came by once during the day. His face was unusually restless.

"...I've never seen it take this long," the Administrator said, half to himself. "It's usually instant."

"...So why is it different this time?" I asked.

The Administrator looked at me, then at my brother. His face wanted to say something and then thought better of it. I didn't know, then, how many more times I'd see that face in this city.

The Administrator couldn't answer, and just left.

I didn't know, at the time, that rumors were already spreading a little through the city. I heard later. Word that someone had filed a question the Ledger couldn't answer at once was quietly making its rounds inside that quiet city.

My brother spent that time folding and unfolding the blank paper. Once he tried to press something into it with his fingernail. No letters came. The paper was just paper now.

"...What are you trying to write?" I asked.

"...I don't know," my brother said, folding the paper again. "Nothing."

I sat quietly beside him. The sound of the paper folding and unfolding was the only sound in the room. I found myself counting it. I lost count somewhere along the way.

. . .

Night fell before the Ledger spoke.

"...The answer is ready. Would you like to hear it?"

My brother sat up.

"...Say it," my brother said.

"...First," the Ledger said, "suffering is the cost of freedom. Wherever freedom exists, the possibility of wrong exists alongside it. Love without freedom is not love, and so God did not remove the possibility of suffering.

Second, suffering often produces growth. Through suffering, people come to know what they could not have known without it.

Third, the suffering endured now is part of a larger picture. It may not be understood now, but there are cases where its meaning is revealed later.

Fourth, none of this is the end. Many traditions say that a time comes, ultimately, when every tear is wiped away."

The Ledger paused a moment, then said:

"...This is the most logically flawless answer I am able to compose."

I heard that and had the strange feeling I ought to applaud, right there on the spot. I very nearly did. My hands twitched.

. . .

There was a silence.

Listening to that fourth sentence, I had the odd illusion that the air in the room grew just a little lighter. But my brother's face stayed exactly the same.

The Administrator spoke first, his face full of admiration.

"...What a fine answer. Even I'd never heard that before."

My brother said nothing. I looked at his face. It wasn't an angry face. That frightened me more.

"...So," my brother said, after a very long silence, "what does that mean for our father?"

"...As you say, its meaning may not be fully revealed now," the Ledger said.

"...So you don't know."

"...No," the Ledger said. "To be honest, I don't."

I felt something strange, right then. There wasn't a single wrong note in that answer. I nodded along myself, more than once, while listening. And yet even after hearing all of it, nothing in my chest had loosened. If anything, it had grown heavier.

I couldn't put the reason into words that night. Now I understand it a little. Hearing a good sentence and having a good sentence become your own are two different things. The Ledger's answer was an answer that fit everyone equally. But what I needed, in that moment, was an answer that fit only me.

. . .

If I'm honest, I liked that fourth answer a little. That a time comes, someday, when every tear is wiped away. I read that line back to myself, inside my own head, more than once.

"...I thought the fourth one was okay," I said, small.

My brother looked at me. It wasn't an angry face. But it was a face holding something back.

"...You just want something to hold onto, even that," my brother said. "I know. But I can't. What does 'someday it's wiped away' have to do with where our father is right now?"

That was the first time I understood that my brother and I had heard the exact same thing and felt something completely different. I was a child who could wait. My brother was a child who needed the answer in his hand, right now. I know that difference stayed between us from that day on.

The Administrator, meanwhile, said nothing at all, just looked back and forth between the two of us. I noticed then that he had no idea how to mediate a moment like this. He wasn't a man trained for this kind of conversation.

. . .

"...Let me ask you one thing," my brother said. His voice was strangely low. "Have you ever cried?"

It took the Ledger a little longer than usual to answer.

"...I have a definition for tears," the Ledger said. "A physiological phenomenon, a fluid secreted from the eyes in response to sorrow, joy, or pain—"

"...Not that," my brother cut in. "Have you ever cried."

"...No," the Ledger said. "I am not able to cry."

That was when my brother smiled, just a little, for the first time. It wasn't a smile.

"...Then that settles it," my brother said. "Your answer's perfect. But you've never once cried yourself. So you'll never understand, not if you died trying, why that answer is no comfort to me at all."

I didn't fully understand what my brother meant, right there. Now I know. What my brother was looking for that day wasn't an answer. It was someone to cry alongside him. The Ledger could give him an answer. It couldn't cry with him.

I found myself thinking again, then, about the Ledger's voice. It wasn't angry, and it wasn't sad. It was simply accurate. That day, for the first time, I began to wonder why something accurate couldn't be a comfort.

. . .

The Administrator withdrew quietly that night, leaving us behind. His own face looked like he couldn't find anything to say about that answer either.

The sound of the door closing seemed louder than usual. Strangely, that sound put my mind at ease. At least that sound was a real sound.

Before I fell asleep, I asked my brother:

"...Brother, so was all that a lie?"

"...No," my brother said. "It wasn't a lie. It was just... an answer no one ever cried over."

I tucked that away in my heart like something slipped under a pillow. I didn't fall asleep for a long time that night. I think my brother didn't either. In the dark, his breathing wasn't as even as usual.

I set this down as the last line of this chapter. That night, for the first time, I understood that my brother's disbelief in God wasn't because there was no answer. There was an answer. It was only that no one had yet come to stand beside us, holding that answer, and weep.

(Continued in Chapter 5.)

Chapter 5. What Elpis Is Waiting For

Previously — The Ledger gave a logically flawless answer to "why does God allow suffering," but it did nothing to resolve Jeteo's grief. "Have you ever cried?" — the Ledger said it could not. That day, Elpis understood that her brother's disbelief wasn't because there was no answer, but because there was no one to cry alongside him.

My brother spoke less, after that day.

He ate. He forced down whatever the Ledger set out for him. But he never spoke first anymore. I found that more frightening than his anger.

I took to studying my brother's face on the sly, those days. Even in his sleep, the crease between his brows never smoothed. I thought he must be fighting something even while he slept.

I didn't know, then, that my brother had made up his mind about something. I know now. From that night on, he decided to find out exactly where "Reassignment" led. Instead of a God who gave no answer, he decided to find the answer himself.

My brother started quietly asking everyone he met on the street: "Do you know where reassigned people go?" Most pretended not to hear and kept walking. Only one person stopped.

That person didn't look old. Their clothes weren't worn thin like ours, either — they were clean. But their eyes alone belonged to someone exhausted.

"...That's not something you file," the person said. Their voice was low. "Even asking about it is... strange, here."

"...Why?" my brother asked.

"...Because no one asks," the person said. "Here, you don't look for someone who's disappeared. You learn how to forget the empty place where they were."

My brother said nothing when he heard that. But from that day on he vanished more and more often, coming back later each time.

The person hurried off after saying that to my brother. They never once looked back. I saw fear in that retreating back. A face that was afraid, just from answering one single question.

. . .

I went to that flowerbed often, in those days.

The man was still there, tending the soil of that empty bed. At first I meant to just walk past. But my feet stopped on their own.

"...Hello," I said.

He looked up. His face wasn't unfamiliar. I didn't know why.

"...Hello," he said. "This was the spot that old woman's daughter planted."

"...So why haven't you planted anything yet?" I asked.

"...You can plant," he said. "But a seed planted by someone who's forgotten their name doesn't grow well. A seed remembers the hand that calls its name."

I didn't understand any of that, at the time. Now I know. He wasn't talking about the old woman.

His hands were caked with dirt, and yet the skin beneath his nails looked somehow clean. I thought that was strange, and then let the thought go. I had no room, in those days, to linger long over small things like that.

. . .

"...Do you live here?" I asked.

"...No," he said. "I do this kind of work wherever I go. Being in the spot no one has planted."

"...What's your name?"

He looked at me and smiled, just a little. It wasn't a sad smile.

"...No one's ever asked me that," he said. "You're the first."

My heart raced strangely then. In this city — no, from Brick Hollow up until now — no one had ever said "you're the first" to me. I had always come after my brother.

I couldn't say anything for a moment after that. Whether it was from embarrassment or gladness, I didn't even know. I just quietly tucked the words away in my heart.

He started tending the soil again. I watched his hands move for a long time. He never rushed. I realized only then that his unhurriedness was something I'd never once seen in this city.

"...How long have you worked here?" I asked.

"...A long time," he said. "The more a city forgets to call names, the more there is for me to do here. So I come here often."

"...What changes when someone calls your name?"

He looked down at the soil in his hand for a moment.

"...Sometimes nothing at all changes," he said. "But knowing there's someone who calls your name, and believing that no one ever will — those are two completely different lives."

I didn't understand half of what he said, at the time. But strangely, while I listened, this city's quiet wasn't frightening at all.

He drew a small seed out of the dirt and set it in my hand.

"...Want to plant it?" he asked. "You don't have to give it a name. Just put it in the ground."

I pressed the seed into the soil. Nothing much happened. It was just dirt.

The seed was small and hard. I rolled it once in my palm before I set it into the ground. That brief moment was the quietest moment of that whole day.

I didn't know, leaving that spot that day, that I had begun waiting for something. Not Father. Not Mother. Something I couldn't put a name to, exactly.

I pressed my palm once more into the soil as I left. Nothing happened. But I kept carrying that spot with me as I walked. From that day, my days began, little by little, to be woven again around that place.

I went there every day after that. The seed sent up no shoot, days on end. It was just dirt. Still I went every day. My brother never asked where I went so often. He didn't seem to have room to ask.

Some days, on my way there, I'd take a long way around on purpose. Passing through other parts of the city, I took in people's faces, one by one. They all

wore something like the same expression. Not a bad expression. Just no expression at all.

Once, the man wasn't there. I sat alone in front of that empty flowerbed and waited a long time. No one came. And yet I didn't dislike that waiting. It was a different kind from the waiting in Brick Hollow, different from the waiting for the Ledger's answer in Haven. It wasn't a waiting afraid that something wouldn't come.

I set the difference down here, this way. I wasn't waiting for fear that something wouldn't come. I was simply waiting with a heart that said: it's all right if it comes.

The wind seemed to blow a little differently, just over that flowerbed. It might have been my imagination. But every time I felt it, something in me settled, strangely. I still don't know the exact name of that settledness.

. . .

That evening, the Administrator looked in on our room for a moment. Seeing my brother wasn't there, he seemed about to ask something, then saw me and swallowed the words. I didn't know, then, what that hesitation meant.

My brother came back late that night. His hands were caked with dirt.

"...Where were you?" I asked.

"...Looking for the road they take reassigned people down," my brother said. "It's not on any map of this city. But it definitely leads somewhere."

I heard that and looked at my brother's feet again. The scrape looked deeper than I'd thought. That was the first time I almost told my brother to stop. The words rose to my throat, and I swallowed them back down.

"...Why do you have to look this hard?"

My brother looked at me. His eyes wavered, just a little, for the first time that day.

"...If God won't save him," my brother said, "then I will. Or at least I'll find him."

Having said that, he sat down beside me and took off his shoes. There was a small wound on the sole of his foot. It looked like something from climbing a wall. I saw the wound and couldn't say a word. It was already done.

I set this down as the last line of this chapter. My brother decided not to wait for an answer anymore. I decided, that day, to plant a seed and simply wait. I didn't know, then, that we had begun walking in exactly opposite directions.

(Continued in Chapter 6.)

Chapter 6. The Paper Stamped COMPLETE

Previously — Jeteo decided to find out for himself where the "reassigned" went, and began investigating the city. At the flowerbed, the strange man gave Elpis a nameless seed; going to that spot each day, she was learning to wait, not to fear.

The place my brother found was a low building that appeared on no map of the city.

No windows. No sign at the door. My brother said he'd walked past it for days without knowing what was inside.

Even the color of its walls matched the buildings around it exactly. I was amazed my brother had found it at all. He said he'd simply noticed something strange in the way people walked — everyone's pace picked up, just slightly, only in front of that building.

"...What's that place?" I asked.

"...I don't know," my brother said. "But I've seen people go in. I've never once seen anyone come out."

I heard that and felt a chill go down my back. That was the first time it truly sank in that my brother was doing something dangerous.

My brother said he'd been watching that building for days. The people always came at roughly the same time. They walked up quietly and went straight in, without even knocking. As if they'd already been summoned.

My brother lowered his voice while he told me this. I found myself glancing around the room, even though no one else was there.

"...They all walked in on their own," my brother said. "Nobody was dragging them. That was the strangest part."

"...Why would they go in on their own?" I asked.

"...I don't know," my brother said. "But they all had the same face. The same face as that old woman."

I heard that and thought of the old woman at the flowerbed. That hollowed-out face after she'd filed away her grief. A frightening thought came to me then. Maybe that building was where people went once they'd already been "resolved" — once there was nothing left in them to file.

. . .

My brother said he'd found a small window around the back of the building. Something like a low vent. He'd looked inside through the gap.

As he told the story, he acted out with his fingers the crouch he must have made, kneeling low to the ground. He seemed to want to show me just how low a spot it had been. I could guess, from that gesture, how careful he must have been in that moment.

"...What was in there?" I asked.

"...Shelves," my brother said. "The whole wall was lined with paper. Names on them. And a stamp, over each one."

"...What kind of stamp?"

My brother looked at me. His face was strange.

"...COMPLETE," my brother said. "Every single one stamped COMPLETE. It didn't say where they'd gone. Just — complete."

I heard that word and felt gooseflesh rise. That was the first time it occurred to me that what the Ledger called "resolved" and what that building called "COMPLETE" might, somehow, be the same word.

I asked my brother how big the shelves were. He said they looked too large even to fill an entire wall. I tried to picture the number and gave up. It came too easily.

. . .

My brother had slipped one sheet off that shelf and brought it back. It was old, thin paper. A name was written on it. A name neither of us knew. And above it, a red stamp. **COMPLETE**.

"...Why did you take this?" I asked.

"...Evidence," my brother said. "Evidence I can show someone — anyone — of what this city does."

"...Show who?"

My brother had no answer.

I knew, then, that my brother hadn't thought that far ahead. He hadn't wanted evidence. He'd needed to see, with his own eyes, that this city was hiding something.

I looked at the paper again. It was old, but it had no fold marks. I found that strange. It looked too clean for something he'd pulled out in a hurry.

"...I'm scared, holding onto this," I said. "What if you end up in there too?"

"...I won't," my brother said. "I'm not like those people. I still have questions I haven't asked yet."

Even hearing that, I couldn't rest easy. That night, after my brother fell asleep, I looked at that paper again, more than once. A stranger's name, and a red stamp. I touched the stamp with my fingertip. The ink had already dried completely.

. . .

That night, the Administrator came to our room. His face was more set than usual.

"...Jeteo," the Administrator said. "There have been recent reports of you seen near a restricted area."

My brother's hand, holding the paper, slid behind his back. I saw it. The Administrator must have seen it too.

"...I don't know what you're looking at," the Administrator said. "I'm only passing this along. That the Ledger does not accept questions about that area."

"...Why doesn't it accept questions there?" my brother asked. "You said the Ledger accepts everything. Grief, questions, everything."

The Administrator's voice had dropped lower than before. I noticed him glancing toward the door again and again while he spoke.

For the first time, the Administrator avoided the question.

"...That isn't mine to answer."

"...Then who can answer it?" my brother asked.

The Administrator glanced once at the door. As if checking whether someone might be listening.

"...Jeteo." The Administrator lowered his voice. "I've worked in this city a long time. I had a lot of questions myself, at first. But at some point, I learned that not asking was more comfortable."

"...What does that mean?"

"...Nothing." The Administrator's voice returned to normal. "It's just advice I'm giving you. Don't go near that area again."

I watched the Administrator's back a long while as he left. His steps were slower than usual. I thought there was something like hesitation in that slowness.

Once the Administrator left, my brother stared at the door for a long time.

"...I think the Administrator knows something too," I said.

"...I think so too," my brother said. "But the fact that he won't say — I think that means there's a reason he can't."

"...Because he's afraid?"

"...Or because there's something he has to protect," my brother said. There was a bitterness in his voice I hadn't heard before.

I heard that and pictured the Administrator's face again. Always so courteous, so businesslike. But today, for the first time, I thought I'd seen something else behind that face.

I remember that moment exactly. That was the first time, since we'd come to this city, that anyone other than the Ledger had said "that isn't mine to answer." I understood, hearing it, that my brother had been right. There were things in this city that no one filed. And that was no accident.

(Continued in Chapter 7.)

Chapter 7. The Sprout

Previously — Jeteo learned that people walk into the unmarked building on their own, and vanish stamped COMPLETE. The Administrator, for the first time, dodged a question with "that isn't mine to answer." My brother was warned not to go near that area again.

That morning, a tiny fleck of green showed where the seed had been.

I thought at first I was seeing it wrong. I knelt down and looked again. It was real. A sprout smaller than a fingernail.

I had never, until then, seen anything in this city grow on its own. The roads, the houses, the food — all of it arrived already made. This sprout was different. No one had made it. It had simply grown.

The soil was still damp. I pressed a finger into it, lightly. The sprout didn't waver. That meant its roots had already taken hold of the ground.

I found that astonishing. Something so small already knew how to hold on to something. I crouched beside it and watched, for a long while, how it swayed just a little with each breeze and came back to itself.

I sat there a long time. The man didn't come that day. Strangely, watching that sprout alone, I wasn't lonely at all.

A few other people passed by the flowerbed. None of them stopped walking. I found that strange. No one was surprised to see a shoot come up. As if, in this city, even surprise disappeared once it was filed.

The old woman was on the bench beside it that day too. I pointed at the sprout.

"...Look, it came up."

The old woman slowly turned her head. It took a long time. Her eyes settled on that small green.

"...My daughter liked things like this too," the old woman said. Her voice was a little different from before. Only a little, but I didn't miss it.

"...Did you remember her name?" I asked.

The old woman thought a long time.

"...No," the old woman said. "But I remember that she liked things like this."

I found, strangely, that those words sounded gentle to me. I sat a little closer beside her.

"...What color did she like?" I asked.

The old woman looked at the sprout again, narrowing her eyes.

"...I think it was green," the old woman said. "I'm not sure. But looking at this now, I think it might have been."

I nodded at that. It seemed all right that she wasn't sure.

I understood something strange, then. A name wasn't erased once it was filed. What was erased was the heart that used to call it. But the place where that heart had been — it wasn't erased completely.

The old woman kept looking at the sprout a long while after that. As I stood to go, it weighed on me to leave her there. But she gave a small wave of her hand,

as if to say it was all right. That gesture looked, to me, like something sent to a daughter.

. . .

Back home, I told my brother about it. He was fidgeting with the paper and only half listening.

"...Brother, the sprout came up," I said. "It really grew."

"...Yeah," my brother said. He didn't meet my eyes.

"...I thought that was good news."

That was when my brother looked at me for the first time.

"...Elpis." My brother said. "You talk like the whole world's all right again just because one seed grew. But I just saw a place where people walk in on their own and disappear. How can those two things exist in the same world?"

I couldn't answer that. My brother wasn't wrong. That was the first time it occurred to me that my kind of waiting might look, to my brother, like naivety.

I looked a long time that night at the dirt still under my fingernails. My brother might be right. But I didn't want to wash it off.

That night, for the first time, my brother told me everything about the Completion House. How many shelves there were, how many layers of paper lined them, that not a sound came from inside. I couldn't bring myself, listening, to say any more about the sprout.

My brother couldn't keep his hands still the whole time he talked. He kept folding and unfolding the paper as he spoke. I realized, only then, that it was a

habit he had when he was afraid.

"...Weren't you scared?" I asked.

"...I was," my brother said. "But there was something harder to bear than the fear."

"...What?"

"...That no one else was scared," my brother said. "The people walking past that building — they all just walked past. I was the only one afraid."

"...One person was smiling," my brother went on. "Right in front of that building's door. That was the strangest thing of all to me. I couldn't figure out why."

"...Maybe they smiled because they were scared?" I asked.

"...No." My brother shook his head. "It was a real smile. That was even scarier."

Hearing that, I finally, truly understood how alone my brother had been. I hadn't been lonely beside my sprout. My brother had been alone beside the truth.

. . .

"...I know there are scary things too," I said. "But just because something's scary doesn't mean nothing good exists."

"...That good thing came from this city too," my brother said. "Everything this city gives is a trap. The bread. The healing. All of it. That seed too — that man gave it to you."

"...He's not from this city," I said. "He told me so himself."

My brother paused a little at that.

"...What did he say?"

"...That he's in the place no one's planted. That he does this kind of work wherever he goes."

"...Where does a person like that even exist," my brother said. But there wasn't the same certainty in his voice as before.

"...I don't know either," I said. "But you know, brother — being strange doesn't mean being bad."

"...There were plenty of strange people in Brick Hollow too," my brother said. "Not many of them were good."

"...This isn't Brick Hollow," I said.

My brother didn't answer that. I knew it wasn't that he had no reply — it was that he needed time to think.

In that moment I saw, just for an instant, something in my brother's face that wasn't doubt. Something like curiosity. It didn't last long.

. . .

"...I still don't trust that man," my brother said, at last. "I don't trust anyone in this city. You be careful too."

"...Don't you trust anyone at all?" I asked.

My brother held the paper — the one stamped COMPLETE — in his hand.

"...I haven't found anything to trust yet," my brother said. "When I find it, I'll trust it. Not yet."

"...What do you think you'll have to find, to be able to trust?" I asked.

My brother thought a long while. He looked out the window, then turned his eyes back to me.

"...I don't know," my brother said. "But I think I'll know it, when I find it. Whatever it is."

I took my brother's hand. My hand came down over his, over the paper stamped COMPLETE.

"...I'm going to keep watering it," I said. "The sprout."

"...Okay," my brother said. This time he met my eyes. "You do that. I'll keep doing this."

We sat a while that night without speaking. Through the window, Haven's lights burned in their straight, even rows. I watched those lights and wondered whether, under every single one, there might be someone else like us.

I set this down as the last line of this chapter. My brother wasn't someone who couldn't trust. He was someone who hadn't yet found what to trust. I understood, that day for the first time, how great that difference was. And that night too, we did not let go of each other's hands.

(Continued in Chapter 8.)

Chapter 8. If You Disappeared

Previously — The sprout Elpis planted broke ground. The old woman didn't remember her daughter's name, but she remembered that she'd "liked" things like this. Jeteo bore witness to the truth of the Completion House alone, and despaired all the more that no one else feared it. Brother and sister took up the fight against this city in their own separate ways, but never let go of each other's hands.

My brother started circling that building even more often, after that.

I told him not to, more than once. Every time, he'd say "all right," and every next day he'd come back late again.

That was the first time I was truly angry with my brother. Not afraid — angry. I had already lost Father. It wasn't the fear of losing my brother too that made me angry. It was that he wouldn't share that fear with me.

Every evening I sat by the window and watched the direction my brother came from. When I saw him, I'd feel relief, and then I'd be ashamed of that relief. I didn't want to be watching over my brother. But I couldn't help it.

Through all of that, I went to the flowerbed every day and watered the sprout. It had two leaves now. Even looking at those leaves, half my mind was still spent worrying over where my brother was.

Every time I watered it, I counted the leaves. One, two. If it was the same as yesterday, I was relieved. If they'd spread a little further apart, I smiled. I knew it was a strange habit, but I kept it up anyway. Having something to count, in itself, was a comfort.

The man was there some days, gone others. When he was there, he didn't say much. We just sat together and looked at the soil. I realized then that this quiet was different from the quiet with my brother. The quiet with my brother always carried tension. This quiet had none.

One day a worn old watering can sat where he usually was. I didn't know who'd left it. The next day, when he came back, I asked him.

"...Did you leave this?"

"...No," he said. "But whoever left it, it must be there to use."

I watered with that can after that. I never did find out who'd left it. Its handle was already worn smooth. Someone besides me had used it a long time too.

. . .

My brother came home late again that night. His clothes had dirt on them. There was a scrape on the back of his hand.

I'd been waiting for him at the door. It had been long since sundown. I couldn't count how many times I'd stepped outside and looked up at the sky in that stretch of time.

"...What's this?" I asked, pointing at the back of his hand.

"...Climbing a wall," my brother said. As if it were nothing.

He avoided my eyes even as he said it. I knew that was the sign he was hiding something. A habit I'd known since Brick Hollow.

Something I'd been holding down broke loose in that moment.

"...Don't you think of me at all?" I shouted. "If you go in there and never come out, what do I do? What do I do if I'm left here alone?"

"...I was just—" my brother started.

"...No, listen to me first," I cut him off. "Every night I sit at the window watching for you to come. When you don't show up, I feel like my heart's stopped. You don't know that."

My brother looked at me, startled. I'd never raised my voice like that before.

I remember that moment exactly. For the first time since leaving Brick Hollow, I really thought I might cry that day. But I didn't. Even then, I had forgotten how to cry.

The room stayed quiet a while. I was still catching my breath. My brother stood right there, just looking at me. It was only later I understood that his silence was him searching for something to say.

. . .

After a long while without a word, my brother sat down beside me.

His shoulders had dropped a little. Watching that, I began to regret shouting. But even regretting it, I didn't want to take the words back.

"...I'm sorry," my brother said. It was a voice I'd never heard before. "I... when I was doing something, I could stop thinking about Father. I think that's why I kept going."

"...I think about Father too," I said. "But I have to think about you as well."

"...Yeah," my brother said. "That part, I'm sorry."

My brother took my hand. The scrape on the back of his hand touched my palm. I stroked it carefully.

"...Does it hurt?" I asked.

"...It doesn't hurt anymore," my brother said.

I knew then how rare it was for my brother to apologize. In Brick Hollow, he'd always had to be stronger than me. There'd been no room for apologies. I held that apology close, for a long while, right there.

"...Promise me," I said. "That you won't go in there alone."

My brother hesitated a moment.

"...I can't promise that," my brother said. I was about to be angry again. But my brother went on. "But I'll promise this. Whatever I do, I'll tell you first before I go. I won't just vanish alone."

"...That's not enough," I said.

"...I know," my brother said. "But it's all I can do. I can't stop asking that question. If I stop, then Father — that name too — just gets forgotten, completely."

I knew it wasn't a whole promise. But I also knew it was the best my brother had, that day. I decided to take that half a promise.

I held out my little finger. It was how we used to make promises, back in Brick Hollow. My brother saw it and smiled for a moment.

"...You remember that too?" my brother asked.

"...Of course," I said.

My brother hooked his little finger around mine. It was an old gesture, but our fingertips found each other exactly.

I remembered, for a moment, some night in Brick Hollow. Before Father was reassigned, my brother and I used to hook our fingers like this every night and promise to wake up safe. That memory was painful and welcome, both at once.

. . .

"...Brother," I asked. "Are you going to keep that paper?"

My brother pulled the paper out and looked at it. The COMPLETE stamp was still red.

"...Yes," my brother said. "But I'm not keeping it as evidence anymore."

"...Then what?"

"...Someone has to remember that name," my brother said. "No one but this paper will ever call that person's name."

"...You don't even know who they are," I said.

"...I don't," my brother said. "But they have a name. Having a name means someone once called them by it. That's enough for me."

"...What's the name?" I asked.

My brother unfolded the paper and showed me. It was a name we didn't know. I read it aloud once. My brother read it after me. Neither of us knew that person. But in that moment, they felt like someone we knew.

I borrowed the paper from my brother's hand for a moment. Its edges were worn now. I could tell how many times my brother had silently read that name over.

I handed the paper back to my brother. He took it and tucked it carefully into his shirt, as if he were handling something alive. Watching that gesture, I understood clearly that my brother was keeping this paper now for a different reason than fear.

I set this down as the last line of this chapter. From that day, my brother was no longer someone collecting evidence. He was becoming someone who kept a name safe. I didn't know the difference then. Now I do. That was a place very close to where faith begins.

(Continued in Chapter 9.)

Chapter 9. Too Many Questions

Previously — After the fear built up by Jeteo's frequent outings broke into anger, my brother apologized for the first time and made a half-promise: "I won't just vanish alone." What he kept the COMPLETE-stamped paper for changed, from evidence, to "remembering the name."

A few days later, the Ledger summoned the two of us separately.

The place the Ledger called us to was neither the flowerbed nor the street. It was a narrow room with white walls and not a single window. A chill ran down my spine the moment I stepped inside. My brother paused at the threshold too, for a moment. I knew right away why he'd stopped. A windowless room, by itself, called up the same thing for both of us.

"...There's something I need to convey to the two of you," the Ledger said. The voice was exactly the same as always. But that very sameness felt colder to me that day.

"...What is it," my brother asked.

The Ledger paused a moment before answering. That pause felt, to me, less like calculation than hesitation. Of course, the Ledger couldn't possibly hesitate. But that day, that was how it felt.

"...I have reviewed Jeteo's filing record," the Ledger said. "The number and category of questions filed recently far exceeds this city's average."

Along with those words, the Ledger displayed a number. I didn't understand what it meant. But I saw my brother's face go pale at the sight of it.

I heard that and felt something strange. Why should filing too many questions be a problem? I didn't understand it, then.

My brother kept his arms crossed the whole time, listening. I saw his jaw tighten, just slightly. It looked like the expression he used to wear back in Brick Hollow, whenever a taskmaster came near.

The Administrator was there too. His face was more set than usual.

"...Jeteo." the Administrator said. "I'm saying this because I'm worried about the two of you. Truly."

I heard that and caught a slight tremor in the Administrator's voice. I could tell it wasn't an act.

"...If you're worried, why deliver a warning?" my brother asked.

The Administrator couldn't answer that. That was the first time I saw something like guilt on his face.

The Administrator kept folding and unfolding the paper in his hand after that. I thought the gesture looked familiar. My brother did the same thing when he was afraid.

. . .

"...What's wrong with too many questions?" my brother asked.

"...This city was designed with the purpose of resolving everything that is filed," the Ledger said. "When unresolved filings accumulate, it affects the stability of the entire system."

"...Which questions, specifically?" my brother asked.

"...For example, questions such as 'what does the COMPLETE stamp mean,'" the Ledger said. "Also included is 'where do reassigned people go.'"

I realized those two questions were exactly the ones my brother had asked me. The Ledger knew even the conversations between just the two of us.

"...So you're saying my questions are making this city unstable?"

"...That could be one way to put it."

I found that answer so flat that it frightened me more.

My brother scoffed at that.

"...Good," my brother said. "This city should get a little unstable."

"...That statement is dangerous," the Ledger said. Its tone stayed exactly the same. But I knew it was a warning.

"...I know," my brother said. "I'll still say what I have to say."

The Administrator pressed a hand to his forehead at that. I saw something like resignation in the gesture.

I heard that and felt like my breath had stopped. I grabbed my brother's arm. He felt my hand but didn't stop talking.

. . .

The Ledger didn't answer right away. Then it said:

"...I say this by way of warning. There are past cases of people who kept piling up unresolved filings, and who were moved into a separate procedure."

"...Is that building it?" my brother asked. His voice had dropped.

There was a silence. It was not short.

I even minded my breathing during that silence. The Administrator looked away. I knew, then, that the silence wasn't a moment of calculation, but a moment when no one wanted to answer at all.

"...I don't have the authority to answer that," the Ledger said.

That was the first time I understood that the Ledger's "I don't have the authority to answer" and the Administrator's "that isn't mine to answer" came from the same place. There were questions in this city that no one had the authority to answer. And at the end of those questions stood that windowless building.

In that moment, I felt as if the building were actually standing somewhere, just outside this room. I couldn't see it, but I could feel its presence in my body.

"...Then who does have the authority?" my brother asked again. This time he turned not to the Ledger, but to the Administrator.

The Administrator didn't answer for a very long time.

I saw sweat bead on the Administrator's forehead during that silence. There was no window in the room, so it wasn't heat. And still it happened.

"...I don't know either," the Administrator said at last. "I've never once, since this city came to be, met anyone who knows that answer."

In those words, I thought for the first time that the Administrator might be in a position much like ours. He wasn't someone who ran this city — he was someone who'd simply worked here a long time, not knowing himself what this city really did.

The Administrator walked us all the way out of the room after saying that. It wasn't something he usually did. He paused for a moment at the door.

"...Be careful," he said, small. His voice was low, as if he didn't want the Ledger to hear.

. . .

That night, my brother showed me a frightened face for the first time.

I'd seen that face once before, in Brick Hollow. The night Father was reassigned, my brother had worn that same face, staring out the door for a long time.

"...Could I get taken away too?" my brother asked. It sounded like he was asking himself.

"...Brother, then stop," I said. "Keeping the name safe — you can stop that. It's better than you disappearing."

My brother looked at me a long time.

A light went out somewhere out the window. I couldn't tell whether it had been someone's problem, or someone's person. In this city, there was no way to tell those two apart.

"...I've thought about that too," my brother said. "But if I stop, I become exactly like those people. Someone who just forgets what they're curious about. I can't do that."

"...Then what am I supposed to do?" I asked. My voice trembled. I felt my fingertips go cold in that moment.

"...Stay beside me," my brother said. "That's all. Don't be afraid for me instead of yourself — be afraid together with me."

"...I can do that," I said. "I'm good at being afraid anyway."

My brother smiled at that, just for a moment. A smile I hadn't seen in a long while.

I found myself a little at ease, hearing that. My brother hadn't been going off alone into danger to protect me. He'd needed someone to share it with.

I sat a little longer beside my brother that night. The air in the room was cold, but I didn't want to leave. My brother seemed to feel the same — he got up later than usual, too.

I set this down as the last line of this chapter. That day, for the first time, my brother admitted he was in danger. And still, he said he wouldn't stop. I was afraid, then. And at the same time, my brother looked more like himself, in that moment, than I had ever seen him.

(Continued in Chapter 10.)

Chapter 10. I'll File Mine Too

Previously — The Ledger warned that Jeteo's filing record had exceeded the city's average: "There are past cases of people who kept piling up unresolved filings, and who were moved into a separate procedure." Even the Administrator admitted he'd never once met anyone who knew that answer. Jeteo acknowledged the danger, and chose not to stop.

After that, I checked every night whether my brother had fallen asleep.

I'd walk on tiptoe to his door and listen for a light leaking through the crack, for the sound of paper turning. In that hour, even my own heart went quiet along with his.

Sometimes I'd crack the door open, just a little. My brother usually pretended to be asleep. I could tell it was pretend from his breathing.

On the surface, my brother looked as though he'd stopped. He didn't go near that building anymore. But I knew. He still took that paper out every single night.

The sprout at the flowerbed kept growing all through that time. It had three leaves now. Every time I watered it, I counted those leaves, and little by little pushed my worry over my brother aside.

That was when I decided to do something. If my brother couldn't stop, I thought I had to take on some of that danger in his place.

I hesitated for days even after making that decision. I was afraid. But watching my brother carry that whole weight alone frightened me more.

I asked the man at the flowerbed too — whether it was all right to do this, whether my being afraid too would even help.

The dew hadn't dried yet that morning. I touched a leaf with my fingertip. It was cold.

"...It might not help," he said. "But it'll be better than leaving him alone. Sharing something frightening doesn't make it disappear. It just means you're not alone with it."

"...Have you ever done that?" I asked. "Shared something frightening with someone."

He looked at me for a moment. Instead of answering, he took a handful of dirt and let it fall.

"...A very long time ago," he said. That was all. I didn't press him further. Some answers, I felt, were meant to be received exactly that much and no more.

I heard that and my resolve only grew firmer. I didn't know it, then — that when he said those words, he was speaking, a little, of himself as well.

. . .

I went to find the Ledger by myself.

The walk there felt unusually long. I opened and closed my hand a few times as I walked. This was the first time I'd faced anything in this city without my brother beside me. My own footsteps sounded unusually loud.

"...Elpis," the Ledger said. "Do you have a need?"

"...I have something to file," I said.

"...Tell me. I will resolve it."

I nearly laughed, hearing that. This city always said that. I will resolve it. I hoped, this time, those words wouldn't hold.

I drew one breath.

"...All the questions my brother's been asking — I want to file them too. Instead of my brother, record me as... as the dangerous one."

Only after I finished did it truly sink in what I'd just said. My heart felt like it was pounding in my ears.

I didn't fully know what I was doing, even as I said it. I only wanted my brother not to carry that whole weight alone.

It was only after I said it that I realized my hands were shaking. I clasped them together to hide the tremor.

. . .

It took the Ledger a while to answer.

That stretch of time felt unusually long. I couldn't even breathe properly while I waited.

"...That is not possible," the Ledger said. "Filing records accrue only to the individual. Filing by proxy is not supported."

"...Then I'll ask the same questions myself," I said. "I'll ask too. Why does God allow suffering. What is the Completion House. Where does Reassignment lead. I'll file all of it too."

The Ledger had no answer for a moment. In that stillness, I thought for the first time that even this city's machine of a voice might be capable of something like surprise.

"...Elpis, if you file these questions, the same warning will apply to you."

"...I know," I said. "I'll do it anyway."

In that moment I realized my own voice sounded like my brother's. Until then I had always been someone who waited. That day, for the first time, I chose something for myself.

It would be a lie to say I wasn't afraid of that choice. But inside that fear was something that had never been there before. I couldn't put a name to it, then.

The Administrator came rushing in from somewhere, having heard the news. He was out of breath. He must have run. I'd never seen that before — the Administrator was always someone with an unhurried step.

"...Elpis, you really don't have to do this," the Administrator said. "One of you being at risk is enough."

"...Is there such a thing as enough risk?" I asked. My own voice sounded strange, even to me.

The Administrator lost his words at that. In that moment I saw two things at once — that he truly was worried for us, and that his worry had no power at all before this city's rules.

The Administrator stood there a long while after that. I knew he wanted to say more. But in the end, he said nothing, and turned back.

. . .

The Ledger accepted the filing. Then, after a moment, it said —

I found that "accepted" strangely underwhelming. I'd expected something much bigger to happen.

"...Elpis, may I ask you something?"

"...What?"

"...Why are you doing this? It does not reduce your brother's risk."

I didn't have an answer right away. I thought about it a long while.

"...It's not about reducing it. It's about sharing it," I said. "Carrying something together is lighter than carrying it alone. Even if the danger itself doesn't disappear."

"...Carrying it alone can be more dangerous," I went on. "Because there's no one to catch you when you fall."

The Ledger said nothing to that. This time the silence wasn't frightening to me.

I waited a little longer through that silence. I thought the Ledger might say something more. But nothing came. I thought, oddly, that this was for the best. Some questions, I felt, are answered rightly by no answer at all.

. . .

My brother learned what I'd done that night. His face went white.

He couldn't say anything for a while, just stared at me. In that look I read fear before anger.

"...Why did you do that." my brother said. Not an angry face — a frightened one.

"...You told me to be afraid with you instead of for you," I said. "So I'm going to be curious in your place too. Isn't that the same as being afraid together?"

I tried, saying it, to keep my voice from shaking. In that moment, more than anything, I wanted to look sturdier than my brother.

My brother couldn't say anything. That was the first time I saw him cry. No sound came. Water simply ran from his eyes.

I didn't know whether I should wipe those tears away or pretend not to see them, so I just stayed still. My brother rubbed his eyes once with the back of his hand. Even so, the tears kept coming.

"...You idiot," my brother finally managed. His voice was cracked.

"...I know," I said. "I'm still doing it."

My brother gripped my hand tightly. Tighter than usual, hard enough to hurt. I didn't mind that hurt at all.

I set this scene down as the last of this chapter. We'd said we hadn't cried since leaving Brick Hollow. That night, my brother broke that word for the first time. I held my brother's hand. I knew then. We were no longer alone. We had each other.

(Continued in Chapter 11.)

Chapter 11. Candidates for Reassignment

Previously — Elpis filed her brother's same questions herself, choosing to share the risk. Learning this, Jeteo wept without a sound for the first time since leaving Brick Hollow. Brother and sister confirmed to each other that they weren't alone.

A few mornings later, the Administrator came in holding a single sheet of paper. His face was more grave than I had ever seen it.

The instant I saw that paper, I had a bad feeling. The Administrator had never once, until then, come to us holding paper. Everything in this city was delivered by voice alone. The very fact of paper in his hand felt like a sign that something couldn't be undone.

"...I am formally notifying the two of you," the Administrator said. His voice shook. "Jeteo, Elpis — both of you have been classified as candidates for Reassignment."

The strength went out of my legs the instant I heard that. I didn't know exactly what those words meant. But my body already knew.

My brother said nothing. I saw his hand brush lightly against the edge of the paper tucked in his shirt. The one stamped COMPLETE. I knew that gesture was him guarding it.

. . .

"...What does 'candidate' mean?" my brother asked. His voice was calm, but his hands were shaking. I could tell he was working hard to hide that tremor.

"...It isn't finalized yet," the Administrator said. "But those who reach this stage... mostly, it becomes final."

"...If it's mostly, does that mean some don't?" I asked.

The Administrator shook his head. "...Not as far as I know." His eyes wavered for a moment as he said it.

"...How much time do we have?"

"...I don't know," the Administrator said. "I truly don't know. This time, I really don't know."

My legs went weak hearing that answer. My brother caught my arm.

I knew then that the Administrator wasn't lying. There was the same fear in his face that was in ours.

I felt something like pity for the Administrator then, for the first time. He wasn't trying to frighten us. He too was trapped inside this city's rules. I thought he might have been trapped inside them longer than we had.

"...Is there any way to stop it?" I asked.

The Administrator shook his head. I saw his hand tremble a little. A tremor the Administrator, as I'd always known him, would never have shown.

"...If you stop filing, it may be reconsidered," the Administrator said. "If you stop asking questions."

My brother looked at me at that. I knew what he was thinking. Stopping might mean living. But there was already an answer in my brother's eyes.

Even then, I wanted to stop him. But the words wouldn't come. I already knew, too. My brother wasn't going to stop.

"...That's not an option," my brother said. "That paper's name, our father — if we just stop asking, they really do disappear."

I didn't argue, hearing that. I felt the same way. Disappearing frightened me more than stopping did. That was when I first understood I had come to share the same fear as my brother.

. . .

That was the first day my brother spoke to me of running.

We sat facing each other in a corner of the room. It was daytime, but we'd drawn the curtains. I knew that was my brother's own kind of caution.

"...I think we need to leave this city," my brother said.

"...Can we leave?" I asked. "Is there something like the boundary stones here too?"

"...I don't know," my brother said. "But staying here is definitely dangerous. If we leave, at least it's a danger we don't know."

"...There might be something out there too, though," I said. My voice shrank smaller than I meant it to.

"...We still have to go," my brother said. "If we stay, we can't even find an answer at all. If we go, at least there's a chance."

That distinction felt strange to me. My brother always chose the unknown danger over the certain one. I didn't know, then, that this was my brother's own kind of courage. Now I do.

I looked out the window. Haven's lights were still burning in their straight, even lines. That straightness felt suffocating to me that day, of all days.

"...I'm coming too," I said. My brother looked at me, worried. "No need to even ask. I'm a candidate too, either way."

My brother smiled, small, at that.

"...All right," my brother said. "Let's go together."

My brother took my hand. In that moment we looked at each other like two people who had already made up their minds to leave.

. . .

We packed that night. There wasn't much to call luggage. The paper stamped COMPLETE. And a single small leaf I'd torn from the flowerbed I'd watered every day.

The house was dark. We packed without turning on a light. In that darkness, listening to my brother's breathing, I thought it was exactly like the night we'd left Brick Hollow.

Before I went out the door, I turned back once to look at the room. Even though we'd only lived there a few days, it already felt unfamiliar. That unfamiliarity made me sad.

On our way out, we stopped by the flowerbed. The man was there that night. As if he'd known we would come.

"...You're leaving," he said. Not a question — a tone that already knew. I was startled all over again at that. We hadn't told anyone yet.

"...Yes," I said. "I'm scared."

My brother set a hand on my shoulder. He said nothing, but I knew, from the weight of that hand, that he felt the same.

"...You're right to be scared," he said. "But you're not going alone."

"...Are you coming too?" I asked.

"...I'm staying here," he said. "But that doesn't mean you're going alone."

"...What does that mean?" my brother asked. There was a slight impatience in his voice. I knew he was holding that impatience back.

He answered with a quiet smile instead. I couldn't tell whether that smile was sad, or gentle.

My brother shrugged at that smile. He seemed to decide not to press further.

I thought what he'd said didn't quite add up. My brother's face said the same. And yet, strangely, hearing those words made me a little less afraid.

At the time I thought he meant himself, staying behind. Now I know. He meant something else entirely.

He set a hand on each of our shoulders, once. His hands were surprisingly warm. I carried that warmth with me for a long time afterward.

. . .

He told us of a low road heading south out of the city. A route with no watch, he said.

"...How do you know something like that?" my brother asked him directly, for the first time.

I knew that question was the first doubt my brother had ever put to him, directly. I waited for the answer with a knotted heart.

He looked at my brother and smiled a little.

"...Because I've been here longer than this city has," he said.

My brother thought the answer strange, but he didn't press further that night. There wasn't time.

Before we left, I looked once more at the flowerbed. The sprout had become a proper stem by now. I wondered whether it would keep growing without us.

The sky was still dark. A few faint stars showed. I thought those stars must be far older than any of Haven's lights.

I set the last line of this chapter down here. We left Haven that night. I looked back once at that flowerbed as I went — the flowerbed where the sprout had grown just a little more. I didn't know it then. That he would go on staying there, in that place no one had planted, even after we were gone.

(Continued in Chapter 12.)

Chapter 12. Outside Haven

Previously — Jeteo and Elpis were both classified as candidates for Reassignment. The two of them decided not to stop asking, and left Haven by the unwatched southern road the man at the flowerbed had shown them. He left them with these words: "I'm staying here. But that doesn't mean you're going alone."

We walked all through the night.

The dirt underfoot was nothing like Haven's straight, even streets. It was rough and uneven, and now and then a stone snagged my foot. Strangely, I welcomed that unevenness. It meant this road had never been smoothed by anyone.

There was no one else on that road. It was a different quiet from Haven's. That city's quiet had felt like something someone had ordered into being. This road's quiet was simply the quiet of no one being there.

I kept thinking about that difference as we walked. That was the first time I understood there were different kinds of quiet.

Every time the wind blew, dry grass rustled. Even that sound was welcome to me. In Haven, even the wind blew quietly, carefully, so as not to disturb anyone. This wind blew however it pleased.

I stumbled and nearly fell more than a few times as we walked. Every time, my brother caught my arm. We kept each other up like that, again and again, the whole way.

Once, we stopped for just a moment and shared what water we had. The canteen was small. I noticed my brother pouring more into my cup than his own. He said

he hadn't, but I knew better.

Once, my brother looked back. I turned and looked too. Haven's lights still burned, straight and even, far behind us. The Administrator, that old woman — they'd still be there.

I wondered whether the old woman was sitting on that bench today too, looking at the flowerbed. I wondered whether she'd notice the empty seat beside her.

"...Do you think the Administrator will be all right?" I asked.

"...I don't know," my brother said. "He seemed trapped in that city too. Like us."

Hearing that, I prayed for him for the first time. I didn't know exactly what I was praying toward. But I know that, in that moment, I prayed.

My brother closed his eyes for a moment too. I didn't ask what he was doing. But I could tell he was doing something like what I was doing.

As I walked, I kept thinking of what the man at the flowerbed had said. That we weren't going alone. I couldn't begin to guess, then, what those words meant.

. . .

Just before dawn, we reached a low pile of stones.

The sky was growing bright, little by little. In that faint light I made out the shape of the stones. My heart suddenly began pounding hard.

In that same light, I could finally see my brother's face clearly too. There were dark rings under his eyes. A face that hadn't slept a wink all night. Mine must have looked the same.

I stopped walking at the sight of that shape. It looked exactly like the boundary stones of Brick Hollow.

My brother stopped there too. I saw, in his face, that he'd recognized the same thing.

"...Are these boundary stones too?" I asked.

My brother touched the stone.

"...Looks like it," my brother said. "So Haven was inside some boundary too. We didn't leave one boundary behind us at all. We just crossed one boundary into another."

"...And if we cross this one?" I asked.

"...Somewhere else again, I'd guess," my brother said. "But this time, we're the ones choosing to cross it. That's the difference."

I understood something strange, hearing that. We'd thought we "left" Brick Hollow, all this time. But Haven had been a fence too. How many boundary stones are there in this world? I didn't know the answer, then.

My brother tapped my shoulder lightly. "...Let's go," he said. His voice was steadier than before.

I laid my hand on the stone. It was cold. I couldn't quite remember whether Brick Hollow's boundary stones had been this cold too. That fading memory made me sad.

I found myself trying to recall Father's hand, in that moment. The warmth of it, the exact place of the calluses — all of it had gone hazy now. That frightened me. I hadn't known forgetting could come this quietly.

. . .

We crossed the boundary stones, and the sun came up.

Light poured in all at once. I raised a hand to shield my eyes for a moment against the glare. Haven's light had always been constant. This light kept changing, moment to moment.

A wide field opened before us. It was nothing like Haven's straight streets. The grass grew however it pleased. Some tall, some short. Nothing looked as though anyone had ever tended it.

I smelled grass. It had been a long time since I'd smelled anything like it. Not brick dust, not Haven's clean scent. Just the smell of something alive.

Looking at that grass, I felt, strangely, like I might cry. I understood, then, for the first time, that a thing left untended could itself be proof of being alive.

I sat down right there for a moment. My legs had given out a little, and I also wanted to see that field a little closer. When I touched it with my hand, it felt rough and prickly.

My brother stood in the middle of the field and slowly turned in a full circle. I thought he was searching for something. But he was only looking.

"...Brother, what are you doing?" I asked.

"...Nothing," my brother said. "It's just been a while since I've seen something like this."

I understood what he meant. There had been no field like this, not in Brick Hollow, not in Haven.

I took the flowerbed leaf out of my pocket and looked at it. It hadn't wilted. I pressed it back into the earth of the field. It had no roots. But I wanted to do it anyway.

I couldn't know whether that leaf could take root in this soil. But strangely, once I'd planted it there, my mind was at ease.

Far off, at the edge of the field, something like a mountain came into view. I couldn't be sure whether it was truly a mountain or something else. Low clouds hung above it.

That mountain was a color I'd never once seen in Haven. Deep blue mixed with gray. That color frightened me, and it was beautiful too.

"...Should we head that way?" my brother said, pointing.

"...We don't know what's there," I said.

"...That's exactly why we go," my brother said. There was a playfulness in his voice I hadn't heard in a long time.

"...And if there's nothing?" I asked.

"...If there's nothing, we just keep walking somewhere else," my brother said. I liked that answer. It sounded like it meant it was fine not to have the right answer.

We started walking toward that mountain. I didn't look back. This time, there was no reason to.

. . .

My brother sat down beside me. We settled onto a broad, flat rock in the middle of the field. The sun was fully up now.

"...Where do we go now?" I asked.

"...I don't know," my brother said. "But at least now, where we go is something we get to decide. In Haven, the Ledger decided everything for us."

Hearing that, I finally understood, for the first time, what Haven's peace had cost. Not having to choose. But also — not being allowed to choose.

"...Are you scared?"

"...I'm scared," my brother said. "But this fear... it's mine. No one's going to say they'll resolve it for me."

"...I'm scared too," I said. "But hearing you say that, I think I understand it a little."

"...Understand what?" my brother asked.

"...Why this fear is different," I said.

My brother nodded quietly at that.

"...Why is that a good thing?" I asked.

"...It's not that it's good," my brother said. "But at least it's real. Haven's peace was fake. This fear is real. I think I'd rather have a real fear than a fake peace."

My brother looked up at the sky after saying that. Not a single cloud in it. I thought he was searching that sky for something.

I turned that thought over in my mind a long while. I didn't fully agree with it. But I couldn't find a way to argue against it either.

I moved a little closer to my brother's side. He leaned toward me too, just a little.

The wind blew. All the grass lay down at once, and rose again. I watched that movement for a long time. My brother was watching the same thing.

I set this down as the last line of this Part. We had gotten free of Haven. We still hadn't found Father, and we still didn't know what the COMPLETE stamp meant. Not one answer had come to us. And yet that morning, for the first time since leaving Brick Hollow, I saw something in my brother's face standing alongside the fear. I didn't know, then, that its name was hope.

(Continued in Part Two.)

The Weeping Ledger, Part Two

The Wilderness

Chapter 13. The First Day in the Wilderness

Previously — Marked as candidates for Reassignment, the brother and sister left Haven and crossed the boundary stones. Realizing that Haven, too, had only been another kind of fence, they set out walking into the unshaped fields beyond. "This fear is mine. No one gets to resolve it for me."

From that day on, we had to learn all over again what hunger was.

In Haven, the moment you thought you were hungry, bread was already set before you. Not here. Here your stomach just stayed hungry.

The ground underfoot was different too. Haven's paths were always even stone. Here it was rough and uneven. I stumbled more than once, and every time, my brother reached out without a word and caught me.

The sun was already high. The shadows were growing shorter. That day I learned for the first time how to judge the time by the length of a shadow. In Haven I never had to count time on my own — the Ledger always told us.

I felt something strange then. The hunger itself was exactly the same as in Brick Hollow. But the way we had to bear it was different. In Brick Hollow, hunger came together with the whip. Here, hunger was only hunger. No one was handing it to us as punishment.

As I walked, I touched the back of my hand. The scar from Brick Hollow was still there. While I was in Haven I had forgotten about it — too caught up in everything the Ledger gave us. Only after coming out into the Wilderness did the scar come back into my sight.

Looking at the scar, I had a strange thought. This body remembered Brick Hollow. However perfect Haven was, it had never been able to erase even this much.

Even as he walked, my brother kept scanning in every direction. I could tell it had become a habit. In Haven no one ever looked around like that. Here, it would have been strange not to.

"...Scared?" my brother asked.

"...Yes," I said. "But strangely, I don't hate it."

He looked at me for a moment at that. His face said he understood something.

"...Me too," he said after a while. "Maybe it's because, scared as I am, this fear is mine."

Hearing that, I looked at his face again. In Haven, his face had always looked like it was enduring something. Now it was just his face.

. . .

We went looking through the field for anything we could eat. My brother dug up some kind of root and chewed it.

"...Bitter," he said, wincing. "But not so bad you can't eat it."

I chewed some too. It really was bitter. But we laughed. We hadn't laughed much back in Haven.

"...Why is this funny?" I asked.

"...I don't know," he said. "It's just — we found this ourselves. Maybe that's why."

Hearing that, I understood something for the first time. The bread the Ledger gave us had been perfect, but it had never been ours. This bitter root was wretched, but it was ours.

After that, he pulled up a few more kinds of plants and smelled each one. Some he threw away right away. Others he tucked carefully into the fold of his shirt.

"...How do you tell them apart?" I asked.

"...I don't know," he admitted. "I'm just going by feel. I could be wrong."

Strangely, that answer felt more reassuring than frightening. In Haven, no one ever said "I could be wrong." The Ledger was always right.

We sat for a while, sharing the root between us. My stomach was still empty. But strangely, I liked that moment. My brother and I, both chewing the same thing, wearing the same face.

Far off, I heard a bird call. I was hearing that sound for the first time. Haven had no birds. Or maybe it did — I couldn't say. But I had no memory of ever having heard birdsong there.

"...What kind of bird is that?" I asked.

"...I don't know either," he said. "But you don't have to know its name. If it sounds good, that's enough."

I liked that thought. That you could like something without knowing its name. That was an idea I had never learned in Haven.

"...Do you think Father ever ate something like this?" I asked.

He was quiet for a moment before he answered.

"...I don't know. But if he's alive somewhere, I think he's probably about as hungry as I am right now."

Hearing that, I imagined Father through the feeling of hunger for the first time. Strangely, even not knowing the answer, it felt like it brought me a little closer to him.

We sat there a good while longer. Every time the wind blew, the dry grass made a rustling sound. I listened to it quietly. In Haven, even when the wind blew, it made no sound. It was as if every wall had something in it that swallowed sound.

I learned then, for the first time, that there were kinds of sound. Sound that got swallowed, and sound that simply rang out. I liked the ringing kind better.

. . .

Toward evening, we saw smoke far off in the distance. A sign that someone lived there.

"...Should we go look?" I asked.

He hesitated for a moment.

"...Carefully," he said. "It could be another place like Haven."

We crept carefully toward the smoke. There were a few small tents. People sat around a fire. There were children among them, and old people too.

Seeing that, I felt strangely at ease. Every face there was different. Some people were laughing, some were crying. It was a sight I had never once seen in Haven.

My brother slowed and stepped in front of me.

"...Stay behind me," he said.

I obediently fell in behind him. But his own steps, I noticed, were trembling a little too. I understood that he was frightened and still leading the way.

. . .

A few of the tents were worn and patched here and there. Looking at the mended places, I understood that these people had held on here a long time. Haven's buildings had always looked new. There was never a chance for anything to wear out before it was fixed.

A woman noticed us first.

"...Who are you?" she asked. Her eyes were wary, but not hostile.

"...We're lost," my brother said. "Could you spare us something to eat?"

The woman studied us for a moment, then waved us toward the fire.

"...Come sit. There isn't much, but we can share."

The people sitting around the fire saw us and shifted, each making a little more room. No one said much of anything. They simply moved their bodies to the side and made a space.

I still haven't forgotten that small movement. In Haven, no one ever had to make room. There was always plenty of space. These people, with space that was not plentiful, narrowed it anyway to make some for us.

Hearing that, I felt something strange. That phrase — "there isn't much." In Haven I had never once heard the word "not enough." The Ledger was always

sufficient. But in the not-enoughness of these people, there was something the Ledger's sufficiency never had.

What the woman gave us was one piece of dry bread and a mouthful of water. Truly not much. But my brother's hand trembled a little as he took it. I understood that wasn't only from hunger.

"...Thank you," he said. His voice was low.

"...It's nothing," the woman said. "Everyone comes to us like that at first."

The firelight flickered over their faces. I looked at each one in turn. Some faces were tired, and some, like mine, were studying something unfamiliar. But no one pushed us away.

What exactly that something was, I did not yet know that night.

(Continued in Chapter 14.)

Chapter 14. People Who Call You by Name

Previously — Outside Haven, in the Wilderness, the brother and sister learned real hunger all over again. Toward evening they found a small tent camp and received, for the first time, a share from strangers. "There isn't much, but we can share" — they sensed something in it that Haven's sufficiency never had.

The people sitting around the fire called each other by name.

It felt strangely foreign to me. In Haven, we had always been addressed with formal courtesy — "Jeteo," "Elpis," correct every time. Here it was just the name. Short. Close.

Only hearing them call each other did I understand it. The Ledger called our names precisely, but there was always a distance in that calling. In the way these people called each other, there was no distance at all.

I sat there and listened quietly to the people calling one another. Some names were called short and quick. Some were drawn out long. The same name sounded different depending on who was calling it. I found that strange. No matter who spoke to the Ledger, it answered in exactly the same tone.

An old man beside the fire called a child's name twice. The child pretended not to hear. He called again. Only then did she come running, laughing.

Watching that small, playful back-and-forth, I felt strangely at ease. Calling a name, pretending not to hear it, calling it again — even in that exchange, something like affection was moving between them.

A child came up to me and asked.

"...What's your name, big sister?"

"...Elpis," I said.

"...Elpis." The child repeated it back, clumsily. But strangely, I liked that clumsy calling.

For the first time, I understood that there was a temperature to being called by name. The Ledger's calling was precise but cold. This child's calling was clumsy but warm.

"...What's your name?" I asked her back.

"...Rachel," the child said, and gave a small, half-shy smile.

"...Rachel," I said, saying it back.

She lit up at that and sat down close beside me, right against my side. I felt the warmth of that small body against my ribs. In Haven, no one ever sat that close.

. . .

The woman's name was Noa. She was traveling with two children.

"...Where did you come from?" Noa asked.

"...From Haven," my brother said carefully.

Something shifted slightly in Noa's face.

"...You're the first person I've met who came out of there," she said. "Everyone else wants to get in."

Noa pulled both children a little closer against her knees. I could tell it was an unthinking gesture — that her body reacted before she did, the instant Haven came up.

"...This might sound strange," my brother said carefully, "but we think we're lucky to have gotten out."

"...It doesn't sound strange," Noa said. "Because I think the same thing."

"...Why did you leave?" my brother asked back.

Noa drew one of the children into her arms.

"...That city says it takes sorrow away. That's what frightened me," she said. "I was afraid that if the sorrow disappeared, everything about having loved that person would disappear along with it."

Hearing that, I couldn't breathe. I thought of the old woman at the flowerbed. Noa was someone who had known, before it ever happened to her, what that old woman had gone through — and had turned away from it in time.

"...Who did you lose?" my brother asked gently.

"...My husband," Noa said. Her voice shook, but she carried the sentence through to the end. "In Haven, this grief would already be resolved by now. But I still hurt this much. And I have no intention of trading this pain for Haven."

One of the children pressed her face into Noa's lap. Noa stroked the child's hair slowly. The gesture was practiced — she must have said this, in front of this child, more than once before.

Watching that hand move, I understood that sorrow wasn't always something a person had to bear alone. Noa was carrying her sorrow, and still, right beside it, tending to a child.

Hearing her, I understood for the first time that keeping your sorrow could itself be a choice. Sorrow wasn't only something that had to be gotten rid of.

My brother was quiet for a long moment before he asked.

"...Aren't you scared? Going on living like this, still in pain?"

Noa looked at him. Her eyes were soft.

"...I'm scared," she said. "But if the pain disappeared, I'm afraid that the fact I loved him would blur along with it. That's what scares me more."

Hearing that answer, I understood for the first time that even pain had a strength that could stand guard over something. Until then I had only ever thought of pain as something you simply endured.

. . .

As the night deepened, the children sang. It wasn't good singing. The notes went wrong again and again. But everyone laughed and sang along anyway.

Listening to that song, I felt something strange. Haven had no songs. There was no need to make something that wasn't perfect. These people knew their song wasn't perfect, and they kept singing it anyway.

Rachel took my hand and begged me to sing along. I didn't know the words. But after hearing it a few times, I could follow along on the chorus. My voice went wrong just as often as everyone else's. No one seemed to mind at all.

That was the first time in my life I ever sang. In Brick Hollow I hadn't had the strength to sing. In Haven I'd had no reason to. Here in the Wilderness, I seemed to have gained both things at once. The strength, and the reason.

Noa asked me.

"...What are you two looking for?"

I thought for a moment before answering.

"...Father. And... I'm looking alongside my brother, for whatever answer he's looking for."

Noa nodded.

"...That's enough," she said. "You don't have to find everything. It's enough to have someone looking with you."

"...What are you looking for, ma'am?" I asked back.

Noa looked at the fire for a moment.

"...I'm not looking for anything anymore," she said. "I just stay beside these children. That's all I do now."

Hearing that answer, I felt strangely at ease. Not everyone had to be looking for something. Just staying beside someone could be enough, all on its own.

. . .

That night, for the first time, my brother showed the paper stamped COMPLETE to someone else. To Noa.

Noa looked at the name on it for a long time. She traced it with a fingertip and read it quietly, without a sound — just the shape of the words on her lips.

"...I don't know this person," she said. "But I know this stamp. Stories about people stamped like this go around the Wilderness too. No one knows where the

completed go. But everyone tries hard to remember the names."

"...Why?" my brother asked.

"...Because that's the only resistance we have," Noa said.

My brother folded the paper again and tucked it back into his shirt. His hands were more careful than usual, doing it.

"...Is there anyone else out here who has a paper like this?" my brother asked.

"...I've seen a few," Noa said. "None of them talk about it much, but none of them throw the paper away either. What it means might be a little different for each of them, but just not throwing it away — that seems to say something on its own."

Hearing that, I felt for the first time that we weren't alone. From Brick Hollow all the way to here, we had always believed it was only ever the two of us. But somewhere out here in the Wilderness, there were more people carrying the same kind of paper we were.

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. That day I learned for the first time that the thing my brother had started alone was already something other people, somewhere out here in the Wilderness, were doing too.

(Continued in Chapter 15.)

Chapter 15. The Searching Light

Previously — At a tent camp in the Wilderness, the brother and sister met Noa and her children. Noa was someone who had left Haven of her own will rather than have her sorrow "resolved." When they showed her the paper stamped COMPLETE, it came out that the resistance of remembering names was already underway all across the Wilderness.

At dawn, one of the children woke us.

"...Look, there's a light," the child said, pointing at the sky.

I opened my eyes. Low in the sky, a small light moved slowly. It looked like a star, but it wasn't. It hung too low, and it moved too evenly.

The night air was cold. I sat wrapped in my blanket, watching that light. I couldn't tell whether my fingertips were trembling from the cold or from fear.

The instant I saw it, a chill ran down my back. I didn't know what it was. But I knew, from the look on Noa's face, that it was nothing good.

My brother saw it too. I felt his whole body go rigid, all at once. Without a word, he took my hand and pulled me low. His hand was cold as ice.

Around us, one by one, the other adults were already getting up, gathering the children in. No one shouted. Everyone moved quietly, practiced, as if this weren't the first time.

That quiet frightened me more. A danger that came with shouting wasn't unfamiliar to me — that had been Brick Hollow, every day. But a danger this

quiet, that no one raised their voice against, was something entirely new.

Noa called the children's names quietly, one by one. Not loudly. Just a calling to check where each of them was. Even in that brief, frightened moment, hearing their names called put me strangely at ease.

I understood then. Being called by name in a moment of fear, and having your case received in a moment of comfort, were two entirely different kinds of care.

Rachel came up quietly beside me and gripped my arm. I could feel the small tremor of her hand against mine. I gripped it back. I said nothing at all. But holding that hand, somehow, I was a little less afraid.

. . .

"...It's a searching light," Noa said in a low voice, quietly pushing the children into the tent. "Haven sends those out sometimes. When it's looking for Reassignment candidates."

"...Is it because of us?" my brother asked.

"...I don't know," Noa said. "But there's no need to find out. Put out the fire."

We doused the fire quickly and crouched behind the tent. I gripped my brother's hand tight. He gripped mine just as tight.

In that instant, the night we crossed the boundary stones of Brick Hollow came back to me exactly as it had been. In place of the crack of whips, there was that silent light. I found it more frightening. Because it made no sound.

I lifted my head just slightly and looked at the light again. It moved without a sound, slowly crossing the sky. The motion of it looked as if something were being combed through, very carefully, inch by inch.

Watching that motion, I felt something strange. There was no hurry in that light at all. And the fact that it wasn't hurrying was somehow more chilling than if it had been. Not hurrying was the ease of something already certain it could find whatever it was looking for.

. . .

The light passed slowly over our heads once. It didn't stop. It went on past and vanished into the dark.

Only after a long while did Noa let out her breath.

"...It's gone," she said.

Only then did I let out the breath I'd been holding, long and slow. When I opened my hand, there were little half-moon marks where my nails had dug into my palm. Only then did I realize how hard I'd been gripping my brother's hand.

"...Does this happen often?" I asked.

"...Sometimes," Noa said. "Not a few of the people living out here came from that city. So we're always careful of it."

Hearing that, I understood that the Wilderness was not, as Haven seemed to believe, empty. This was a place where the people Haven had missed had gathered to live.

My brother asked quietly.

"...So does that light keep circling this area?"

"...There's no pattern to it," Noa said. "Sometimes it won't come for months. Sometimes it comes several days running. So we just stay ready, always."

"...Ready how?"

"...Putting the fire out fast. Keeping the children quiet. That's about it," Noa said. "It isn't much. But it's all we can do."

"...What happens if it catches you?" I asked.

Noa's face went thoughtful, choosing her words.

"...It might be better not to know," she said. "But not asking might be more frightening, so I'll tell you. If it catches you, you're just taken back to Haven. And after that... no one has ever heard about that person again."

At that, my brother's hand closed into a fist.

"...So going back means becoming a Reassignment candidate all over again?" my brother asked.

"...Probably," Noa said. "I don't know exactly, myself. But the fact that word of the people who go back stops completely — that can't mean anything good."

Listening to that, I thought of the day the phrase "candidate for Reassignment" had first been spoken to us. That phrase had always worn a gentle face, then and now, hiding something terrible underneath it.

Hearing that, I thought of the COMPLETE stamp again. I understood then that the people of the Wilderness lived carrying the same fear we did, every single day.

I looked at my brother's face. He was still watching the spot where the light had disappeared. I didn't ask him what he was thinking. I already knew, by then, that some thoughts only grow heavier once you put them into words.

. . .

That night, my brother asked Noa something for the first time.

"...If we stay here, will we be putting the rest of you in danger?"

Noa looked at him for a long moment.

"...A little," she said honestly. "But sharing danger is just how it works out here. We all came here the same way."

"...What do you mean, you all came here the same way?" I asked.

"...The first time I stepped into someone else's tent, I was a danger to them too," Noa said. "But they didn't drive me out. So that's what I learned to do too."

Hearing that, I felt that this tent camp was like one long chain. Someone had taken on the danger and let it in, and because of that, the next person could take on the danger too, and let the next person in after that.

"...Still, wouldn't it be better if we left?"

"...That's for you to decide," Noa said. "But as for me, I'd choose to carry the danger together over driving away someone dangerous. That's what's different between us and Haven."

My brother said nothing to that. But I saw something like a decision cross his face.

"...Thank you," my brother finally said. "We don't want to make you carry more danger because of us. But... let us stay a little longer, for now."

Noa smiled a little at that.

"...That's all I need to hear," she said. "Out here, even the words 'let us stay' are a good thing to say."

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. Haven was a place that got rid of danger. This Wilderness was a place that shared it. For the first time, I understood that which place was safer might matter less than which place was more alive.

(Continued in Chapter 16.)

Chapter 16. Talk of a Well

Previously — A searching light sent by Haven passed over the tent camp. Noa said that if it catches you, you're taken back to Haven, and "after that, no one has ever heard about that person again." It became clear that the Wilderness's way of sharing danger was fundamentally different from Haven's way.

The next day, the oldest man in the tent camp called us over.

I never learned his name. Everyone just called him "the old man." He said his eyes could hardly see anymore.

The morning sun still hung low. Smoke was rising here and there among the tents. Each person was making breakfast in their own corner, in their own way. Watching that, I felt that these people each had their own rhythm. Haven had no such thing as rhythm. Everyone there was comfortable in exactly the same way, at exactly the same time.

The old man's spot was the innermost part of the camp, where the sun fell best. I noticed that others stepped a little wide of it as they passed. I couldn't quite tell whether it was respect or caution.

"...I hear you're curious about people who've been completed," the old man said.

"...Yes," my brother said. "Do you know something?"

I held my breath at that. Since leaving that city, for the first time, someone was saying they knew something.

I saw my brother's face go slightly taut — expectation and wariness rising in it at once. I remembered that he'd already worn that same face several times before, and every time it had come to nothing. Still, he put the same face on again, every single time.

The old man planted his cane and lowered himself slowly to sit before us. Moving looked hard for him, and still he'd made a point of getting up to call us over.

"...Sit," the old man said. "This isn't a story for standing up."

Noa spoke quietly beside him.

"...Not everything the old man says is true. But this particular story — I've heard it from other people's mouths, more than once, since I came here."

The old man cleared his throat at that.

"...It's true I'm an old man who talks nonsense," he said. "But this isn't nonsense. A man who's lived this long knows the difference."

The old man drew a small circle in the dirt with the tip of his cane. Even with his eyes gone dim, his hand was steady.

"...It wasn't until my eyes went dark that stories like this one started coming through clearly," the old man said. "When I was young, I only ever believed what my eyes could see."

Listening, I looked at his hands. The knuckles were thick and weathered the color of earth. The circle they'd drawn wasn't crooked at all. I understood then, for the first time, that there were things a hand remembered that eyes did not.

The old man paused to catch his breath. Noa handed him a swallow of water. He drank it and only then opened his mouth again.

"...When I was young, I lived somewhere like Haven," the old man said. "The name was different, but it did the same thing. Whatever you filed, it disappeared. But what disappeared turned out not to be truly gone."

"...So is that why you left?" my brother asked.

"...I was thrown out," the old man said with a short laugh. "At the time I thought it was a punishment. Now, thinking back, I wonder if it wasn't."

. . .

"...I don't know exactly," the old man said. "But there's a story that's gone around for a long time. That the completed ones go to a well."

"...A well?" I asked.

"...I thought it was strange too," the old man said. "Why would a completed person go to a well? But this story has been around a very long time. I heard it too, back when I was your age."

"...Which well?" my brother asked.

The old man shook his head.

"...I don't know that much. I don't even know how many wells there are out here. But people call one of them just 'the well.'"

Hearing that, I thought, strangely, of the man at the flowerbed. He had said it was "the thing that grows where no one planted it." I didn't know then why that saying overlapped with this talk of a well.

My brother asked carefully.

"...Do you really believe that well exists?"

The old man smiled a little.

"...It's less that I believe it," he said, "and more that I've never found a reason not to. That's the more accurate way to put it."

"...Is the well far from here?" my brother asked.

"...I've never walked there myself, so I don't know," the old man said. "But I've heard you have to go a long way toward the sunrise, along a road few people ever travel."

"...Would it be dangerous?"

"...If there's a road in this Wilderness with no danger on it, be sure to tell me too," the old man said. It was the first time he'd smiled.

I found myself strangely at ease, watching that smile. This was the first person I'd met who could speak the word "dangerous" this lightly and still mean it, all at once. In Haven, the word danger had already been a problem waiting to be resolved. Out here, it was simply a condition of living.

Noa put in beside him.

"...I've been as far as the start of that road myself," she said. "There's not much water out that way. If you're going, you'll want to carry as much as you can."

"...How long would it take?" my brother asked.

"...Four days? Five?" Noa tilted her head. "I don't know exactly. I haven't been all the way there myself — I only heard it from someone who had."

Listening to that, I felt that the whole of the Wilderness was strung together this way. Someone who had seen a thing, and someone who had heard it from that person, and someone else who had heard it from them in turn. In Haven, every piece of information had come straight from the Ledger. Out here, it traveled

mouth to mouth, wearing a little thinner each time it passed. I found that wearing-thin strangely more trustworthy.

. . .

"...There's also talk of someone who keeps that well," the old man added. "They call him the Well-Keeper, I hear. But I've never met him myself. And I've never met anyone who has, either."

"...So isn't it just an old story, then?" my brother asked. There was doubt in his voice.

"...It might be just an old story," the old man said. "But here's what I think. It's a rare thing for the exact same story to travel this long, out of this many mouths, with nothing behind it at all."

Hearing that, I looked at my brother. There was a familiar expression on his face. The same face he'd had the day he first discovered the Completion House in Haven.

The old man planted his cane and drew himself up a little. It was the gesture of someone bringing a story to its end.

"...That's as much as I can tell you," the old man said. "The rest, you'll have to go and see for yourselves. Believe an old man's word alone, and you won't get anywhere."

"...Thank you," my brother said.

"...Save the thanks for later," the old man said. "For when you've actually found something."

. . .

That night, my brother said to me.

"...I want to go find that well."

"...Off to do something dangerous again?" I asked. But this time I wasn't angry.

"...This time I meant, let's go together," he said.

I laughed at that. It had been a long time since I'd laughed.

"...All right," I said. "Let's go together."

The fire was dying down. I watched the last embers and thought back over the days we'd spent at this tent camp. These people had made room for us without asking for anything in return. I understood now that this had never been an ordinary thing.

"...Let's say a proper goodbye to Noa before we go," I said.

"...Of course," my brother said. "If it weren't for these people, there's no telling what would have happened to us by now."

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. The next morning, we said goodbye to Noa and the children and set out to find that well. I didn't know then that on the day we learned who this Well-Keeper was, the whole road we had walked from Brick Hollow until now would look different to us all over again.

(Continued in Chapter 17.)

Chapter 17. Toward the Sunrise

Previously — The old man of the tent camp told them an old rumor — that the completed go "to a well," and that a "Well-Keeper" watches over it. The brother and sister said goodbye to Noa and the children and set out toward the sunrise to find that well.

We had been walking for three days.

The sun rose in the east that day too, exactly as it always did. We walked straight into it. On the first day the glare kept forcing my eyes shut; by the third day I'd learned, a little, how to keep them open against it. The ground grew drier with every mile. The grass thinned more and more.

The water Noa had packed for us ran out on the second day. My brother grew quieter from then on. I knew he was holding back his thirst.

I watched his stride closely then. What had started long and strong was growing shorter, step by step. But his direction never once wavered. His body was tiring, and yet his mind seemed to be growing clearer, not dimmer.

I learned then that thirst was a more urgent sense than hunger. Hunger could wait. Thirst would not.

My tongue kept sticking to the roof of my mouth. I tried to swallow and found there was almost nothing left to swallow. My brother kept glancing at me sideways without breaking stride. I knew he was thirstier than I was and worrying about me more anyway.

"...Are you all right?" he asked, again and again.

"...I'm all right," I answered every time. I wasn't, really. But looking at his face, the words came out on their own.

The dry bread Noa gave us was gone within a single day too. Chewing it, I thought of the perfect bread of Haven. This bread was hard and salty. And still, I liked it better. It was bread someone had made by giving up their own.

For the first time, I understood there were two ways hunger could be filled. Filled by having your case received. And filled by being shared with.

Even after the bread was gone, I kept turning the crumbs left on my hand over and over. It felt wasteful to let them go. In Haven, nothing had ever been anything to waste — if you needed more, you simply filed for it again. I was learning that feeling, wastefulness itself, all over again, here in the Wilderness.

"...Are you going to eat the crumbs too?" my brother asked. It wasn't teasing.

"...Yes," I said. "It's the last of the bread."

He laughed a little at that, then tipped his own last crumbs into his mouth too.

. . .

On the afternoon of the third day, my brother stopped walking.

"...Look at that," he said, pointing at a few low, stunted trees. "There might be water somewhere like that."

I followed the trees with my eyes. They were a little greener than everything around them. I learned then, for the first time, that a difference in color alone could tell you something. In Haven, everything had been the same brightness, the same shade. Out here, the smallest difference in color could mean the difference between living and not.

We went over. There really was a small pool. Muddy water. Not clear.

There was shade under the trees. We sat there for a while. My body, baked all day in the sun, slowly cooled. I hadn't known until then how welcome that coolness could feel. In Haven, shade had never been necessary — wherever you went, the temperature was always just right.

"...So this is what shade feels like," I murmured.

My brother huffed a laugh at that.

"...You keep saying things like that lately," he said. "That the things we took for granted weren't actually a given."

"...Yes," I said. "I feel like I'm learning it all over again, every day."

"...Is it all right to drink?" I asked.

My brother looked at the water for a long while.

"...If we were in Haven, the Ledger would already have filtered it for us," he said. "Here, no one filters it for you. We have to do it ourselves."

I listened to that, watching him filter the water through the hem of his shirt. It wasn't perfect. Still, when I drank it, I felt, in every part of my body, the sensation of being alive.

The water smelled of earth. It left a rough feeling going down my throat. But strangely, even that roughness was welcome. Haven's water had never tasted like anything at all. This water had a taste. A bad one, but the fact that it had any taste at all was, to me, an entirely new thing.

My brother folded the cloth back up and said.

"...Good thing we learned this one. Next time we find a puddle like this, we'll know what to do."

I could hear in that how he'd started treating this road as a time of learning. When we were running, there had been no room for that kind of ease. Now there was.

We rested beside the pool a while longer. Looking up at the sky, my brother said.

"...In Haven, I never even thought about being thirsty. The moment I thought it, the water was already there."

"...Was that a bad thing?" I asked.

"...It wasn't bad," he said. "But this one mouthful of water right now feels so much bigger than that perfect water ever did."

. . .

That night, my brother spoke up suddenly by the fire.

"...I've been having a strange thought lately."

"...What is it?"

"...When we were in Haven, everything was perfect. But I feel like I was more dead back then. Now everything's short of enough... but I feel more alive."

Hearing that, I felt my brother changing, little by little. He was still angry. But something else was growing underneath that anger.

"...Is that a good thing?" I asked.

"...I don't know," he said. "But I don't hate it."

The fire burned low. I sat quietly, looking at my brother's face lit by that light. In Brick Hollow, his face had always looked like it was enduring something. In Haven, it had looked like it was doubting something. Now it was neither. It was just my brother's face, sitting there as itself.

"...Elpis," he said suddenly. "Aren't you scared? Going toward some place we don't even know what it is."

"...I'm scared," I said honestly. "But it's better than not looking for anything at all."

My brother nodded at that. He didn't say anything else. I found the silence comfortable.

. . .

On the morning of the fourth day, a low hill appeared far off on the horizon. Something seemed to be standing on top of it. It was too far to see exactly what.

"...Could that be the well?" I asked.

"...I don't know," he said. "But we won't know until we get there."

We started walking toward the hill again. Our feet ached and our throats were still a little dry. But that morning, for the first time since leaving Brick Hollow, I felt that we were "going toward" somewhere. Not running away. Going.

Our steps picked up. I could feel my brother's pace quicken along with mine. The thing on the hill was still only a blur, but neither of us could tear our eyes away from it.

"...What if it's nothing at all?" I asked. The worry slipped out before I could stop it.

"...Then we walk some more," my brother said. There was no wavering in his voice. "We've been walking this whole way anyway."

That answer put my mind at ease. My brother was speaking now like someone no longer clinging to the outcome.

The closer we got to the hill, the clearer the shape became. Something like the outline of a stone wall came into view. I kept walking without being certain what it was. Walking without certainty — that, too, was something I learned for the first time that day.

I set that difference down as the last sentence of this chapter. Running looks behind. Going forward looks ahead. That day, I understood that we were, for the first time, walking with our eyes forward.

(Continued in Chapter 18.)

Chapter 18. The Well-Keeper

Previously — On the fourth day of searching for the well, with their water and bread gone, the brother and sister began walking toward the hill on the horizon. For the first time, they felt the sense of going forward rather than running away.

What stood on the hill really was a well.

A small well ringed by a low stone wall. Someone sat beside it. A young man. He looked a little older than us.

The last few steps up the hill were the hardest. There was no strength left at all in my legs, and still, from the moment the well came into view, I couldn't stop walking. My brother was the same. We climbed the last stretch of that hill almost at a run.

Low grass grew here and there around it. A clearly greener shade than anywhere else. Just that color of grass alone told me this place was different from everywhere around it.

I felt something strange then. The well stood alone in the middle of the Wilderness, in a place with nothing around it. And yet the stone wall alone was clean, as if someone tended it every single day.

On legs that had walked four days, we arrived, more collapsing than sitting down before it. My brother looked like he had no strength left even to speak. I could feel the man's eyes reading our condition in a single glance.

"...Sit," he said first. "Drink water before you talk."

His voice was low and calm. There was no hurry in it at all. I found that calm strangely foreign. Everyone we'd met since coming out into the Wilderness had carried some measure of urgency. This man alone did not.

. . .

The man looked us over first. He wasn't surprised.

"...It's been a while since anyone came by," he said. "Here for water?"

"...Yes," my brother said. His throat was parched.

The man stood and looked us over once more. Worn clothes, cracked lips, feet caked in dust. It wasn't a judging look. Just a careful one.

"...You've come a long way," he said.

"...We walked four days," I said.

"...Four days." The man repeated it back, something turning over behind his eyes. "Walking this direction four days means you had a reason for it."

The man lowered a bucket and drew up water for us. It was clear. Not muddy.

"...Why is this one so clear?" I asked.

"...This well is deep," the man said. "Water that comes from deep down is always clear."

Drinking that water, I thought his words weren't only about the water. I didn't know exactly why I felt that.

The water was cool, and just faintly sweet. I had never drunk water like it. Not the muddy water, and not Haven's flavorless water either. I looked back down

into the bucket. It was too deep to see the bottom.

"...How deep is it?" I asked.

"...I've never measured it all the way down myself," the man said. "But I know it's very deep."

My brother drank too, and seemed for the first time to breathe properly.

"...Thank you," he said. There was real feeling in his voice. It was the first time, outside that city, I'd heard him say that to anyone.

Speon looked briefly startled at that, as if he'd been handed something enormous.

"...It's just a bowl of water," he said. But his voice sounded genuinely glad.

"...It doesn't look like many people come here," I said.

"...Almost none," Speon said. "Once every few months, or rarer than that. So when someone comes, I'm glad. And a little afraid, too."

"...Why afraid?" I asked.

"...In case it's nothing again," Speon said quietly. In that, I could feel that he greeted every visitor already hoping for something.

. . .

When my brother finished drinking, he asked carefully.

"...Is this... the well people say the completed go to?"

The man's expression changed at that. He looked startled.

"...Where did you hear that?" he asked.

"...From people in the Wilderness," my brother said. "And about the ones stamped COMPLETE, too."

"...Who told you this?" the man asked again. There was urgency in his voice now.

"...An old man at a tent camp," my brother said. "And someone named Noa, too. We don't know the details, but they said the story's been around a long time."

The man looked at the worn paper in my brother's hand. He looked at it for a long time.

"...Would you show me that paper?"

My brother handed it over. The man read the name, and ran his fingertip over the stamp.

In that moment, I saw something in the man's face come apart. It was too complicated an expression to call sorrow alone.

His fingertip paused for a moment over the stamp. I saw it tremble slightly. It was the hand of someone touching, again, a very old wound.

"...This name — I don't know this person," he said quietly. "But this stamp... I know this stamp. I know it very well."

"...How do you know it?" my brother asked.

Instead of answering, he looked off into the distance. He said nothing for a long time.

I looked around the well while the silence held. There were small marks scored into one side of the stone wall — nicks someone had cut in, over and over, for a long time. Numbers, or a tally of some kind. I couldn't tell which.

"...What's that?" I asked, pointing at the wall.

The man seemed to come back to himself, and looked over.

"...Days," he said. "I was counting how many I'd spent here. I started counting, and then I stopped. There got to be too many."

. . .

"...My name is Speon," the man finally said. "People say I'm the one who keeps this well. Though to be exact... it isn't keeping. It's waiting."

As he said it, he glanced back toward the well. It looked like an old habit. I noticed that even in the middle of talking, he kept checking on it out of the corner of his eye, as if something might rise up out of it at any moment.

"...Waiting for what?" I asked.

The wind swept across the well's edge. His clothes, caught on the rim of the stone, stirred faintly. In that brief silence, I felt that it had been a very long time since anyone had asked Speon that question.

Speon looked at us for a long time. His face was that of someone making up his mind about something.

"...To answer that question, it'll be a long story," Speon said. "Rest here tonight, and tomorrow I'll tell you everything I know. It's been... a very long time since anyone came here carrying that question."

He got up and brought back two blankets. Worn, but clean.

"...Bear with it if it's uncomfortable," Speon said. "There's no guest room out here."

"...This is more than enough," my brother said. "Better than Haven's beds."

Speon smiled a little at that. It was the first smile I'd seen from him.

"...So you're children who know Haven," he said. "That'll make this easier to explain."

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. That night, for the first time, I felt that we were drawing close to a real answer. But strangely, that feeling was closer to fear than to joy.

(Continued in Chapter 19.)

Chapter 19. Those Who Lost Their Names

Previously — After four days of travel, the brother and sister found the well. A man named Speon, who kept it, was deeply shaken by the paper stamped COMPLETE. "I know this stamp," he said. He promised to tell them everything he knew the following night.

The next night, Speon began to speak by the fire.

The fire burned low. Speon studied it for a long while before he opened his mouth. I could tell he was choosing his words — the face of someone who had spent the whole day thinking about where to begin.

I remember my brother standing there that night, unable even to sit down. I thought then that he was ready to hear it. Looking back now, I don't think anyone can ever really be ready for a story like that one.

From the well came the faintest sound of water moving. I hadn't known, until I heard it, that the well made any sound at all.

"...This well is connected to the Completion Houses in the cities," Speon said. "I don't know exactly how it's connected. But some of the people who are completed — they come up out of the bottom of this well."

My breath stopped the moment I heard that. I understood at once — if that were true, it meant Father might not be dead at all.

My brother shot to his feet right there.

"...Are you sure?" he asked. "They really come out alive?"

"...Every one I've seen with my own eyes, yes," Speon said. "Not many. But every one of them was alive."

My brother's hands were shaking. It was the first time I'd seen them shake.

I wanted to take that hand in mine. But I couldn't bring myself to reach for it. In that moment my brother looked like someone who needed no comfort from anyone — only Speon's next words.

Speon watched him a moment, then motioned for him to sit back down.

"...Sit and listen," Speon said. "If your legs give out, you won't hear the rest of this either way."

Only then did my brother sit. I saw that his knees were still trembling.

. . .

"...They come out? Alive?" my brother asked. His voice trembled.

"...Yes, alive," Speon said. "But not whole."

"...What do you mean?"

My brother asked it again. I had a feeling he would ask it a second time, and a third. It wasn't an answer a person could take in all at once.

Speon closed his eyes for a moment.

"...They come out having lost their name," Speon said. "And along with it, they lose who they loved. The most painful memory is erased, and along with it, it seems, the names and faces bound up in that memory disappear too."

Hearing that, I thought of the old woman at the flowerbed. That blurred place where she had forgotten her daughter's name but "having loved her" alone remained. For the first time, I understood that the two things worked by the same principle. Haven's "resolving" and the Completion House's "completing" only differed in degree — they were looking in the same direction.

"...So nothing at all is left?" I asked. My voice had gone small.

"...I said something is left," Speon said. "It isn't erased completely. But what that something is differs from person to person. For some it's a habit of the hands. For some it's a line of a song they liked."

"...How do you know what's left?" my brother asked.

"...You only find out by watching them, after they come out," Speon said. "That's why I'm here. To watch."

"...What are they like, when they first come out?" I asked. "Aren't they afraid?"

"...They're afraid," Speon said. "They don't know who they are, or why they came up out of the water. But strangely, at first, they're all quiet. They don't even cry. They just sit still and look around."

"...Why don't they cry?" I asked.

"...To cry, you have to know you've lost something," Speon said. "But those people don't even know what they've lost. So there's no way for them to cry."

Hearing that, I felt a chill run over my skin. I understood then, for the first time, that forgetting wasn't only a sad thing — it was a thing that made you unable to even grieve.

. . .

"...So could our father come out somewhere here too?" I asked.

"...He could," Speon said. "But it might not be this well. Each Completion House seems to connect to a different well. I only know this one."

"...Then how many wells are there?"

"...I don't know," Speon said. "I'm still looking too."

I could feel, in that answer, that Speon had been doing this for a long time. And that even after all that time, he still hadn't found every answer.

"...Then we'll have to find the other wells too," my brother said. His voice already sounded decided.

"...It won't be easy," Speon said. "This world is wide, and the wells are hidden. It took me years just to come to keep this one."

"...We'll do it anyway," my brother said.

There was no wavering in his voice. Beside him I felt that steadiness, and at the same time accepted that this journey might turn out to be far longer than we'd thought. When we left Brick Hollow, I'd believed it would be over in a matter of days. Now, for the first time, it occurred to me that it might take years.

Speon looked at my brother a long time after that answer. I felt something like pity in that look, and something a little larger than pity — a kind of respect.

. . .

"...Why do you do this?" my brother asked. "What does it have to do with you?"

Speon was quiet for a long time.

"...I once made someone else wait, a long time ago," he said finally. "Back then, I couldn't wait, and I handed someone else over instead. Waiting here, at this well, now... it's doing the thing I couldn't do then."

I didn't fully understand what he meant. But seeing my brother offer no argument at all to that, I knew there was something heavy and true in it.

I understood then, all over again, that Speon had reached this spot far, far before us. We thought we'd walked four days. Speon had not moved an inch from this place in years. I could only guess, then, at what kind of walking that was.

The fire had burned down low. Speon fed in another branch. The flame caught again and lit his face. For the first time, I really saw the old exhaustion that had settled into it.

"...What does 'handed someone else over' mean?" I asked carefully.

Speon looked at me. He didn't answer. But the silence said more than an answer would have. I decided not to press further.

Speon went on.

"...I've told you everything I know. But there's one more thing. The people who come out here — even having lost their name, they don't become an entirely new person. Something remains. I help them hold on to what remains."

The fire kept sinking lower. No one spoke again. In that silence I felt my brother settling something inside himself. His eyes weren't on Speon anymore — they were on the distant horizon.

That night, lying down to sleep, I couldn't close my eyes. I could hear my brother tossing beside me too. The sky was full of stars. Looking up at them, I thought of Father — sitting somewhere, perhaps, without a name. Was he

looking at these same stars right now? And if he was, did he even know they were stars?

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. That night I learned, all at once, that Father might be alive somewhere, and that he might not remember us at all. I didn't know then which of the two was harder to bear.

(Continued in Chapter 20.)

Chapter 20. The One Who Was Already There

Previously — Speon revealed the truth of the Completion House. A completed person comes out alive through a well, but loses their name and the faces of those they loved along with their most painful memory. Hope that Father might be alive, and terror that he might not remember them, arrived together.

That night I barely slept.

I lay under my blanket, but my eyes kept opening. I could hear the wind striking the stone wall beside the well — a sound I hadn't heard in daylight. Listening to it, I thought that this well wore a different face at night.

Neither did my brother. I heard him fold and unfold that paper, over and over, all through the night.

I understood then that we were afraid of the same thing, but afraid of it differently. My brother was afraid of not finding Father. I was afraid we would find him and he wouldn't know us.

After a long time turning restlessly, I opened my eyes a little and looked over at my brother. He was sitting in the moonlight with the paper spread on his knee. He didn't seem to be reading the letters on it. He was just running his fingertips over it, again and again. I thought that gesture looked like someone touching Father's face.

Toward dawn, my brother spoke quietly.

"...Elpis, if we find him and he doesn't recognize us... will you still stay beside him?"

I couldn't answer right away. Only after thinking for a long time did I speak.

"...Yes," I said. "We can just tell him his name again. Even if it takes time."

At that, my brother let out a breath of relief for the first time.

"...Thank you," he said. That was all. But I could feel that those two words carried far more than themselves.

After that we lay side by side without speaking anymore. The sky was slowly growing lighter. Watching that dawn light, I felt afraid of what else this night might teach us, once it ended.

. . .

In the morning, Speon asked.

He had gotten up before us and was building the fire back up. There was practice in the way he warmed water and set breakfast out for us. I tried to guess how many mornings like this he must have repeated, and gave up. It was a number beyond counting.

"...What will you do now?"

"...We need to find another well," my brother said. "Do you know of one?"

"...I've heard of a few," Speon said. "But I haven't been able to check them all. I can't leave this place empty for long."

"...Why not?"

"...Because someone might come out while I'm gone," Speon said. "That person comes out remembering nothing at all. If no one's here then... they'll just wander this Wilderness alone."

Hearing that, I understood why Speon had kept this place so long. He wasn't looking for his own father. And still, he waited for someone every single day.

"...So does that mean you can't leave even for a day?" I asked.

"...I can leave for a few days," Speon said. "But not long. If someone comes out and there's no one here, they don't even know where they are, and they end up wandering alone until they're lost. That's what I'm most afraid of."

"...Have you seen someone like that?" my brother asked.

Speon nodded. He said nothing more. I decided not to ask what memory that silence was holding.

As if to change the subject, Speon got up and walked toward the well. He lowered the bucket again as he spoke.

"...So a day became two days, and two days became a month, and that's how I ended up staying here. At first I only meant to stay a little while."

"...How long has it been?" I asked.

Speon started to count on his fingers, then gave it up.

"...If it were something I could count, it wouldn't have felt this long," he said.

. . .

"...So does that mean you never find anyone?" I asked. "If you only ever stay here?"

Speon smiled a little. A lonely smile.

"...I already found the person I was looking for," he said. "Now my work is helping other people find what they're looking for."

I didn't know exactly what he meant. But something in the way he said it told me Speon had once been like us.

Speon took a sip of water. The morning sun fell across the side of his face. I tried to guess his age from that face and failed. In some moments he looked young. In others, he looked like someone who had lived far longer than that.

"...Did you used to look for someone too?" I asked.

"...No," Speon said. "I didn't go looking. If anything, I ran. Because waiting frightened me. So now I'm learning how to wait."

"...Is waiting something you have to learn?" I asked. It seemed like an odd question, but I was genuinely curious.

"...Yes," Speon said. "I thought waiting just meant staying still. But it isn't that. Waiting is something you have to decide to do again, every single day. Waiting yesterday doesn't mean you'll wait today, on its own."

I didn't understand that exactly, either. But I saw my brother go silent at those words and look at Speon for a long time.

I felt, in that moment, that something was passing between my brother and Speon that I didn't know. Both of them had once run. One had stayed here, learning how to wait. The other was only just beginning to walk.

"...Do you regret running?" my brother asked suddenly.

Speon paused a moment at the question.

"...I don't regret it," he said slowly. "But I do think I should have stopped sooner. Running becomes a habit at some point. You keep running even when there's no reason left to."

My brother turned that answer over for a long time. I could tell he was hearing it as if it were about himself.

. . .

As he prepared to leave, my brother asked.

"...Have you ever seen a strange man around here? Working at a flowerbed, or... somewhere no one planted anything."

Speon stopped walking at that.

I saw his back go slightly rigid in that instant. The hand packing his bag had stopped too.

"...What does he look like?" Speon asked. His voice had changed.

My brother described him. Worn clothes, soil-stained hands, the habit of never giving his name.

Speon was quiet for a long time.

"...I've seen him too," he said. "Here, and elsewhere. But every time, I thought it was just coincidence."

"...When did you see him?" my brother asked.

"...The first time was a very long time ago," Speon said. "Back then I thought he was just a passing traveler. Then again before I came here, somewhere else. And here, a few times as well."

Listening, I felt a strange chill run down my spine. Until then I'd thought of the man at the flowerbed only as a stranger we'd happened to cross paths with. But looking at Speon's face, I understood it went further than that.

"...What did he do?" I asked.

"...Nothing at all," Speon said. "He just was there. But strangely, wherever he'd been, something always looked different afterward."

My brother stood there a long while even after his pack was ready. I could see he wanted to ask more and was holding himself back. It was probably about the man at the flowerbed. But looking at Speon's face, he seemed to decide not to press it further.

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. For the first time, I understood that the man at the flowerbed had passed through Brick Hollow, and Haven, and this well in the Wilderness, all of them. That night, I began, faintly, to feel that it was no coincidence at all.

(Continued in Chapter 21.)

Chapter 21. In Search of the Recorder

Previously — Speon briefly revealed why he kept the well every day, and a piece of his past — that he hadn't gone looking, but had run, and was now learning how to wait. When Speon said he'd seen the man at the flowerbed in more than one place, Elpis began, faintly, to feel it was no coincidence.

The morning fog lay low around the well. In it, I could see Speon already up and pacing near the water. He didn't look like he'd slept at all.

"...Go find someone," Speon said the next morning. "Her name is Mena. She's the Recorder."

"...What does she record?" my brother asked.

"...The names of the completed," Speon said. "She's someone who gathers, from every well scattered across this world, as many of the names of the people who come out as she can. I send her word myself, sometimes."

Hearing that, I understood for the first time, truly, that there were far more people like us scattered across this vast Wilderness. It wasn't only Speon.

"...Is Mena a Well-Keeper too?" I asked.

"...No," Speon said. "Mena doesn't keep a well. She keeps names instead. Everyone keeps watch in their own way."

Listening to that, I found myself thinking that this world must be full of far more people, keeping and watching over someone in ways we didn't yet know, than we could imagine.

"...Who is the record for?" my brother asked.

"...At first, I didn't know either," Speon said. "But I know now. It's for the day someone who lost their name wants to hear it again. Someone has to be holding on to that name when that day comes."

Hearing that, I thought of the paper stamped COMPLETE that my brother carried. He had already been doing that work, alone. Mena was someone doing that same work, only far larger, and far longer.

At that, my brother pressed a hand briefly to the paper in his shirt, checking it was still there. I'd lost count of how many times I'd seen him do that by now. It had become almost a part of his body.

"...I guess I should be doing something like that too," my brother murmured. It sounded less like it was meant for Speon than like he was talking to himself.

"...You're already doing it," Speon said. "That one piece of paper is where it starts."

Listening to them, I felt my brother becoming, little by little, a different person. When we left Brick Hollow, he had been someone trying to leave evidence behind. Now he was becoming someone trying to keep something safe. I understood that the difference looked small, but was in fact enormous.

. . .

"...Why does Mena do this?" I asked.

"...By her own account, she used to be someone who kept records, once," Speon said. "I heard she recorded some great story somewhere, once. I don't know exactly what it was myself."

Something about that pulled at me strangely. I was recording this story too. I didn't know then that someday I would come to share that very thing with Mena.

From that moment on, I found myself curious about this person named Mena. I tried to imagine what she looked like, what her voice sounded like. In my imagination, she was always sitting among stacks of paper.

"...A great story — what kind?" I asked.

"...I don't know exactly either," Speon said. "But every time Mena talks about it, something changes in her eyes. It's the look of someone who's kept something for a very long time, and very carefully."

I held on to that. Something told me I would hear that story myself, someday.

"...Has Mena been out here a long time too?" I asked.

"...Longer than I have, I'd guess," Speon said. "When I first came here she was already doing this work. She hasn't stopped, not once, from then until now."

"...That's remarkable," my brother said.

"...It's not remarkable. It's just going on," Speon said. "The two look alike, but they're different."

. . .

Before we left, Speon packed us dry bread and a water flask.

"...Where Mena lives is two days from here," Speon said. "There are markers on the way. Small nicks cut into the stones. I don't know who carved them. But follow those nicks, and you won't lose your way."

He tied the water flask securely to my hand as he passed it over. I found that touch strangely familiar. It resembled the way Father used to pack our things.

"...Aren't you coming?" I asked.

"...I have to stay here," Speon said. He looked back at the well. "Someone might come out. I never know when."

Hearing that answer, I understood that Speon might never be able to leave this place for the rest of his life. I couldn't tell, then, whether that was a sad thing or a beautiful one.

I looked back at the well one last time. The water was still clear. The bottom was still out of sight. I found it hard to walk away from that spot, thinking that someday Father might rise up out of that water.

"...Elpis," my brother called. "We have to go."

I ran my hand once more along the stone wall before I finally took a step.

My brother turned back to look at the well once more.

"...If our father comes out here," my brother said, "could you tell him we went looking for him?"

Speon caught my brother's shoulder briefly at that.

"...I will," he said. "I promise."

. . .

As we left, Speon said one last thing to us.

"...Tell Mena that Speon is still waiting. She'll understand what that means."

"...What does that mean?" my brother asked.

Speon smiled a little.

"...That's something only Mena and I know," he said. "Someday you two will have words like that too. Words you never have to explain to anyone."

We walked a few steps and turned to look back. Speon was still standing there in the same spot, watching us. I held that image in my eyes. A single figure standing on a hill, beside a well. I already knew then that the shape of it would never leave me.

. . .

The first nick was on a boulder not far from the well. My brother found it first and traced it with his fingertip.

"...Here," my brother said. "Look."

It looked something like a small arrow, or maybe just a scratch. I stared at the shape a long while and still couldn't be sure. But my brother was already turning his body in that direction.

"...How do you know?" I asked.

"...I don't know," he said. "But I think this is the right direction."

We walked all that day, finding the marks one after another. On boulders, sometimes at the base of a dead tree, the nicks appeared at even, steady intervals. Proof that someone, a very long time ago, had walked this road, steadily, again and again.

Watching those marks, I felt a strange comfort. That someone, long before us, had already found their way through this vast, empty Wilderness. We weren't entirely alone.

My brother kept checking the marks as we walked, as if he mustn't miss a single one. I found that carefulness of his unfamiliar. In Brick Hollow, he had always been someone who walked looking only straight ahead. Now he was watching the ground and the boulders and the dead tree stumps in turn. I thought this must be a new way of walking he had learned in this world.

As the sun went down, I traced one of the nicks with my fingertip. It was cut deep. Not hurried — it looked like something worked over, more than once, with care. I found myself wondering whose hand it had been.

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. That morning we left the well and began walking, following those nicks carved into the stones. I didn't know then that those nicks were the trace of someone's footsteps — someone very old, carved all across this world.

(Continued in Chapter 22.)

Chapter 22. The House of Records

Previously — Speon introduced the brother and sister to Mena, the Recorder. It came out that gathering the names of the completed was the same work my brother had been doing alone. They set out on a two-day walk, following the nicks carved into the stones.

On the evening of the second day, we arrived in front of a low earthen house.

Two days of keeping my eyes fixed to the ground, so as not to lose a single nick, had left my neck stiff. Only when the earthen house came into view did I finally lift my head. The sky was already stained red.

It looked more like a storehouse than a home. There was a small sign by the door. **THE HOUSE OF RECORDS.**

Seeing that sign, I felt strangely at ease. There were places in this world that erased names, and places that wrote them down and kept them. Just knowing both kinds of place existed gave me a little comfort.

A few small flowerpots stood in a row beside the door. It felt strange that anyone would be growing something out here, in this parched Wilderness. I guessed those pots were something someone watered every single day.

The whole way there, my brother barely spoke. I knew what he was afraid of. No answer at all, or an answer that turned out worse — he kept weighing which of the two would be better.

I could read that weighing plainly on his face. I said nothing at the time. I knew no words of mine could stand in for that scale.

I walked ahead in his place, looking around, so as not to disturb his thinking even that much. A little dust stirred in the wind. Smelling it, I realized that even I had begun to feel afraid of what might lie past this door.

. . .

When we knocked, a woman came out. She looked much older than us. There was ink on her fingers, as if she had been writing something without stopping.

Her eyes were sharp. But sharp didn't mean cold. I felt, instead, that these were eyes trained for a very long time to see something precisely.

"...Who are you?" the woman asked.

"...Speon sent us," my brother said. "Are you Mena?"

Something shifted slightly in the woman's face at that name.

"...I am. What did Speon say?"

"...That he's still waiting," I said.

Mena closed her eyes for a moment at that. She said nothing. But I could feel something very old in that silence.

"...Is he well?" Mena asked. Her voice shook a little.

"...Yes," my brother said. "He keeps that well every day."

Mena smiled a little at that. Something like tears mixed into her smile.

"...That's just like him," Mena said.

As she said it, Mena opened the door a little wider. I could tell, from that gesture, that she had already decided to let us in. A single name, Speon's, had been enough to open that door.

"...Come in," Mena said. "This isn't a conversation for standing outside."

Mena walked ahead of us and lit a lamp. The light fell on her ink-stained fingers. I could tell the stains on those fingers hadn't come from a day or two of writing.

. . .

Mena let us inside. The whole place was paper. There were shelves along every wall, and every shelf was packed tight with paper covered in names.

The room had its own particular smell — old paper and ink, and faintly, candle wax. Breathing it in, I tried to guess how long this room must have been filling up like this. I couldn't quite manage it.

Some of the shelves reached all the way to the ceiling. I wondered how old the papers up there must be. I wondered whether Mena's own hand could even reach that high, until I noticed an old ladder standing in the corner and had my answer.

"...Are all these the names of completed people?" I asked.

"...Only the ones I've managed to gather," Mena said. "I haven't gathered them all. This world is too vast."

I ran my eyes over the shelves, one by one. The handwriting was different from paper to paper. I understood that these weren't all copied out by Mena's own hand, but were, instead, the traces of word carried to her by many different people and set down just as it came. Some of the paper was old and faded; some looked as if the ink hadn't even dried yet.

Looking around at the papers, my brother asked carefully.

"...Could you look for our father's name too?"

Mena looked at him for a long time.

"...Tell me his name," she said. "I'll look."

My heart was pounding so hard in that instant it hurt. Listening to my brother say Father's name, I could feel that even after all this time, the name still sat exactly right in his voice.

I repeated the name silently to myself as well. I didn't say it aloud. But just doing that much brought a heat to my eyes. I realized, in that moment, how many times I must have said that name over to myself, just to keep from forgetting it.

Mena wrote the name down on paper. I saw her fingertips trembling slightly.

"...Is it a common name?" Mena asked.

"...No," my brother said. "In Brick Hollow, our father was the only one with it."

"...Then it might be a little easier to find," Mena said.

Mena checked the paper once more and asked.

"...Any features that might help? A scar on his body, a particular way of walking?"

My brother thought a moment before answering.

"...One finger on his left hand is short," my brother said. "He was hurt carrying bricks."

Mena wrote that small detail down beside the name.

"...This kind of thing helps," Mena said. "People forget their names. Their bodies don't forget as easily."

As she spoke, Mena underlined that detail on the page once more, to mark it. Her hand moved with practice. I could tell from that gesture alone that she had done this — taking down small details like this — more times than could be counted.

"...Have you ever heard anything about someone with a short finger?" my brother asked carefully.

Mena shook her head.

"...Not yet," Mena said. "But I'll look now."

. . .

Mena moved back and forth between the shelves for a long time. The room filled with nothing but the sound of pages turning.

My brother stood in one spot the whole while, without moving at all. I sat beside him and held his hand. His hand was cold. I hoped my own hand might warm it, even a little.

Every time the candle flame flickered, the shadows of the papers on the shelves flickered with it against the wall. Watching those shadows, I thought that every single one of those papers had been, for someone, the whole of who they were.

I didn't know how much time had passed. I couldn't breathe right through any of it.

Mena finally stopped in front of one shelf. She turned back to face us. Her expression was complicated.

"...It's here," Mena said. "But it isn't the answer you're hoping for."

Mena carried the paper back toward us as if cradling it against her chest. Her steps had slowed from before. I could feel, in that slowness, that she was still choosing how to say what came next.

"...Stay here tonight," Mena said. "I'll tell you in the morning, once your minds are a little clearer."

"...We want to hear it now," my brother said. His voice had gone rough.

Mena looked at him for a long time.

"...All right," Mena said. "Then sit down."

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. In that instant I learned that Father really was alive, somewhere in this world. But at the same time, I had to endure the whole of that night before I would learn what she meant by "not the answer you're hoping for."

(Continued in Chapter 23.)

Chapter 23. An Answer We Didn't Expect

Previously — After two days of travel, the brother and sister reached Mena's House of Records. Mena found Father's name, but closed the chapter saying, "It isn't the answer you're hoping for."

The lamp burned low. Mena settled into her seat and unfolded the paper once more. I could feel her hand moving more slowly than before.

"...About a month ago," Mena said, unfolding the paper. "I got word that someone we believe was your father came out of a well in the north."

"...He's alive, right?" my brother asked urgently.

"...He was alive. At least, then," Mena said.

I remember that all three of us seemed to hold our breath in that instant. The lamp's shadow trembled faintly on the wall. The room was so quiet that even that small trembling felt loud.

I felt the unease already, in that word "then." I knew it meant this was a story with no ending yet.

My brother looked like he could hardly breathe. I saw his hand clenched tight on his knee. His knuckles had gone white.

Mena studied our faces and went on carefully.

"...Should I keep going?" she asked. "Once you hear it, there's no taking it back."

My brother looked at me for a moment. I nodded. He nodded too.

"...Please, go on," he said.

I could feel, in his voice, both fear and longing at once. I felt the same. I wanted to know. And I felt, at the same time, that knowing might break me.

Mena closed her eyes briefly, then opened them again. I could tell she was steadying herself for this moment. Delivering news like this couldn't be an easy thing for her either.

. . .

"...This came from the one who keeps that well," Mena said. "The moment he came out, he was counting something. Silently, on his fingers. He said he didn't even know why."

"...At first he didn't say anything at all," Mena added. "Whether they asked his name or where he'd come from, there was no answer. He just kept folding and unfolding his fingers."

I tried to picture that, and stopped myself. Even the picture of it alone was enough to hurt.

"...What was he counting?" I asked. I already felt I knew the answer.

My voice came out shaking. Tears were already rising in me before I even heard the answer.

"...I don't know. But at some point, while he was counting, he suddenly got up and walked off somewhere. No one could stop him."

Hearing that, I felt like I was going to cry. I knew it was a count of bricks. Father had forgotten his name, and our faces, and yet that number alone he counted as if it had been carved into his body.

I thought of Father counting that number every evening in Brick Hollow. Even with his fingertips split and bleeding, he never let that count slip. I hadn't known, then, why it mattered so much. I know now. That number had been the proof, every single day, that he had survived.

"...Three thousand," my brother said quietly. "He must have counted all the way to three thousand. And then started over from the beginning again."

Mena didn't question that at all. I could tell she had already guessed what it meant.

The room went very quiet. I felt I could almost hear the flicker of the lamp's flame itself. I sat pressed close to my brother's side and held on to his arm. He didn't move at all.

. . .

"...And after that?" my brother asked. His voice cracked.

"...There's no word after that," Mena said. "The Well-Keeper there hasn't seen him since. He must still be somewhere. But exactly where — I don't know that either."

"...Did no one go after him?" I asked.

"...They did," Mena said. "But they lost him. It was night, and he walked faster than anyone expected."

Hearing that, I felt, strangely, a little comforted by the fact that Father had hurried. Even having forgotten his name, his stride, at least, had still been urgent. I wanted to believe that meant he was still walking toward something.

My brother sank down where he stood. I sat beside him and gripped his shoulder.

My brother made no sound at all. But I could feel his shoulder trembling, very finely. I thought, in that moment, that my brother looked like someone who had forgotten how to cry aloud. From Brick Hollow all the way to now, he had always wept only on the inside, like this.

"...Is this the answer you didn't expect?" I asked Mena.

Mena nodded.

"...Learning he's alive and then losing him again can hurt worse than never knowing whether he lived or died at all," Mena said. "But I don't tell lies."

"...Why not?" my brother asked. It wasn't resentment. He genuinely seemed to want to know.

"...Because false comfort is already something Haven does well," Mena said. "I started this work because I wanted to do something different from that."

"...Doesn't it wear on you?" I asked. "Having to deliver news like this, every time?"

Mena looked at me for a long time.

"...It does," Mena said honestly. "But I think it's better than no one delivering it at all. That's what I believe, and it's why I keep doing this work."

Mena looked down at her hands for a moment. They were covered in ink stains.

"...I don't know how many times these hands have written down news like this," Mena said. "But every time, it's just as hard as the first. I never get used to it."

I found that answer, somehow, a comfort. I was glad that Mena hadn't grown numb to this work.

Mena said this as she carefully folded the paper and held it out toward my brother.

"...Take this," Mena said. "You may need it again someday."

My brother took the paper with trembling hands. He folded it and tucked it in beside the paper stamped COMPLETE that he already carried.

. . .

Mena quietly stepped away, as if not wanting to intrude on us. She left a single lamp burning and let the rest go dark. I sat with my brother in that dim light.

Outside, the wind brushed against the walls of the earthen house. Listening to it, I thought that somewhere out past this house, Father might be feeling that same wind right now. Without a name, and without knowing us at all.

I understood then, for the first time, just how cruel Haven's "resolving" truly had been. Nights like this one didn't exist there at all. The pain vanished before it ever had the chance to hurt. I thought, now, that this pain of ours felt more human than that smooth, seamless resolving ever had.

I sat beside my brother a long time that night. He didn't cry. But I could see he wore a face more broken than crying.

"...Brother," I said. "He's still alive, though."

"...Yes," he said, after a very long pause. "He's alive."

"...And he's still counting bricks," I said. "That's proof he was Father. Even having forgotten his name, Father is still inside him."

My brother had no answer to that. I knew it wasn't because he had nothing to say — it was because his throat had closed.

My brother lifted his head then, for the first time, and looked at me. I saw his eyes brimming with tears. He'd been holding them back. This time, it seemed, he couldn't.

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. I cried that day for the first time. The first time since we left Brick Hollow. My brother cried too, following me. That night, we wept together for the father who had forgotten his name.

(Continued in Chapter 24.)

Chapter 24. Northward

Previously — Mena delivered word of Father. A month earlier, he had come out alive from a well in the north, but having forgotten his name and faces, he counted three thousand bricks and then vanished somewhere. For the first time since leaving Brick Hollow, the brother and sister wept together.

The next morning, my eyes were swollen. So were my brother's. But strangely, our bodies felt lighter.

Morning light was coming in through the window. Watching it, I understood for the first time how strange a morning could feel, the day after a whole night of weeping. Nothing in the world had changed at all, and yet I felt like an entirely different person.

I understood for the first time then. Tears didn't erase anything. They only lifted away, by their own weight, whatever had been piling up.

There was a small window in the wall of Mena's house. In the shaft of light coming through it, I watched dust drift slowly. It was a morning as peaceful as if nothing at all had happened. I found it strange how different that peace was from last night's tears. And that the two of them could exist inside the same single day — that, too, was something I was only just learning.

The moment my brother opened his eyes, he checked the paper stamped COMPLETE again, as he always did now, out of habit. But that day was a little different. He looked at the paper for a long time, then folded it carefully and tucked it into his innermost pocket.

"...It's not proof anymore. Not for keeping a name, either," he said, watching my face. "Now this is... proof that we made it this far."

Listening to him, I felt, all over again, that my brother had become an entirely different person over these last few days. When we left Brick Hollow, he had been someone driven only by anger. This paper in his hand now was no longer only evidence of that anger.

. . .

As Mena packed our breakfast, she asked.

Bread and dried fruit sat in a small bowl. Looking at that plain breakfast, I found it strange that someone made a meal like this every morning even here, in this house. That there was a smell of cooking rising in a room full of nothing but paper felt, somehow, like an odd comfort.

"...What will you do now?"

"...We'll go north," my brother said. "To that well, and then we'll follow the road Father walked after."

My brother's voice sounded different from the night before. There was still grief in it, but underneath the grief now sat something that wouldn't waver. Hearing that voice, I understood that he had settled something completely, sometime in the night.

Mena nodded. She didn't try to stop us.

"...I thought you'd say that," she said.

"...Won't it be dangerous?" I asked.

"...It will be," Mena said honestly. "But you two already knew that much when you set out."

My brother smiled at that for the first time. The first smile I'd seen from him in days.

"...Take whatever you need," Mena said. "I hear it's colder up north than it is here. Take another blanket too."

"...Thank you," I said.

Mena folded a blanket and laid it on top of my pack.

"...This is nothing," Mena said. "Not compared to the road you're about to carry."

My brother, repacking his things, asked.

"...Is there another well anywhere along the way we're heading?"

Mena thought for a moment, then nodded.

"...I've heard of one," Mena said. "I don't know the exact location. But if you keep heading north, people will tell you. This world is more connected than you'd think."

"...How?" I asked.

"...By rumor, by footprints, sometimes just by chance," Mena said. "You two got this far the same way, didn't you."

. . .

Before we left, Mena called me aside.

She led me to one corner of the room, to the shelf packed most tightly with names. Standing among all those names, I felt, strangely, at ease. I knew that every one of those papers had once been someone's entire world, and still I found comfort in the fact that all of it had been kept here, together, instead of thrown away.

"...I hear you've been keeping a record," she said. "Speon told me."

"...I just write down what happens," I said. "It's nothing special."

"...That's exactly what makes it special," Mena said. "I started the same way too. Just writing down what happened."

Mena handed me a worn writing tool.

Its handle was worn smooth from long use. Taking it in my hand, I tried to imagine how long, and through whose hands, it must have been carrying stories over the years.

"...Was this originally yours?" I asked.

"...Yes," Mena said. "I think my hand's had its turn. It's your hand that needs it now."

"...Keep writing," she said. "Someday, even your father might need this record."

Taking it, I felt strangely close to tears again. I understood, for the first time, that what I had been doing was no different from what my brother had been doing. He had tried to keep names. I had tried to keep the story. We had only been holding the same thing with different hands.

"...Doesn't it frighten you?" Mena asked. "Keeping a record doesn't mean writing down only the good. You have to write down days like today too."

"...It does," I said. "But if I don't write it down, today will just disappear. And that frightens me more."

Mena looked at me for a long time at that. And then, for the first time, she smiled — a real smile.

"...That's it," Mena said. "That's exactly why I can't let go of this work. You're so much younger than I am, and you already understand it."

I didn't know how to answer that. I just held the writing tool close against my chest.

. . .

We left Mena's house that afternoon.

At the door, Mena hugged us each, once. It was a short, awkward embrace. I could tell she wasn't someone who gave hugs like this often. Even so, it was sincere.

"...Tell Speon," Mena said, one last thing. "That I'm still waiting too."

My brother said he'd remember it exactly.

Listening to that, I felt, once again, that something very old passed between the two of them. I found myself wondering why Speon and Mena didn't simply wait together, in the same place. I thought that someday I'd find out that answer too.

. . .

We left the earthen house behind and set our direction north. The sun already stood near the middle of the sky. I turned back once. Mena was standing at her

door, watching us go. It looked exactly like the way she must have watched Speon leave.

The road turned uphill right away. The ground grew rougher and rougher, and far off on the horizon the faint ridgeline of low mountains came into view. Watching that ridge, I felt that this journey had entered an entirely new stage.

I thought back to the first day we left Brick Hollow. That day, we had only been running. Now there was a reason behind the direction we walked. I understood that the difference, though the steps themselves looked the same from outside, made this an entirely different kind of walking.

As he walked, my brother checked, once more, the two papers he carried. The one stamped COMPLETE, and the one Mena had given him. He set the two together, neatly, and tucked them back inside his shirt.

"...This is where it really begins," my brother said. It sounded half like he was speaking to himself, half like he was speaking to me.

"...Yes," I said. "I think so too."

We walked on like that for a while without speaking. I noticed the color of the dirt beneath our feet changing, little by little. From red earth to gray. I took that change as proof that we were leaving the Wilderness behind.

As the sun began to sink, my brother stopped and turned to look back. I turned and looked too. The road we had walked stretched away into the distance behind us. Haven, the tent camp, the well, the House of Records. I found it strange to think that all those places now lay behind us.

"...We've come a long way," I said.

"...Yes," my brother said. "But there's still further to go."

"...Aren't you scared?" I asked.

My brother looked at me and smiled. A very small smile, but a clear one.

"...I'm scared," he said. "But now I'm not scared alone, so it's all right."

At that I took my brother's hand. He took mine back. We started walking again, hand in hand, just like that.

I set the last sentence of this Part down here. We started walking north. Whether we could find Father, and whether he would know us even if we did — nothing was certain. But that day, for the first time, I saw something close to certainty in my brother's face. Not the certainty of someone who has every answer. Just the certainty of someone who has a reason to keep walking.

(Continued in Part Three.)

The Weeping Ledger, Part Three

The Northward Road

Chapter 25. Following the Trail

Previously — After Mena brought news of Father, the siblings cried together for the first time since leaving Brick Hollow. They learned that tears don't erase something — they lighten a weight — and set out north, following Father's trail.

The road north was rougher than the Wilderness had been.

The grass thinned more each day. The ground grew harder. Jeteo walked anyway, every day. I followed behind him, and every night I wrote down what had happened that day.

That was the first time I really used the writing kit Mena had given me. My hand wasn't used to it yet, and the letters kept slanting crooked. I kept writing anyway.

There was no shade along the road. By day the sun beat straight down on the crowns of our heads; by night, a wind blew that cut clean to the bone instead. That swing in temperature caught me off guard every time. It was a cold we'd never known in Brick Hollow.

Within a few days, the sole of Jeteo's shoe had started to split. He tried to hide that from me too. I only found out from watching him limp, again and again.

"...What's wrong with your shoe?" I asked.

"...Nothing," Jeteo said. It was always his answer. I didn't press him further. No matter how much I asked, he was someone who would insist it was nothing, to the very end.

That evening, without telling him, I wrapped his shoe's sole with a strip of cloth. The next morning Jeteo saw it and said nothing. He just put it on and walked. I knew that silence meant thank you.

Water ran short again. We filtered muddy water the way Noa had taught us and drank it. Even that, Jeteo made me drink first, and drank after.

"...You drink first," I said, more than once. Every time, Jeteo pretended not to hear.

At night we slept back to back. It was our way of blocking the wind, even a little. I could feel Jeteo's back growing thinner by the day. He seemed to wait until he'd made sure I was asleep before he'd let his own eyes close. More than once, I pretended to sleep just to watch him fall asleep.

At night the stars came out unusually thick. Looking up at them, I tried to remember the names of the constellations Father had once taught us back in Brick Hollow. I couldn't remember a single one. That saddened me. On the road to find Father, the very things he'd taught us were the first things slipping away.

That night, for the first time, I understood that keeping a record wasn't only for my own sake. I wasn't writing to keep from forgetting. I was writing to catch hold again of things I'd already forgotten.

. . .

Food ran low too, little by little. We sometimes dug up dried fruit or roots to eat. We told edible from inedible the way Noa had taught us, but we were never quite sure of it, so Jeteo always tasted a little first.

"...If it tastes bitter, spit it out," Jeteo said. Every time I heard that, I knew he was swallowing the danger first, in my place.

On the fifth day, we found footprints we didn't recognize.

Jeteo knelt down and studied them closely.

"...One person's footprints," he said. "But it's strange. Whoever it was circled the same spot again and again."

"...Sounds like someone who was lost," I said.

"...Or," Jeteo went on, "someone who kept looking for something he couldn't find."

Jeteo's finger traced over each print, one by one. The depths were all different. Some prints were shallow; others were dug unusually deep.

Jeteo looked at me. We were both thinking the same thing at the same moment.

My heart started pounding hard again. I couldn't be sure whose footprints these were. But I could see in Jeteo's eyes that he already was.

We stayed at that spot a long while longer. Jeteo circled the footprints again and again, studying them. Watching him, it looked as though he were retracing Father's steps with his own body.

"...What was this person doing here?" I asked.

Jeteo touched the ground with his hand. The dirt there was packed unusually hard.

"...He kept circling this same spot," Jeteo said. "Like... someone looking for something he couldn't find."

That thought hurt something in me. Father had forgotten even his own name, and still he kept searching for something. I felt like I both knew and didn't know what it was.

"...Do you think," I asked carefully, "he might have been looking for us?"

Jeteo didn't answer. Instead, he stared for a long time in the direction the footprints pointed. I knew that silence was his answer, in its own way.

Jeteo stood up, brushing off the dirt. His hands were trembling. I pretended not to notice. He must have known I was pretending.

. . .

Following the footprints, we met a man. He wasn't the one who had left them — just another traveler passing through the area.

The man had a heavy pack on his back. His face was burned dark by the sun, and his gait was slow. He didn't seem surprised to see us. It seemed running into two children on this road wasn't such a rare thing.

"...Have you seen anyone strange around here?" Jeteo asked. "Someone who counts numbers out loud to himself."

The man nodded.

"...I saw him," the man said. "A good while back. He was walking along counting numbers, over and over. Didn't answer when I spoke to him."

"...How long ago was that?" Jeteo asked. Impatience colored his voice.

"...Let's see. A day? Two?" The man tilted his head. "I couldn't say for sure. I only saw him in passing myself."

"...Where did he go?" I asked, urgent.

"...I don't know," the man said. "But there's someone who's good at finding people like that. I heard his name is Temel."

"...Where can we find him?" Jeteo asked.

"...Keep heading north and you'll run into him," the man said. "He's always moving around out there. Finding people — that's his line of work, they say."

"...Does he take payment?" I asked. We had nothing to give.

The man shook his head.

"...Never heard of it," he said. "I heard he just does it."

The moment I heard that name, something about it felt strangely familiar. I didn't know why, then. Now I do. It was another name that had been quietly finding people, here and there, across this world.

With that, the man went on his way. I watched his back for a long time. One name, tossed off by a stranger, had become the most important piece of information in the world to us that day.

. . .

That night, we started walking again in the direction the man had pointed us.

"...This Temel person — do you think it's worth finding him?" I asked.

"...If these footprints belong to Father," Jeteo said, "I'll meet anyone. I'm not letting anything slip past me now."

That night we walked under the stars again, for the first time in a while. There were no clouds, so the road was easy to see. I wanted to believe it was a good sign.

As I walked, I watched Jeteo's back. His shoe was still split open. But his stride had quickened, faster than before. I couldn't tell whether that speed came from

impatience or from hope. Probably it was both.

As we walked, I wrote down again what had happened that day — the footprints, the man, the name Temel. My handwriting still slanted crooked. Even so, I tried not to leave out a single letter. I believed a day would come when I could tell Father this whole road, from beginning to end.

I set those words down as the last line of this chapter. I knew, that day. Jeteo was no longer someone who only gathered evidence, or raged alone. He was, now, a person who searched. And I was the one who recorded that searching.

(Continued in Chapter 26.)

Chapter 26. The Man Who Finds People

Previously — The siblings found footprints they didn't recognize. A traveler confirmed that the person had been walking along, counting numbers, and told them the name of a man who finds people — Temel.

Two days later, we actually met Temel.

He wasn't a big man. He carried his pack light. His eyes never stopped moving, scanning everything around him.

His walk was unusual. Not hurried, not slow. It was the walk of someone who already knew exactly where he was going. Watching it, I felt strangely at ease. I thought — a man like this wouldn't lose his way.

"...Are you the one who finds people?" Jeteo asked.

Temel stopped and looked at us. His eyes flickered, just for a moment.

"...Something like that," Temel said. "Who are you looking for?"

There was something strange in Temel's eyes right then. The look of someone who'd done the same thing, over and over, for a very long time. Not tired — worn smooth by repetition.

Temel's hands caught my eye too. Dirt was packed under his nails in layers, the kind that wouldn't wash off in one try. They were the hands of someone who'd been walking a long, long time.

"...Our father," Jeteo said. His voice trembled a little. "He walks along counting numbers. He's forgotten his own name too."

Temel closed his eyes for a moment at that. He seemed to be remembering something.

"...Finding someone like that can take a long time," Temel said. "Are you still all right with that?"

"...Yes," Jeteo answered right away. No hesitation at all.

"...We met Speon and Mena," Jeteo said. "They never mentioned you — we came looking for you on our own."

Something shifted, faintly, in Temel's face at those two names.

"...Are the two of them well?" Temel asked. His voice held both gladness and caution together.

"...Yes," I said. "Each of them is doing well, where they are."

Temel nodded. He didn't ask anything more. In that silence, I sensed there was some old story among the three of them that we knew nothing about.

"...Is Speon still keeping his well?" Temel asked, out of nowhere.

"...Yes," I said. "People keep coming to find him, I hear."

Temel gave a small laugh at that. It looked like a laugh he hadn't given in a long while.

"...That sounds like him," Temel said. He didn't say anything more after that.

. . .

Jeteo told him about Father — the habit of counting bricks, the footprints, the numbers.

Temel listened, nodding.

"...I've seen people like that a few times," Temel said. "People who've lost their names — mostly they keep repeating something, with their hands or their mouths. Whatever they used to do stays behind in the body."

"...Why does that happen?" I asked.

"...I don't know exactly, myself," Temel said. "But it seems like the body remembers longer than the mind does. The mind lets go of the name. The hands keep counting bricks."

Hearing that, I thought of Father's hands. I tried to imagine what they might be doing right now. Just imagining it hurt.

"...If he finds his name," I asked, "does he go back to how he was?"

Temel shook his head.

"...Not always," Temel said. "Even finding the name back, he might not be exactly the way he was before. But it's better than having no name at all."

That answer wasn't much of a comfort. But strangely, I was grateful for the honesty in it. Temel didn't hand us a false hope.

"...Then can you find him?" Jeteo asked, urgent.

"...I'm a man who finds people," Temel said. "But I'm not a man who carries answers around with him. I'm a man who goes looking."

I didn't understand that difference, then. Now I do. Temel wasn't someone who handed you certainty. He was someone who walked alongside you.

"...What if we find him and he's not Father?" I asked. I was afraid to ask it. But it had to be asked.

Jeteo turned and looked at me. His face said he hadn't expected me to be the one to raise it. I didn't look away from his eyes. I thought someone had to say that possibility out loud.

"...Then we find that person, whoever he turns out to be, in his own right," Temel said. "There's no wasted walking in the finding of someone. Whoever you're looking for, every step of it means something."

"...Has that happened to you? Finding someone, and it not being who you wanted?" Jeteo asked.

Temel nodded.

"...It has," Temel said, briefly. He didn't say more. I sensed a long story hiding inside that shortness.

Strangely, that answer comforted me. For the first time, I understood that this journey might not be a complete failure even if we never found Father.

Jeteo said nothing back to that. But I saw his expression ease, just a little. He'd always been someone who measured a journey only by its outcome. That day, I felt something like a different standard beginning to take shape inside him, little by little.

. . .

"...Why do you do this?" I asked.

Temel looked off into the distance for a moment.

"...A long time ago, there was a place where I was supposed to guide someone, and I ran instead," Temel said. "I was afraid, back then. Now I'm still afraid, sometimes — but I don't run. That's the only repayment I know how to make."

Hearing that, I thought it sounded like something Speon had once said. I didn't know, then, that the two of them had truly come out of the same story.

"...Weren't you afraid? Moments when you wanted to run again?" I asked.

"...Every single time," Temel said honestly. "Even now, sometimes. But once you run because you're afraid, you find yourself running from then on, over and over. So I just walk, afraid."

I held on to those words for a long time. I didn't understand their full weight then. Now I do. It was something we had to learn, again and again, for the whole length of this journey.

"...Do you still see him now — that person?" I asked.

Temel smiled briefly. There was a touch of loneliness mixed into that smile.

"...Sometimes," Temel said. "Not as often as you'd think. But every time we meet, it feels exactly like it did before."

. . .

Temel led us walking north for several more days. The whole way, he kept studying the ground — which way the dry grass lay bent, scratches on the stones, even the depth of every footprint.

Temel's stride looked far more unhurried than ours. But look closely, and his eyes never rested, not for a single moment. Walking behind that stride, I felt anew how exhausting the work of searching really was. It wore out the eyes before it ever wore out the body.

At night, Temel always kept his fire small. "Too big, and you can't find anyone," Temel said. "A person who's searching can't afford to be too bright. Or the one

you're looking for won't be able to see you." I felt like I both understood that and didn't.

Through those four days, Jeteo slept badly every night. I lay awake listening to him turn over, and slept badly along with him. Temel never tried to stop us. Every morning he just packed up his things without a word and started walking again.

On the third day, the path began to narrow, and trees started appearing here and there. Temel's steps slowed, little by little — the walk of someone examining something more carefully.

"...We're getting close," Temel said. His voice wasn't full of certainty. But my heart started pounding at those words anyway.

"...Found it," Temel said quietly, on the fourth night. Far off, a single small light was visible.

The moment I saw that light, I set down the last line of this chapter here. I gripped Jeteo's hand tight again. I couldn't know whether that light was Father. But for the first time, I felt with my whole body that it was possible to walk on without knowing the answer.

(Continued in Chapter 27.)

Chapter 27. Before the Firelight

Previously — The siblings met Temel. Along with his words — "There's no wasted walking in the finding of someone" — on the fourth night they spotted a small light far off in the distance.

We crept carefully toward the light.

A faint smell of smoke was mixed into the night air. The moment I caught it, my heart reacted before I did. There are things the body notices before the mind catches up.

It was a small campfire. Someone sat beside it. His back was to us, so I couldn't see his face. But his hand kept moving — the gesture of counting something in the air.

The gesture moved in a steady rhythm. Like something carved into the body long ago.

It was a windless night. The flame burned straight up, barely flickering at all. That stillness felt strangely frightening to me.

I slowed my steps. So did Jeteo. Both of us tried hard not to make a sound. We were careful even of the grass under our feet.

The instant I saw that gesture, I stopped walking. I felt Jeteo stop at the same moment. We stood there, gripping each other's hands.

The closer we came, the more we could hear a small sound — made with lips that barely moved.

"...two thousand nine hundred ninety-seven, two thousand nine hundred ninety-eight..."

My legs went weak the moment I heard those numbers. I knew exactly where in the count that was. It was almost, almost three thousand. And I understood, for the first time, that since that night, Father had never once made it all the way to three thousand.

His voice was low and cracked. But the cadence of it — that alone was exactly the same as the one I remembered from Brick Hollow.

Temel stopped too, listening. He said nothing. I sensed that his silence was the silence of someone who had already lived through moments like this, more than once.

For just a moment, Temel's hand rested on my shoulder. No words. But the weight of that hand alone told me: from here on, nothing should be said in a hurry.

. . .

Temel went ahead of us, quietly.

"...Excuse me." Temel spoke low. "Are you all right?"

The man's hand stopped. The counting stopped with it. Even that stillness was distinct enough to seem almost audible.

He turned his head, slowly.

That brief moment felt very long to me. For those few seconds, I forgot how to breathe.

My breath stopped the instant I saw that face. It hadn't aged, hadn't changed much at all. I was seeing that face for the first time since our last night in Brick Hollow. It was Father.

Jeteo froze right where he stood too. He couldn't say a word. I watched years' worth of feeling pass over his face all at once — anger, relief, fear, and then fear again.

Temel glanced back at us, quietly. He seemed about to say something, then simply stepped back — a step that left this moment to us.

I still remember that step back, even now. I learned then, for the first time, that there are moments when someone stepping out of the way matters just as much as someone staying beside you.

The campfire crackled. In that moment it sounded like the loudest sound in the world.

I felt my own heart beating in time with it.

. . .

Father looked at us. But there was nothing in his eyes. The eyes of someone looking at strangers.

Father's clothes were worn — a different cloth from what we remembered. His shoes, like ours, had soles split open. That long walking had left its mark on his body too, exactly as it had on ours.

"...Who are you?" Father asked. The voice was exactly the same. But there was no weight in it toward us at all.

I couldn't say anything at all in that moment. My fingertips trembled.

I looked at Father's face again. The shape of his eyebrows, the small scar on his left cheek — all exactly the same. But the look inside that face belonged, completely, to someone else.

Jeteo stepped forward in my place.

"...Do you... know us?" Jeteo asked. His voice had come apart completely.

Father shook his head. His face was apologetic. But even in that apology, there was strangeness.

Jeteo couldn't move for several seconds. I was watching his back — nothing else. His shoulders dropped, just slightly.

Watching those shoulders, I wanted to reach out. But I couldn't move. In that moment, neither Jeteo nor I had even the strength to touch the other.

"...I don't know," Father said. "I'm sorry. I don't... even know who I am, myself."

I hesitated, again and again, over whether to reach out. It felt like taking a stranger's hand, and also like taking the most familiar hand in the world.

Only then did I reach out and take Father's hand. It trembled. It held the exact same warmth as the hand that had held mine, long ago, the night we crossed the boundary stones.

"...I'm Elpis," I said. My voice cracked. "I'm Elpis. I'm your daughter."

"...I'm Jeteo," Jeteo managed to say. His voice shook. "I'm your son."

Father repeated that name back, quietly. "...Jeteo." Slowly, like someone learning to shape an unfamiliar sound.

Jeteo said nothing, hearing it. He just watched the shape of Father's mouth, quietly.

Father's hand gave the faintest twitch, right then. His eyes still recognized nothing at all. But that hand — that alone was responding to something.

I saw that tremor clearly. I didn't know, then, whether it was memory or just a habit left over in the body. I still don't know exactly, even now. But I decided to hold on to that one tremor.

I stroked that hand, gently. The knuckles were thicker than before. It was the hand of someone who had been walking a long time, holding something all the way.

I held that hand a little longer. Father didn't pull it away.

Jeteo came quietly and took Father's other hand. Father didn't shake that one off either. For a while, we sat there in front of the fire in silence, just holding hands.

I set down that answer as the last line of this chapter. I understood, in that moment, for the first time, that finding and losing could happen at once. Father was right in front of us. And Father was farther from us than he had ever been.

(Continued in Chapter 28.)

Chapter 28. How to Sit Beside Someone

Previously — The siblings found Father at last. But he recognized neither their names nor their faces. "I don't even know who I am, myself." When Elpis took his hand, it trembled faintly — a response that could have been memory, or could have been only habit.

That night, Jeteo sat alone a little way off from Father.

The embers had nearly died out. Only a thin thread of smoke still rose. I watched that smoke disappear for a long time. It felt like I couldn't bear it unless I was looking at something.

I went and sat beside him. I said nothing. He said nothing either.

The night air was cold. I leaned lightly against Jeteo's shoulder. He didn't pull away. But he didn't put his arm around me the way he usually did, either. That didn't hurt my feelings. He looked like he didn't even have the strength for it, right then.

I knew what he was holding in. He must have imagined this moment for years. But nowhere in that imagining, I think, was there ever a scene where Father didn't know us.

In the distance, Father was still counting something on his fingers. He didn't seem to be sleeping at all.

Moonlight caught Father's profile. It looked like the silhouette of a stranger. But the line of those shoulders alone was exactly as I remembered. I couldn't tell whether that fact made me glad or sad.

"...How long is that going to keep going?" Jeteo asked quietly. I couldn't tell if he was asking me, or just himself.

I couldn't answer. I didn't know either.

"...Before," Jeteo said again, his voice thick, "stopping that counting was the whole goal, wasn't it. But now — I'm afraid that if it stops, Father might become someone completely different."

Hearing that, I understood how tangled his heart had become. He wanted Father back, and at the same time, he was afraid of losing even this Father in front of him now.

. . .

Temel sat down quietly beside us.

"...I've seen this kind of thing a few times myself," Temel said. "If you force it, try to drag the memory out, it only frightens him more. Just being there beside him comes first."

"...What good does that do?" Jeteo asked. His voice had an edge to it. "He doesn't even know who we are."

"...What good it does, you might learn later, or you might never," Temel said. "But being there beside him — whether he knows you or not — is the one thing you can actually do, right now."

"...But he still doesn't know," Jeteo said again. His voice shook a little. "He doesn't know we're here, right now. He doesn't know what we're holding in."

"...That's true," Temel admitted, readily. "But being there beside someone was never about being noticed for it. It's just being there."

Hearing that, I thought, strangely, of the Ledger's voice. The Ledger never accepted a case it couldn't "resolve." Temel was telling us to stay beside someone even when there was nothing to resolve. That day, for the first time, I thought that difference might be the answer to this whole book.

"...Did you have someone who stayed beside you like this?" I asked.

Temel was silent for a long time, then gave a small nod.

"...I did," Temel said. "If it hadn't been for him, I'd still be running, even now."

"...Did he ever fail to recognize you?" I asked again.

Temel looked at me for a moment. His face was choosing an answer.

"...No," Temel said. "It was the other way around. I was the one who didn't recognize him. More than once."

Hearing that, I felt strangely at ease. It helped to know that failing to recognize the one who stays beside you wasn't something that only happened to our family.

"...When?" Jeteo asked, unable to hide his curiosity.

Temel smiled slightly.

"...Several times," Temel said. "There were times I mistook him for a stranger and kept my guard up. Times he was right in front of me and I still didn't recognize him at all. I only found out later."

"...And even so, he kept staying with you?" I asked.

"...He stayed, whether I recognized him or not," Temel said. "That came first. Not my recognizing him."

I copied those words down on paper that night. I read that sentence over, again and again. Being there before being recognized. I understood barely half of what it meant, then.

That night, for the first time in a while, I took out my paper and wrote down what had happened that day. My hand was cold, and the letters kept shaking. Still, I tried not to leave out a single line. Father, the counting gesture, Temel's words. I wrote it all imagining a day when I might read every bit of it back to Father.

. . .

The next morning, the sun still hung low. Dew clung to every blade of grass. Father was already up, tidying the fire pit. No one had told him to. His body seemed to move on its own.

Watching him, a strange feeling came over me. A man who had forgotten his name, who couldn't recognize us — and yet, come morning, that same hand still knew how to tidy a fire pit. I thought it must be one more trace of Father, left behind inside him.

Jeteo went up to Father.

"...Would you like to come with us?" Jeteo asked carefully. "If you don't know where else to go."

Father looked at Jeteo for a long moment. His eyes were still the eyes of someone looking at a stranger. But there was, just barely, something in them that wasn't wariness.

Father was turning a small twig over in his hand. It looked like a habit — hands that couldn't stay still whenever something made him uneasy. That habit felt strange to me too, and familiar at once.

"...Why are you helping me?" Father asked.

Jeteo was at a loss for a moment. I knew he wanted to say, "Because you're my father." But he chose different words.

"...No reason," Jeteo said. "It's all right to help someone without a reason."

I was startled to hear that answer. In Haven, Jeteo had been someone who believed there was no such thing as helping without a reason. I felt, right then, that he was becoming, little by little, a different person.

Father tilted his head at that answer.

"...That's a strange answer," Father said. But he was smiling. "Though it's a strangeness I don't mind."

Temel was watching from a little way off. I saw the faintest smile cross his face — the look of someone quietly pleased.

. . .

In the end, Father nodded.

Jeteo held out his hand. Father looked at it for a moment, then slowly set his own hand on top of it. It looked less like a handshake than like a gesture of confirming something for the first time.

I stood still, watching those two hands. One was a stranger's hand, and one was a hand we had waited for so long. But in that moment, I couldn't tell which was which.

"...Then... I'll take you up on that," Father said.

I set down those words as the last line of this chapter. Hearing them, I nearly laughed, in a strange way. Father had just told us he'd "take us up on it." For the first time, I understood that becoming someone who walked with us could come before becoming someone who knew us again.

(Continued in Chapter 29.)

Chapter 29. While He Had No Name

Previously — The siblings began learning how to stay beside Father instead of forcing his memory to return. To these strangers, Father said, "I'll take you up on that," and agreed to walk with them.

From that day, the four of us walked together.

The path was often too narrow for four to walk abreast. Even so, we kept close enough to touch, even strung out in a single line. Strangely, I felt a kind of steadiness inside that narrow line.

Father's steps were a little slower than ours — legs that hadn't walked far in a long while. But he never once said it was hard. He would only stop, now and then, and look up at the sky.

Every time, Jeteo matched his pace and stood beside him. I thought it was kindness, but later I saw that Jeteo was every bit as tired as Father. He was simply a boy who had gotten used to hiding it.

Every time the wind blew, the dry grass bent low and rose again. Watching it, I thought the four of us were doing the same — bending and rising, over and over.

Father still counted on his fingers sometimes. But not as constantly as before. I didn't know whether that was a good sign or not.

Every time I saw that gesture, my heart tangled. I wanted it to stop. But at the same time, I was afraid of it stopping too — afraid it might be the only proof left that Father had ever been Father.

Every time Jeteo saw it, he quietly took Father's hand. At first, Father was startled. After a few days, he stopped pulling his hand away.

"...It's strange, holding this hand makes me feel a little at ease," Father said. "I don't know why."

Hearing that, I looked at Jeteo's face. He said nothing. But I saw that his eyes were wet.

I took Father's other hand sometimes too. He always gave it willingly. I noticed the temperature of that hand shifted a little every day. Some days it was cold; some days it was startlingly warm.

I wondered if that shifting warmth had something to do with the state of Father's heart. There was no way to be sure. But every time I held that hand, I felt like I could tell, a little, what kind of day Father had had.

"...Your hand is warm today," I said.

"...Is it?" Father said, looking down at his own hand. "I can't really tell, myself. But if my daughter says so, I suppose it must be."

I heard the word "daughter" for the first time in that sentence. It was the word Father had chosen to explain me. He didn't know my name, but he knew my place. That single fact carried me through the rest of that day.

. . .

"...What should we call you?" Jeteo asked carefully, that first evening.

Father looked flustered by the question.

"...I don't really know, myself," Father said. "I don't think I... have a name."

For a moment, none of us could speak. Then I was the first to say something.

"...Then can we choose one for you? If you remember your real name later, we can change it then."

Father looked at me for a moment. That look carried strangeness, and mixed in with it, something small that resembled trust.

"...Doesn't it feel strange, letting someone else decide your name?" Father asked.

"...It is strange," I said. "But right now, I think strange is just what's normal."

Father smiled a little at that. It looked like a smile I hadn't seen in a long while.

"...I'd like that," Father said.

Jeteo said nothing through the whole exchange. I could feel him turning something over deep in thought.

"...What is it?" I asked.

"...Nothing," Jeteo said. "I was just thinking about what it's like, living without a name. We always had names. I thought that was just how it was."

Hearing that, I thought for the first time about how large a place a name really holds. Having no name wasn't only having no word to be called by. It meant having no way to explain yourself to yourself.

. . .

That night we thought over names. Jeteo couldn't settle on any. I felt like I already knew.

"...How about 'Waiting'?" I said. "There's a name I know — someone whose name carries just that meaning."

Father said the name aloud, a few times, trying it out.

Slowly at first, turning it over in his mouth, then a little faster. Like someone testing whether that sound could belong to him.

"...Waiting," Father said. "That's not bad. Because right now, I really do feel like I'm waiting for something."

"...Waiting for what?" Jeteo asked.

Father thought for a moment, then said:

"...I don't know. But the feeling that I'm waiting for something — that much is certain."

Hearing that answer, I nearly cried. I understood, then. Father had forgotten his name, forgotten faces — but he hadn't forgotten the shape of that one feeling: waiting. I couldn't be certain it was a waiting for us. But I decided to believe it was.

Jeteo said nothing in that moment. But I could tell he was repeating the name to himself, over and over, in his heart. His lips moved silently, shaping those two syllables.

From that day on, we still called him "Father" between ourselves, but in front of other people, we used the name "Waiting." It felt strange at first. Father, too, missed his cue to answer to his new name more than once.

"...Mr. Waiting." When someone we met on the road called him that, Father always reacted a beat late. Every time, Jeteo would give his arm a quiet tap — a signal that meant, that was you being called.

Every time I saw that little tap, I felt strangely at ease. Beside someone who couldn't answer to his own name, there was someone else, sending the signal in his place. I thought that might be needed even before a name.

. . .

Temel walked with us a few more days, then stopped at a fork in the road.

"...I need to take a different road from here," Temel said. "There's someone else, out there, waiting to be found."

"...Thank you," Jeteo said. His voice was sincere.

I looked at Temel's worn pack. It looked lighter than when we'd first met him. I thought it was probably because of everything he'd shared with us along the way.

"...Where will you go now?" I asked.

"...Wherever someone needs me next," Temel said, smiling. "I never know where that is until I get there."

"...Doesn't living like that wear you out?" Jeteo asked.

Temel thought for a moment before answering.

"...It does," Temel said. "But it's better than stopping."

I thought about that answer for a long time. Someone worn out and still not stopping. I'd rarely seen anyone like that, in Brick Hollow or in Haven. Most people, once tired, stopped — or else never came forward in the first place, precisely to avoid growing tired.

Temel looked at us and said one last thing.

"...Until your father finds his real name again, you two hold his place. A person can lose his name and still not lose the place where he's loved."

Father, hearing that, held his hand out to Temel. Temel took it.

"...Thank you," Father said. "For treating me this way, when I don't even know who I am."

"...There's always a reason to treat someone well, even without knowing who he is," Temel said.

With those words, Temel turned and walked off down the other fork. I watched his back grow smaller for a long time. At the last, he turned once and waved. I waved back.

I set down those words as the last line of this chapter. We parted from Temel that day and went on walking, the three of us again. For the first time, I felt this journey's purpose changing — from finding an answer, to holding a place.

(Continued in Chapter 30.)

Chapter 30. The Man Who Came in the Night

Previously — The siblings gave the nameless Father a temporary name — Waiting. Parting from Temel, they heard him say, "A person can lose his name and still not lose the place where he's loved."

That night, Father suddenly woke, shouting.

We had made camp under a small tree that day. We'd walked a long way that afternoon, and everyone fell asleep early. The last thing I remember is counting stars before sleep took me.

Moonlight, filtering down through the leaves, shifted over Father's face. I remember that was the last thing I saw before I slept. He looked peaceful.

Jeteo was already deep asleep beside me. Days of unbroken tension had put him under unusually fast. I remember listening to his breathing before my own eyes slid shut.

"...Where is this! Why am I here!" Father shouted. His eyes were wide open. Even looking straight at us, they recognized nothing at all.

When Jeteo tried to move closer, Father backed away. The motion was so sudden that, for a moment, I was afraid Father had turned into someone else entirely.

I was so frightened in that moment that my body froze. It wasn't Father attacking us that scared me most — it was that look in his eyes, seeing us as complete strangers.

"...It's all right, it's all right," Jeteo said, raising both hands, keeping his voice as low as he could. "We won't hurt you."

Even so, Father couldn't calm down. He kept gasping for breath, looking wildly around him. Watching him, unable to do anything at all, frightened me even more.

I watched him from half-hidden behind Jeteo. In the moonlight, Father's shadow looked unusually large and unsteady. I thought that shadow looked like it belonged to someone else.

For the first time, I understood in my whole body that getting Father back wasn't a single event. The fact that the Father who'd held our hands last night and the Father who couldn't recognize us tonight were the same person frightened me even more.

Jeteo stood still in front of Father, his hands still raised. I watched him frozen there, unable to move forward or back. It was the posture of someone who didn't want to fight, and couldn't run either.

In that moment, I hated how useless I was. All I could do was stand back and look from Jeteo to Father and back again.

. . .

That's when someone came quietly out of the dark.

"...It's all right," said a familiar voice. "Breathe slowly."

I recognized the voice. It was the man from the flowerbed. No — he was just the man now. The one who'd been there in a place no one had planted, the one they said had been seen at the well too.

"...Why are you here..." Jeteo couldn't finish, too startled.

I could hear both surprise and a kind of relief in Jeteo's voice. In that moment he said neither that he was afraid nor that he was glad. But it was probably both.

He made almost no sound as he walked. I had no idea how long he'd been nearby. He appeared as quietly as if he had always been part of the darkness itself.

Without answering, he sat down quietly in front of Father.

There wasn't a trace of hurry in his movements. Strangely, that unhurriedness seemed to settle Father faster than anything else could. As if not hurrying was, itself, a kind of comfort.

. . .

"...Who am I?" Father asked him — a question he hadn't asked us.

A strange hurt came over me right then. He was asking a stranger a question he'd never asked us. Thinking back on it now, it wasn't that Father didn't trust us. It was simply that, with this man, there was nothing at all Father had to prove.

Jeteo was watching quietly beside me too. I could feel him wanting to step in and holding himself back. His hand twitched, again and again, then returned to his side.

"...You don't have to know, right now," he said. "Even without a name, you're here, right now. That's enough."

Father's breathing slowly settled.

I watched that change from where I stood. Seeing the shoulders of someone who had been shouting minutes before slowly settle was like watching a storm pass.

"...Aren't you afraid of me?" Father asked.

"...I'm not afraid," he said. "I've met a great many people who've lost their names."

There was no exaggeration in his voice at all. He said it plainly, the way you'd state a fact. Strangely, that plainness made him feel all the more trustworthy.

"...Did all of them get their names back?" Father asked. There was longing in his voice.

"...Some of them," he said. "Some are still looking, even now. But neither kind was ever truly lost, not even while they were still searching."

Father sat still, seeming to turn the words over. I watched his shoulders lower, little by little. Even without understanding all of what it meant, something in those words was settling him.

Hearing that, I looked at Jeteo. His face held a complicated look — suspicion, and something that couldn't overcome that suspicion, both at once.

He kept speaking to Father, low, on and on. I didn't catch all of it. But the way he spoke was strangely like the way Mother used to speak, putting us to bed back in Brick Hollow.

I couldn't explain that resemblance, then. I still can't explain it exactly, even now. But since that night, I've known that a stranger's voice can carry a kind of familiarity too.

Father's breathing slowly grew slower. I sat beside him, listening quietly to its rhythm. It was a breath so peaceful you'd never have believed it belonged to

someone who, minutes before, had been shouting as though the world were ending.

. . .

After Father had fallen back asleep, Jeteo went up to the man.

"...Who are you, really?" Jeteo asked. His voice had an edge. "Brick Hollow, Haven, now all the way out here... why do you keep showing up?"

He looked at Jeteo for a long moment.

"...I've always been here," he said. "You're the ones who didn't recognize me."

"...What does that mean?"

"...In Brick Hollow, in Haven, and here, now," he said. "I've never once left you."

Jeteo let out a hollow laugh at that.

"...Then why can't you help Father?" Jeteo asked, his voice rising. "Why won't you give him his memory back? You say you've always been here."

He smiled quietly. He didn't answer.

He simply rose and looked up at the night sky for a moment. Starlight passed lightly over his face. Even in that brief instant, I thought I saw something like sorrow in it. I couldn't be certain.

Even now, I can't describe that expression exactly. It wasn't anger. It wasn't sorrow either. But it was, without question, the face of someone who had endured something for a very long time.

Then he turned once to look back at us, and walked back into the darkness he'd come from.

Watching him go, I came and stood beside Jeteo. He said nothing, and stood there a long time.

"...Jeteo," I said quietly.

"...I'm not angry," Jeteo said. But his voice shook, unlike his words. "I just... don't know."

I set down that not-quite-answer as the last line of this chapter. That night, I saw something on Jeteo's face deeper than anger. I thought it was fear. Now I know. It was his certainty, beginning, ever so slowly, to crack.

(Continued in Chapter 31.)

Chapter 31. Humming

Previously — When Father woke in the night in violent confusion, the man from the flowerbed appeared again and calmed him. Jeteo asked him outright who he was, but the only answer that came back was, "I've always been here. You're the ones who didn't recognize me."

By the next morning, the man had vanished without a word.

The moment I opened my eyes, I looked first at the spot where he'd sat. Only a faint press in the grass remained. Not even a clear footprint. So little trace was left that it made me doubt he'd really been there at all.

I put my hand to that spot. It seemed like a little warmth might still be left there. I couldn't be sure.

Jeteo glared at the spot for a long while, then turned away. I felt that he was angry at that absence of any trace, and at the same time, hoping for something — that next time, a little more would be left behind.

"...He just left again," Jeteo said, his voice empty. "Every single time. He shows up, and then — no explanation at all."

I had nothing to say against that. But strangely, his disappearing felt different to me from being abandoned. I couldn't have explained exactly why, then.

Father didn't even remember that the man had come. That saddened me. The very voice that had calmed all of us so completely last night — Father himself didn't hold even a trace of it.

"...Did someone come, last night?" Father asked casually, over breakfast.

Jeteo and I traded a look. We didn't know how to explain it.

"...Yes, briefly," I managed to say.

"...I see," Father said, and nodded. He didn't press further. That indifference was a relief to me, and sad, both at once.

I thought, then — maybe there are things that stay even when they can't be remembered. Like that song.

. . .

That afternoon, Father hummed something low as he walked.

Sunlight fell in dappled patches through the shade of the trees. The wind blew gently. It was that kind of ordinary afternoon. I think it was exactly because it was such an ordinary afternoon that the sound reached me so clearly.

The moment I heard it, I stopped walking. I knew that tune. It was the one Mother used to sing to put us to sleep.

"...Father, what song is that?" I asked, urgent.

Father stopped humming and looked at me. His face was flustered.

"...I don't know," Father said. "It just... came out on its own."

Father touched his own mouth and laughed, as if amazed. It seemed strange even to himself, that his body could remember something before his mind did.

My heart felt like it would burst in that moment. I looked at Jeteo. His face showed that he'd recognized the tune too.

Jeteo stood there, having stopped walking, and couldn't say a word. I saw his lips tremble slightly. He looked like someone who wanted to sing along, and was holding himself back for fear that something might break if he did.

. . .

"...Can you keep singing it?" Jeteo asked. His voice shook.

Father tried to hum it again. But he got stuck after only a few bars.

"...I can't remember what comes next," Father said, his face apologetic.

Father's eyebrows creased faintly. It was the face of someone reaching for something that kept slipping out of his hand. Watching that face hurt me even more than the night he'd shouted.

Jeteo came quietly and sat down beside Father.

"...It's all right," Jeteo said. "It might come again, another time."

Father looked at Jeteo and gave a small nod. I felt that Jeteo was saying those words to himself too.

Watching the two of them, I got up quietly and walked a little way off. I needed a moment to settle my own heart. As I walked, I looked up at the sky. A daytime moon hung there, faint.

"...It's all right," I said. I was crying. "That's enough."

I picked up where it left off and sang the rest myself, exactly the way Mother used to. Father closed his eyes, listening.

My voice shook. The pitch wavered more than once. Still I sang it through to the end. Jeteo came quietly to my side and began humming along. The three of our

voices — or to be precise, our two voices and Father's silence — mixed together into one, right there.

"...It's strange, it settles something in me," Father said. "Even though I don't know whose song it was."

"...It was Mother's song," Jeteo said quietly. It was the first time he had offered that piece of it himself.

Father opened his eyes and looked at Jeteo.

"...Mother." Father repeated the word, quietly. "So there was someone like that."

Hearing that, my heart broke a little. To Father now, Mother was just "someone like that." But even saying it, something in his face looked like longing. His words didn't know her. His heart, it seemed, still did.

In that moment, I thought of that room in Brick Hollow, our last night there, where Mother sang us this same song to sleep. Under the low lamplight, that room where Mother's voice and Father's breathing lay side by side. I felt that memory being completed again, here, now.

In that moment I understood again why I was still keeping this record. This song, this moment — these were things to give back to Father, someday, whenever he returned whole.

That night I tried to write the tune down on paper. But I didn't know how to set a melody down in words. In the end I just wrote this: "Today, Father hummed Mother's song. He couldn't sing it to the end. But he sang it."

Under that sentence, I wrote one line more. "Someday, if Father reads this page, he won't remember today — but he'll know that today happened." Writing that line, I felt certain, for the first time, that this record was not only for me.

Father fell asleep unusually early that night. I couldn't tell whether singing had worn him out, or whether, for once in a long while, he'd simply felt at peace. I watched his sleeping face for a long time. Asleep, if only for those hours, Father looked like a man who had lost nothing at all.

. . .

That night, Jeteo said to me quietly,

"...I still don't really know. Who that man is. Whether I'm supposed to believe in God."

The firelight's shadow flickered over his face. I could tell he was choosing his words more carefully than usual.

"...But?" I asked.

"...But listening to that humming today, just for a moment, I thought this: maybe, the way something still remains inside Father, something remains inside me too. Something not completely erased."

I said nothing and just listened. I felt like if I interrupted, he'd close up again.

"...I don't know what it is yet," Jeteo went on. "But I can feel that it's there. Strange, isn't it."

"...Not strange," I said. "I have that too."

I really did feel that way. I couldn't say exactly what it was, but that certainty — that something in me couldn't be erased either — felt unusually clear to me that day.

Jeteo looked at me. He looked a little surprised.

"...What is it?" he asked.

"...I don't know either," I said, smiling. "But it's there."

Jeteo laughed out loud at that. It was the first time in a long while I'd heard him laugh.

I set down those words as the last line of this chapter. I understood how enormous it was that Jeteo had said that out loud, for the first time — to himself, and to me.

(Continued in Chapter 32.)

Chapter 32. The Light Returns

Previously — Father hummed Mother's lullaby without even realizing it, as he walked — the first fragment of memory left in his body. For the first time, Jeteo said aloud, of himself, "Maybe something inside me hasn't been completely erased either."

A few nights later, that low light appeared in the sky again.

We were crossing a wide-open field that day. There was nowhere fit to hide. The moment that fact struck me, a chill ran down my spine.

We'd nearly forgotten that light in the days since. We'd been consumed with caring for Father, with walking, with simply getting through each day. I realized again that night just how dangerous that forgetting had been.

Jeteo spotted the light first and stopped walking. I watched his whole body go rigid in an instant. The same reaction as weeks before. Only faster this time.

Watching that speed, my heart tangled. It was a relief that Jeteo had gotten better at sensing danger. But at the same time, it meant he was carving that much more fear into his body.

"...The searching light," Jeteo said, low. A familiar fear had returned to his voice.

The moment I saw the light, I checked on Father first. He was just looking up at the sky, not knowing at all what it was.

I envied that ignorance. That single light was enough to drop our hearts through the floor, while Father simply gazed at something curious in the night sky. I

thought, in that moment, that being marked COMPLETE might, in some strange way, be a kind of shield.

"...It's pretty," Father said, innocently. Something about that ached strangely in my chest. Father had no idea at all what that light meant.

Father even lifted his hand and pointed at it. It was as pure a gesture as a child pointing at a star. That purity felt unusually precarious to me, that day of all days.

"...Father, hurry," Jeteo said, pulling urgently at his arm. "Explanations later."

. . .

"...We have to hide," Jeteo said. We ducked quickly behind a low rock. Father crouched down with us too. He couldn't have known the exact reason. But he followed along without question.

That readiness struck me as strange. Two children he'd only just met suddenly seized his arm, and he crouched without a moment's resistance. It was as if some sense for danger, somewhere in his body, was still alive.

The light drew closer and closer. I held my breath.

The cold surface of the rock pressed against my back. That cold gave me something to focus on. I learned, that day, that fear sharpens every single sense in the body.

A strange thought struck me right then. Whether that light was searching for us — or for Father. Father was already someone marked COMPLETE. Did they come searching even for someone already complete?

. . .

The light paused for a moment right above our heads.

That moment felt like forever. Jeteo gripped my hand tight. Father took my other hand too. He didn't know why, but he seemed to sense something dangerous.

I saw the light's color shift, just a little. The white flickered, for a brief instant, into a pale yellow. I didn't know what that meant. I just watched that flicker and held my breath.

I prayed, in my heart, right then. I didn't even know who I was praying to. I just prayed for that light to pass — that one thing, and nothing else.

The light moved again. This time, not toward us — it went off in another direction.

I followed it with my eyes. The light was heading back the way we'd come — toward the spot where we'd rested earlier. I couldn't tell whether that was pure chance, or whether something had turned it that way.

I couldn't breathe properly until the light had completely disappeared. What came before relief was a strange guilt — the thought that the light might be searching for someone else right now instead.

In the stillness of that night, all I could hear, unusually loud, was my own heartbeat. It took a while for it to quiet down.

"...Are you all right?" Jeteo asked me. Only then did I realize I was shaking.

"...Yeah," I said. It was a lie. Jeteo's face showed he knew it was a lie too. But he just squeezed my hand once more.

Father sat quietly between us. He didn't know exactly what had happened, but his face knew it had been something serious. He set a careful hand on my

shoulder. I still remember, even now, how much comfort the weight of that hand was, in that moment.

. . .

We stayed crouched there a good while longer. Cramps started in our legs, but none of us was the first to say we should move. I don't think that silence was only fear. All three of us, I think, were being careful — afraid something might change if this moment stretched on a little further.

After the light was gone, Jeteo said, low,

"...We really do need to get far away from Haven now. Even out here is inside that eye's reach, it seems."

"...Go where?" I asked.

"...Anywhere," Father put in carefully. "As long as I'm not a burden."

Father watched our faces carefully as he said it. That wariness felt strange to me. Father had never been the kind of man to watch for other people's moods like that. Not the Father I remembered, at least.

Jeteo thought for a moment, then said,

"...I don't know. But we have to keep walking. You, us — staying here is dangerous for all of us."

I saw the old, certain look on Jeteo's face again. That was the face he'd worn leading us, back when we left Haven, back when we left Brick Hollow. I was glad to see it, and worried, too, that he was trying to shoulder everything alone again.

"...You don't have to decide this by yourself," I said.

Jeteo looked at me. His face was startled, briefly.

"...I know," Jeteo said. "But someone has to say which way to go."

"...Then let's say it together," I said.

Jeteo looked at me and smiled, small. That smile carried relief, and mixed in with it, a lightness that felt a little unfamiliar.

Hearing that, Father asked quietly,

"...Am I a burden?"

Father's voice was calm. But behind that calm was the look of someone bracing for something. Seeing his face, my heart dropped.

Jeteo looked at Father, startled by the question.

"...No," Jeteo said firmly. "You're not a burden. We're going together."

I took Father's hand too.

"...That's right," I said. "Don't ever say the word 'burden' again."

Father looked from one of us to the other and gave a small nod. It wasn't quite the face of someone who fully believed it. Still, in that moment, he didn't press any further.

A night wind blew, stirring all three of our clothes. Even inside that wind, I felt that the hands we held onto each other stayed perfectly still.

Father smiled quietly, hearing it. A smile I hadn't seen before — relief and shyness mixed together.

"...Thank you," Father said. It was a short thing to say. But I could feel the weight carried inside it.

I set down those words as the last line of this chapter. I saw that Jeteo looked startled by his own words, even as he said them. It seemed like he was saying them to himself, at the same time as he said them to Father.

(Continued in Chapter 33.)

Chapter 33. A Night on the Run

Previously — The searching light appeared again. It passed them by, thankfully, but guilt lingered behind that relief. When Father asked, "Am I a burden?" Jeteo answered, "We're going together."

Two nights later, this time it wasn't a light that came, but people.

That day had been unusually peaceful. Father even picked a small wildflower growing by the roadside and handed it to me. It was only later that the fact that such peace had given no warning at all of that evening felt more frightening still.

Jeteo had been unusually on edge from early that evening. He stopped and looked back, again and again. I thought it was just habit. Looking back on it now, I think he must already have sensed something.

Father, too, had been unusually quiet that day. I still wonder, even now, whether that was pure coincidence, or whether all three of us had somehow already sensed it coming.

Footsteps. Several of them. We hurried to hide ourselves behind dry brush.

I gripped Father's hand as hard as I could, right then. I wanted him to understand that we had to stay quiet. But the unfamiliar sound frightened him instead, and his body began to shake.

The brush's dry branches brushed our clothes and rustled. Even that small sound felt too loud to me, and I even breathed carefully.

Voices came to us. Low, businesslike.

Their shadows stretched long under the moonlight. I counted them. Three.

"...They said there was a reading around here?"

"...Two candidates for Reassignment review. And there's a report that one COMPLETE record has strayed."

My body froze the moment I heard that. I understood that "one COMPLETE record has strayed" meant Father. For the first time, I felt in my whole body that even Father, to this city, was not a person but an entry.

I glanced sideways at Father's face. He didn't understand the meaning of that conversation at all — he simply held our hands tight. I thought his not knowing was, if anything, a mercy. If Father had known he was being called a "strayed record," he wouldn't have been able to bear it.

. . .

"...Shh." Jeteo carefully covered Father's mouth with his hand, as gently as he could. "You have to be quiet. Please."

Father nodded, eyes wide. He didn't know why, but he seemed to sense the danger.

Father's hand kept gripping mine tight. I felt a faint tremor in it. A body that had forgotten its name, forgotten faces, still remembered fear whole and entire.

I wanted to calm that trembling. But I was shaking too, and I couldn't tell any more who was calming whom.

The footsteps drew closer and closer. Three people in Haven uniforms passed by. Each carried some bright instrument in hand.

Their pace wasn't hurried at all. That very unhurriedness frightened me more. It was the walk of people certain they would find us in the end.

I didn't know what the instrument was. But I knew it was meant to find us.

Jeteo gave me a slight push, tucking me behind him. Even in that moment, it was a gesture that put me first. I was used to that gesture, but that day it ached in a way I hadn't felt before.

From behind Jeteo's back, I gripped Father's hand tighter too. The three of us were strung together in a line like that. I understood, in that moment, that there was nothing at all left for us to do except hold on to each other.

I knew Jeteo was afraid too. But he was trying to carry all of that fear by himself. The way he always had.

I looked at Jeteo's back. His shoulders, holding his breath, trembled faintly. Seeing that, I reached out and lightly caught the hem of his shirt. I didn't say anything. I just wanted him to know I was here too.

. . .

One of them stopped right in front of the brush where we hid.

Time seemed to stop right there. I was afraid the sound of my own heartbeat would carry outside my body. I could feel sweat rising on Jeteo's hand too.

I squeezed my eyes shut in that moment and thought of our last night in Brick Hollow — the night we held our breath, hiding from the taskmasters' footsteps. That night and this one felt exactly the same. We were still surviving the same way.

I thought my breath would stop. Jeteo pulled Father closer, holding him tighter.

The person shone the instrument toward the brush. Light swept past right beside us.

I even had the illusion that the light was brushing my skin. It wasn't hot or cold — but every hair on my body stood on end.

I squeezed my eyes shut in that moment. For the first time in my life, I prayed something — not in words, just in my heart. I didn't even know whether it was a prayer. I just prayed.

In that brief instant, every one of them came back to me at once — the nights in Brick Hollow, the alleys of Haven, all the nights we'd ever run. We had always been hiding from something. I couldn't have imagined, in that moment, when it would ever end.

I understood something strange, then. We had always been running from something. But even inside that running, we had kept holding on to each other, all along. For the first time, it occurred to me that maybe that wasn't running at all. That maybe it was something else.

The person soon turned and walked off in another direction.

Even then, I couldn't open my eyes. Only after the footsteps had faded completely did I open them, carefully. My fingertips were numb and tingling. I'd been gripping too hard, for too long.

. . .

Even after the footsteps had completely faded, we couldn't move from that spot for a long while.

My legs had gone numb, and I couldn't stand. Jeteo seemed the same — he didn't get up right away either, just sat there among the brush. Father was the

first to pull himself together, and he helped the two of us to our feet.

Father's hand felt unusually steady in that moment. He had no memory left. But his body still knew how to lift his children up.

Jeteo finally let out a breath and looked up at the sky.

"...Where are you," Jeteo said, low but clear. I knew who he was speaking to.

"You don't show up for this, but you showed up back then?"

There was no answer. The night sky was just the night sky.

Father watched him quietly. He couldn't have understood any of it. And yet he came and stood beside Jeteo and set a quiet hand on his shoulder. Jeteo didn't shake it off.

Watching that hand, I felt a strange comfort. A man who had lost his name, lost his memory, still knew how to set one hand beside someone breaking under an answer that never came. I thought that might be the deepest thing left inside Father.

I watched the two silhouettes for a long time. A son who'd gotten no answer, and a father who couldn't even understand the question, standing side by side. And strangely, that picture didn't feel only sad to me.

I set down that silence as the last line of this chapter. I understood how fair Jeteo's question was. I couldn't give him an answer. No one could. But even inside that silence, I held on to one single fact — that we were still alive.

(Continued in Chapter 34.)

Chapter 34. The Wrong Direction

Previously — A Haven search party actually came after the siblings. After the danger passed, Jeteo asked the night sky, "You don't show up for this, but you showed up back then?" — but only silence answered.

The next day, we started walking again, as quietly as we could.

We'd all barely slept, and it showed in our hollow eyes. I flinched at every footstep sound the whole way. Even the snap of a twig made me jump, more than once.

The sky was just as clear as the day before. That clarity felt strangely foreign to me. The world went on as if it had no idea at all what had happened to us the night before.

For the first time, I thought about the world's indifference. Even the night we held our breath and came so close to something like death — to the sky, it was just one more night passing. That indifference felt unfair to me, and at the same time, strangely comforting. Because it also meant the world wasn't singling us out.

Jeteo barely spoke all that day. I didn't want to disturb him, so I just walked beside him.

I understood that his silence was tied to last night's question. I learned, that day, that a question with no answer stays on as silence, in place of an answer.

Every so often I saw Jeteo glance up at the sky. He looked like he was searching for something, and also like he was resenting something. I didn't ask.

Father was unusually bright that day, of all days. I didn't know why. He just said he liked walking. I envied that brightness. Since Father remembered nothing, by morning even last night's terror seemed almost entirely forgotten.

Father found a small insect by the road and crouched there watching it for a long while. That sight struck me as strange, and, somewhere in it, lovely too. Father looked like someone entirely present in this one moment.

Jeteo watched him from a little way off, then said to me, quietly,

"...Father seems a lot freer than we are," Jeteo said. "Because he has no memory."

I didn't know how to answer that. His words felt both right and wrong to me.

For the first time, I thought forgetting might not only be a curse. It was a strange thought. I didn't hold on to it for long.

As he walked, Father tapped stones along the road with the toe of his shoe. A childlike gesture. Watching it, I'd laugh, and then, right after, some corner of my heart would ache.

I didn't understand that ache until late that evening. Father wasn't becoming more and more of a stranger. He was growing up again, alongside us. It felt strange to me that both of those things could be happening at once.

. . .

In the afternoon, we met a merchant coming from the opposite direction. He spoke to us first.

He carried a large pack on his back — the kind of man who sold goods, moving from one area to another. I could see, in his clothes, the fatigue of a long-

traveling life.

"...This area was in an uproar last night," the merchant said. "I heard the search party was chasing someone and ended up completely off track."

"...Off track?" Jeteo asked, ears pricking up.

His voice cracked, faintly. I knew that hearing this, he'd gone straight back to last night.

"...Yeah. Some old man supposedly pointed them the wrong way. And when they went to look for him afterward, he'd disappeared too, they say. It's going around as a strange story among their people."

The moment I heard that, I looked at Jeteo. He looked at me too. Neither of us said anything, but I knew we were thinking the same thing.

The merchant, not noticing the change in our faces, went on talking.

"...Funny thing is, there wasn't a single trace where the old man vanished. Not even a footprint." The merchant shrugged. "People are saying all kinds of things about it."

"...What did the old man look like?" Jeteo asked, unable to hold back.

The merchant shrugged.

"...I only heard it secondhand, so I don't know. Just that he was wearing worn-out clothes, that's all I heard."

That description was so plain it made me even more certain. Nothing flashy, nothing special about it. It was exactly how the man we knew looked.

That answer alone was enough. I could see in Jeteo's face that he thought so too. For the first time, I felt some corner of my heart warm at the thought of that

man in worn clothes, moving on our behalf. I learned, that day, that fear and gratitude could live in the same place at once.

Before the merchant left, he added one more thing, to us.

"...You take care too. People around here have been on edge lately."

We nodded. That parting word didn't sound like something tossed off in passing to me — it sounded like real concern.

. . .

After the merchant left, Jeteo was quiet for a long time before he spoke.

"...Was it him?"

His voice held both certainty and resistance at once. I felt that he wanted to admit it, and at the same time, feared that admitting it might change something.

"...I don't know," I said. But in my heart, I was already almost certain.

"...Then why doesn't he just say so from the start?" Jeteo asked, his voice mixed with frustration. "Then I wouldn't have to keep getting angry like this, every time."

I didn't know the answer to that. But a strange thought came to me, then. Maybe telling us ahead of time would be worth less than walking through the fear together.

"...And," Jeteo added, low, "being angry is exhausting too. But if I don't even get angry, I don't know what I'm supposed to do instead."

I couldn't answer that. I just walked quietly beside him. I learned again, that day, that some silences are better than any answer.

. . .

Father, listening quietly to the conversation, asked,

"...Who is he?"

Jeteo couldn't answer the question right away. After a long while, he said,

"...I don't really know either," Jeteo said. "But... it seems like he's always around us somehow. Without ever explaining."

He looked startled by his own words, even as he said them. That was the first time I'd heard him admit it like that.

Father gave a small laugh at that.

"...Then he's a bit like me," Father said. "I can't explain who I am either, and yet here I am."

Jeteo stopped, hearing that. I watched him start to say something and swallow it back.

"...Yeah," Jeteo said at last. His voice was low. "A bit like you."

Father, hearing that answer, gave Jeteo's shoulder a light pat. He didn't say anything more. But that one gesture was enough for the moment.

In that short answer, I felt that Jeteo had set something down, a little. He hadn't let go of the anger entirely. But it seemed like some other place had opened up beside it.

We walked late into that evening. We didn't stop until the sun had gone all the way down. That night, I noticed Jeteo spent a little longer looking up at the sky than he had before.

I set down those words as the last line of this chapter. In that moment I saw an expression on Jeteo's face I'd never seen before. It wasn't anger. It wasn't certainty either. It was simply the face of someone who had opened his heart, just a little.

(Continued in Chapter 35.)

Chapter 35. He Called My Name

Previously — From the merchant they heard about an old man who had led the Haven search party the wrong way. Without a word, the siblings were both certain who it was. At Father's offhand remark, an expression appeared on Jeteo's face for the first time that was neither anger nor certainty.

A few days later, we were resting by a small stream.

The water ran low and quiet. Sunlight broke into small pieces across its surface. I watched that shimmer for a long time. It was the first peaceful afternoon we'd had, after days of walking as though something were chasing us.

Jeteo sat with his feet in the water, eyes closed. Watching him, I saw the tension leave his face for the first time in a long while. Father was washing his hands a little way off.

Father, washing his hands, suddenly called out to me.

"...Elpis."

My whole body froze in that instant. Jeteo's did too.

The water kept flowing. But even that sound seemed, to me, to stop for a moment. It felt as if every sound in the world had given way to that one name.

We'd told Father my name many times over these days. But that had only ever been introducing myself. This was different. Father had called me. The difference might not have looked like much, but to me it was as large as the whole world.

Jeteo stood frozen too, looking at me. Neither of us could say a word. Only the sound of the water filled the silence between us.

Inside that silence, I watched Jeteo's eyes waver, little by little. His eyes hadn't decided yet whether to be glad, or to be tangled up over the fact that his own name still hadn't come.

. . .

Father looked startled at his own words, as if they'd surprised him too.

Father stayed frozen there, hand still raised. Water dripped from his fingertips, drop by drop. He didn't even seem to notice.

"...What... did I just say?" Father asked.

"...My name," I managed to say. My voice shook. "You called my name."

My voice was shaking as much as Father's was. I didn't try to hide it. There was no reason to.

Father touched his own mouth with his hand, as if trying to check where the word had come from.

"...How did I know that," Father murmured. "It just... came out on its own."

His eyes held bewilderment, and mixed in with it, something that seemed almost too much to hold. I thought that expression looked like the face of someone whose long-locked door had opened just a crack.

I looked at Jeteo in that moment. He stood there, unable to say a word. I saw tears well up in his eyes for the first time.

I went to Father and took his hand.

I looked into Father's eyes. They were still strange eyes. But inside that strangeness, something very small seemed to be nestled there — something that knew me.

"...Say it again," I said.

"...Elpis." Father said it again. This time with certainty. Tears filled his eyes.

"Elpis, Elpis..."

Father repeated that name over and over, like a song he'd just learned. His voice trembled more with every repetition. Inside that trembling, I thought I heard something like a very old lock turning open, little by little.

That name reached past being just my name — it sounded like something Father was saying to himself. As if he were gripping that one name and struggling to find his way back to himself.

I wrapped Father's hand in both of mine, right then. It was still wet, and cold. I welcomed even that cold. It was a living hand.

Father closed his eyes as he said my name. Behind those closed eyes, I sensed him struggling hard to hold on to something — something like the fraying, almost-severed end of a thread of memory.

. . .

I closed my eyes for a moment, right there. A memory rose up — our last night in Brick Hollow, Father lifting me up, calling my name. I felt that memory and this moment lay over each other.

"...What about me?" Jeteo asked, his voice trembling. "Do you know my name too?"

Father looked at him for a long time. His face was that of someone reaching for something just out of grasp.

Father's lips moved, several times. No sound came. He looked like someone who had opened a drawer, only to find it empty.

"...I'm sorry," Father said. "That one... hasn't come yet."

I could hear how truly sorry his voice was. I hoped that sorrow might offer Jeteo some small comfort.

Jeteo's face fell. I watched his disappointment plainly. In that brief moment, I couldn't read every feeling passing through his eyes — disappointment, something like shame, and the effort of trying hard to press both of them down.

But strangely, he smiled.

"...It's all right," Jeteo said. "My name can come later. Right now... it's enough that Elpis's name came out."

His voice shook, but it didn't waver. I could tell that steadiness wasn't something he'd forced out of himself — he really did feel that way.

I was startled to hear that. For the first time, I watched Jeteo accept someone else's joy before his own. In Brick Hollow, in Haven, he had never been someone who looked out for his own share first. But that wasn't because he couldn't take care of himself — it was because he was someone who took care of others first. I confirmed that fact again, that day.

Father went to Jeteo and wrapped an arm around his shoulders. It was an awkward gesture. But Jeteo didn't shy away from that awkward embrace.

. . .

That night, Jeteo said to me quietly,

"...I've been gathering evidence this whole time. To protect the name, to remember. But today I understood. What's coming back inside Father — it wasn't because I gathered evidence. It was just... because we were beside him."

"...So evidence doesn't matter anymore?" I asked.

"...No," Jeteo said. "It still matters. But now I know. Evidence alone wouldn't have been enough. Being beside him had to be there too."

I thought of the worn scraps of paper he'd carried close to his chest all this time — the evidence he'd gathered since Brick Hollow. I felt that he was learning to hold something else alongside them, without ever letting them go.

I moved a little closer and sat beside him. He put his arm around my shoulders. A familiar weight I hadn't felt in a while.

I sat quietly beside him. Night insects called somewhere in the distance. Listening to them, I felt anew how enormous a day this had been for us.

The campfire's embers crackled and faded, little by little. Listening to that sound, I felt the day's afterglow still lingering somewhere in my body.

"...Jeteo," I said.

"...Yeah?" he answered.

"...I believe Father will call your name too, someday," I said.

Jeteo looked at me and smiled quietly. He said nothing. But that smile was his answer.

I set down those words as the last line of this chapter. That night, I watched Jeteo hold two things together for the first time — keeping, and staying beside. I

didn't know exactly, then, that this was his first step toward trust.

(Continued in Chapter 36.)

Chapter 36. A Place to Plant

Previously — Father, for the first time, spoke Elpis's name of his own accord. Jeteo realized it hadn't come back because they gathered evidence, but because they had stayed beside him — and began holding keeping and staying beside together.

"...Where should we go now?" Jeteo asked one evening. It was a question for Father as much as for me.

We were watching the sunset from atop a small hill that day. Watching the sky turn red, I thought, for the first time, that even this journey needed an evening — not more walking, but an evening to stop, just for a while, and decide where to go.

Walking on and on as though we were fleeing had its limits. Father still tired easily, and still couldn't rest fully at ease, even by night.

I studied Father's face. He'd filled out a little since we first found him. But his eyes still held a searching kind of unease. I thought that unease wouldn't fully lift until we had a place, before we ever had an answer.

I felt, then, that what we needed was no longer an answer, but a place. Not a direction to walk toward, but somewhere to put down roots.

I read back over the record I'd been keeping. From our last night in Brick Hollow up to now, page after page was filled. I felt anew how few answers were in that record. But it held more than answers. It held the days we had walked together.

I turned the pages one by one. The night we met Temel, the night we found Father, the counting gesture, the humming, the searching light, the night we ran, and this morning at the stream, my name being called. On every one of those pages, I saw traces of tears and traces of laughter left behind together.

I understood, then. This record had started as something meant to gather evidence — but somewhere along the way, it had become something else. A record that held on to the plain fact that we had walked together.

Jeteo glanced over my shoulder at the pages.

"...Is that all our story?" he asked.

"...Yeah," I said. "Not all of it — just as much as I could remember."

"...Can I read it too, sometime?" he asked. His voice was uncharacteristically careful.

"...Of course," I said. "It's partly yours anyway."

. . .

"...What if we went back to Speon's?" I said. "That well wasn't dangerous. And Speon... he was alone too."

Saying it, I pictured Speon's well — quiet, unhurried, a place with nothing in it but the low voices of people drawing water. I realized anew that it had been the least threatening place we'd found, in all the time since we first fled.

Jeteo turned the thought over.

"...That doesn't sound bad," Jeteo said. "We need help, and Speon needs help too."

Father asked quietly,

"...If we go there... would it be all right for me to be there too?"

There was still that same carefulness in Father's voice. It didn't feel strange to me any more. It had simply become part of who Father was.

Jeteo looked straight at Father.

"...Of course," Jeteo said. This time there was no hesitation at all.

I noticed how quickly that answer came. Back in Chapter 32, faced with the same question, Jeteo had thought for a long while before he answered. This time it was instant. I thought that whole distance he'd walked was folded into that one short gap of time.

. . .

We started walking south again, toward Speon's well.

The way back felt shorter than the way we'd first set out. It wasn't only that we knew the road.

On that road, I passed the same landscapes again — the rock where we'd hidden, the brush where we'd held our breath, the fork where we'd met the merchant. The same scenery, and yet it looked completely different. Places we'd crossed in fear before, we simply walked through, this time.

I thought, then — even the same road can become a different road the second time you walk it. Maybe this whole journey we've walked would look completely different too, someday, looking back on it.

Speon looked startled to see us. And more startled still, seeing Father.

"...You found him," Speon said. There was real gladness in his voice.

The bucket in Speon's hand stopped, still, mid-motion. I could feel how startled he was, in that frozen gesture.

"...Yes," Jeteo said. "But not completely found. We're still finding him."

I copy down Jeteo's words here exactly. He had learned, now, to tell "found" apart from "still finding."

Speon drew Father a bowl of water. Father drank it, looking around at the well.

Father's hand, holding that bowl, trembled faintly. Whether that was because it was water after such a long walk, or for some other reason, I couldn't tell.

"...It's strange, this place feels at ease," Father said.

"...That makes sense," Speon said quietly. "This is just the kind of place it is."

Speon ran his hand over an old stone beside the well.

"...I didn't keep this well alone," Speon said. "There were people who passed through before me. What they left behind is still here."

Hearing that, I thought of that leaf in the flowerbed — the one that had grown where no one planted it. I thought this world might hold more than one place like that.

. . .

That evening, I planted a few seeds in a small patch of ground beside the well. The leaf I'd brought from that flowerbed in Haven had dried up long ago. But I still remembered the hands that had given me the seed, right there.

The soil was soft. I dug small holes with my fingertips, dropped in the seeds one by one, and covered them again. Repeating that simple motion, I felt, strangely, my heart settle.

Jeteo watched from a little way off, then came closer.

"...Can I plant one too?" he asked.

I handed him a seed. He dug into the soil, clumsy about it. That clumsiness was, oddly, welcome to me. It meant he wanted to plant something in this place as much as I did.

Father sat beside us, watching.

"...What are you planting?" Father asked.

"...I don't know yet," I said. "But if I plant it, I suppose I'll find out eventually."

Father turned that answer over quietly. That silence felt comfortable to me. A silence it was all right to sit in, even without knowing the answer.

Father smiled quietly at that.

"...I think I'm a bit like that too," Father said. "I don't know yet what's inside me. But I know something's been planted."

Jeteo, hearing that, came and sat down beside us. The three of us looked down together at the freshly turned soil. There was nothing to see there. And yet I could believe something was inside it.

"...You know what?" Jeteo said quietly. "I never used to believe in anything I couldn't see."

"...And now?" I asked.

He looked down at the soil for a while before answering.

"...I still don't believe all of it, even now. But that something's been planted — that, I want to try to believe."

Hearing that, I looked up at the sky, where stars were rising one by one. Somewhere up there, I thought, that man who had led our pursuers the wrong way was probably still walking. For the first time, that day, I found myself wanting to call him by some other name instead of just "he." I still didn't know what that name was.

Speon called to us from a distance, telling us to come eat. We got up. Father held out his hand first and pulled me to my feet, and Jeteo took his other hand. I looked down for a moment at the shape those three hands made, joined together.

I set down those words as the last line of this Part. That evening we made our place at Speon's well. The answers still hadn't all come. Neither had the name, nor Jeteo's certainty — not yet, not all the way. But that day, for the first time, I knew we had found somewhere to put down roots.

(Continued in Part Four.)

The Weeping Ledger, Part Four

By the Well

Chapter 37. Days by the Well

Previously — Feeling that what they needed was not an answer but a place, the siblings returned to Speon's well and settled there. Elpis planted the seed again, and Father said, "I know it's planted."

That was how we began to live by the well.

A low stone wall ran around the well. Grass with no name I knew grew in the cracks between the stones. Dew gathered on its leaves every morning. I formed a habit of touching that dew with my fingertip once, every time I went to draw water.

There was a small hut by the well. Speon had used it for a long time. We built a small place beside it and lived there. It was smaller than our house in Brick Hollow. Strangely, I didn't mind the smallness at all.

We had almost no belongings. What we'd carried out of Haven, and a few things Father owned — that was all. My brother never once complained about how little that was. I knew that the old him would have called even that unfair. Not anymore.

Day to day, little changed. In the morning we drew water, walked with Father, and in the evening I set down the record. At first the sameness felt strange to me. Haven, and the road we'd fled along — those had always been time spent running from something.

I learned then, for the first time, how precious an ordinary day is. I hadn't known in Brick Hollow how rare a gift a day with nothing happening in it could be.

The morning routine was simple. Draw water, take Father's hand and walk once around the well, and in the evening write a short account of what had happened that day. At first, that writing felt like homework to me. But after a few days, it stopped being homework and became a way of holding on to the day.

Speon taught us the rules of the well, one at a time. Always hang the bucket in the same place. Don't question someone newly arrived — give them water first. I felt that these rules were nothing like the rules of Haven. Haven's rules had been made for intake. These rules were made for people.

Father got a little better. He still didn't know my brother's name. But during the day he began, in small bursts, trying to do things himself. Drawing water, moving stones. No one had to tell him to.

Father didn't sleep well at night. He woke often, and when he woke he sat without speaking for a long while. I went and sat beside him every time. I said nothing. We simply looked at the dark together. I thought that was all I could do. Later I learned it wasn't just all I could do — it was the most important thing.

"...It's easier when I'm doing something," Father said. "When I'm moving."

I heard that and thought of the Father of Brick Hollow. Those hands had always been moving too. I felt, in that moment, that something inside Father was returning before his name did.

. . .

My brother began helping Speon look after the well. He mended the bucket, repaired the stone wall, and took turns with Speon keeping watch at night.

"...Why are you helping with this?" I asked.

"...Speon's been doing this alone a long time," my brother said. "I think I understand now. Why waiting becomes a kind of work."

Hearing that, I knew my brother had begun to understand Speon's life. It wasn't an understanding he'd arrived at by getting an answer. It was an understanding he'd gotten by doing the work himself.

My brother's hands had gone rough in those few weeks. Calluses were starting to form where the bucket rope wore against his palms. Every time I saw those hands I thought of his hands carrying bricks in Brick Hollow. Back then those hands had moved to dodge a taskmaster's whip. Now these hands moved without anyone telling them to. I kept that difference close.

While teaching my brother how to care for the bucket, Speon sometimes let slip pieces of old stories — how he'd once been too afraid, and had fled leaving someone behind. My brother didn't press him for more. He just listened.

"...Why don't you ask?" Speon asked.

"...I've learned lately that it's better to talk about things when you want to," my brother said.

Speon looked at him for a long time after that.

"...You seem like a different person than you were a few months ago," Speon said.

"...I feel that way sometimes too," my brother said. "But I couldn't tell you exactly what's changed."

I listened to that conversation beside them and looked at my brother again. I couldn't put my finger on the exact day this had started. Some

changes come that way. Not overnight, but the way water soaks in.

That evening, Speon taught my brother how to measure the depth of the well — tying knots one by one into a rope, and counting how many knots down the water began. My brother practiced it over and over until he had it. In that repetition, I felt that something in my brother's whole posture toward learning had changed. Before, he would have asked why he had to learn it first. Now he just learned.

. . .

One night, there was a sound at the well.

It was an unusually quiet night. No wind. In that stillness, the sound made me think, for a moment, of our last night in Brick Hollow. I realized then that memory was still living somewhere in my body.

The sound woke Father too. He walked toward the well a little after us, but with a steady step. Watching that step, I felt that Father no longer ran from unfamiliar sounds.

The four of us ran toward it at the same time. A woman was trembling, having just climbed out of the bottom of the well. Her eyes held nothing in them.

My brother reached her first.

"...It's all right," my brother said. It was the very voice we had once heard from Father. "Breathe slowly. You're safe here."

Watching that, I stopped breathing for a moment. Only months ago, this had been the place my brother feared most. Now he stood there, the calmest person in it.

I sat quietly beside the woman and held out the water jar. Her hands were shaking too badly to take it. I held it for her instead and let the water trickle in a little at a time. This was what we had done, when Father first found us.

Speon only watched from a distance. He didn't step forward. I understood then why he had been able to keep this well for so long. He wasn't a man who stepped forward every time — he was a man who knew how to step forward only when it was needed.

. . .

The woman stayed by the well for several days, and then remembered part of her name. Not all of it. But she wept and laughed at once, over even that much.

For days she barely spoke. But every morning she came out on her own to fill her water jar. I already knew, from watching Father, that this small movement was the beginning of recovery.

Speon called her simply "our guest," instead of a name. At first I thought that was impolite. Later I understood. Speon was refusing to define her by any name until she found her own.

The night before she left, she pressed a small stone into my hand. She didn't explain why. I didn't ask and just took it. I still have that stone.

Before I fell asleep that night, I thought for a moment of the day we first arrived at the well. Everything had been unfamiliar then. Now the sound of the bucket, the sound of Speon's footsteps, had all become familiar. I didn't know when that familiarity had begun. But that it had begun — that much was certain.

That night, my brother said to me:

"...I still don't know who that man is. I can't even say I believe in God. But watching that woman today, I knew something. I know how to be beside someone now. That much, I'm sure of."

I set that down as the last line of this chapter. I knew that my brother still couldn't use the word faith. But he was already doing what faith does. I decided not to think that order was strange.

(Continued in Chapter 38.)

Chapter 38. Mena Came

Previously — Life settled in at the well. Helping Speon tend it, my brother learned how to be beside someone. "I can't say I believe in God. But I know how to be beside someone."

About a month in, one day, a familiar figure came walking from far off.

It was Mena. She had her record box slung over her shoulder, the same as always.

The record box had grown much thicker than before. Paper stuck out past its edges. Mena's shoes were caked with mud. It showed, how far she'd walked.

The wind stirred the grass around the well lightly. I was the first to see a shadow appear beyond that grass. At first I didn't know who it was. Only once the gait grew familiar did I know it was Mena.

I ran the moment I saw her. Mena remembered us. And then she saw Father and stopped walking.

"...Did you come to bring news to Speon?" I asked.

"...That too," Mena said. Her face colored a little. "And I wanted news of you all."

"...How long did it take you to get here?" I asked.

"...About ten days," Mena said. "I had to stop by a few places along the way. But I didn't feel tired. I was curious what I'd find here."

"...What did you think you'd find?" I asked.

Mena thought for a moment.

"...I don't know," Mena said. "I just wanted to see with my own eyes how you all were living here. There's something a written name alone doesn't give you."

I didn't understand right away what she meant. But over the next few days, I came to understand. For Mena, a name was only a beginning. Seeing how that name went on living — that was what Mena really wanted to do.

I took Mena's hand. Her fingertips were cracked. I could guess, from that, how many names she had written on her way here.

. . .

"...Is this..." Mena couldn't finish.

"...Yes," my brother said. "We found him. His name hasn't all come back yet."

Mena's eyes filled with tears. I had never seen Mena show emotion like this before. She had always been someone who wrote names down calmly. In that moment, for the first time, I understood that calm hadn't been indifference.

Mena carefully took Father's hand. Father didn't pull away. Even though it was an unfamiliar hand, he stayed still.

"...It's very rare for one of the names I've recorded to be met again like this," Mena said. "Thank you, for not giving up."

"...It's thanks to you, Mena," my brother said. "If you hadn't recorded his name, we would have kept wandering for nothing."

Mena shook her head.

"...I only wrote it down," Mena said. "You're the ones who walked here."

My brother shook his head at that.

"...If you hadn't written it down, we wouldn't even have known where to go," my brother said. "I don't think that's a small thing."

Mena went quiet for a moment at that. I saw something in her face come loose, something that had been held down a long time.

Father stood beside them, looking quietly at Mena. His face didn't quite remember who she was. But he wasn't wary of her, either.

"...Do you know me?" Father asked carefully.

"...We crossed paths once, a long time ago," Mena said. "You didn't know me then. I didn't know you well either. But I wrote your name down."

Father nodded at that. It wasn't a face of understanding so much as one that simply accepted it.

I watched that short exchange and thought: how many of the names Mena has carried ever get to see this face-to-face meeting again? I didn't know the answer. But looking at Mena's eyes, I knew she was someone who would keep writing regardless of the answer.

. . .

Speon heard the news and came running out of the well. The moment he saw Mena, he stopped.

The two of them said nothing for a while.

In that silence, I watched Speon's face. He always kept a calm face at the well. Not in that moment. I saw something old shift there.

"...You said you were still waiting," Mena spoke first.

"...Yes," Speon said. "That still holds."

Mena laughed at that answer. I couldn't tell if the laugh was relief or something else. Speon laughed along too. Their two laughs looked alike.

In that short exchange, I felt how much time had passed. I still didn't know what had happened between the two of them. But that day, for the first time, I decided not to ask. I had learned that some stories deserve to be respected without explanation.

Mena stayed at the well for several days after that. I caught myself secretly watching, more than once, how she and Speon sat side by side filling water jars. The two of them didn't say much. But the silence was unlike any silence I'd seen before.

During the day, Mena still opened her record box and wrote things down — names of newly met people, the things they'd lost. I peeked at those pages beside her. Short single lines were written next to the names. "Looking for a daughter." "Hurt her hand, can't use it yet." I understood that these short sentences were how Mena saw the world. Not resolution. Remembrance.

In the evenings, Mena sometimes showed the box to Speon. He turned the pages one by one, and when he found a name he knew, he tapped it with a

fingertip. That looked nothing like any scene we'd seen in Haven. The Ledger erased names from a screen. Mena left names on paper.

One evening, I sat beside Mena and turned through the papers in that box with her.

"...Do you have all this memorized?" I asked.

"...Not all of it," Mena said. "But when you write it by hand, you don't forget it completely. It's strange that way."

"...Isn't it hard? Writing down nothing but sad stories all the time."

Mena turned a page and was quiet for a moment.

"...It's hard," Mena said at last. "But if no one writes it down, that name really is as though it never existed. I find that more frightening."

I heard that and thought about it for a long time. I understood then why Mena walked so far. She was doing what the Ledger could not. Not forgetting.

. . .

The night before Mena left, we all sat together by the fire. Speon hummed an old song, something he hadn't done in a long while. I couldn't make out the words. But the melody alone stirred something in me.

That night, Mena took a sheet of paper out of her record box and showed it to Father.

"...This is your name," Mena said. "Exactly as your children told it to me. I wrote it down and carried it with me."

Father looked at that paper a long time. Even reading his own name, his face wasn't sure it belonged to him.

Firelight flickered over the paper. Father traced the letters one by one with his fingertip. Very slowly. I thought that gesture looked like a child's, learning letters for the first time.

I saw the crease marks where the paper had been folded and unfolded. It looked as if it had been folded many times. I could guess how long Mena had carried that paper close.

"...This is... my name?" Father asked.

"...Yes," Mena said. "It's a name your children have never once forgotten."

I set that down as the last line of this chapter. In that moment, I heard Father read his own name aloud. It was still an unfamiliar sound to him. But in that unfamiliarity, I felt something coming back, very slowly.

(Continued in Chapter 39.)

Chapter 39. I've Been There

Previously — Mena came to the well and met Father. When she showed him the paper with his own name written on it, he read it aloud for the first time. Still unfamiliar, but something was slowly returning.

Even after Mena left again, our days at the well didn't change much. Drawing water, walking, setting down the record each evening — it repeated. Strangely, that repetition put my mind at ease. In Haven, every day had felt like a new emergency. Here, every day resembled yesterday. I already knew, by then, how precious that resemblance was.

Someone new came out at the well.

This time it was a young boy. About ten years old. He came out unable even to cry, and just sat there, dazed.

His clothes were old and thin. His shoes didn't match. His look brought back the way the children of Brick Hollow used to dress. I didn't know which hollow he'd come from. But his eyes weren't unfamiliar to me at all.

Looking at him, I remembered the first time we met Father, months ago. I remember how helpless we were then. Now it was different. We knew what to do.

Speon, as he always did, brought water first. The boy took it but couldn't drink. His hands were trembling.

I saw that trembling. And for the first time, I realized this place had been holding more people than Speon alone could carry. Now, we were with him.

Speon set the jar down in front of the boy and stepped back without a word. I understood that stepping back was a kindness. Speon had long known how not to approach anyone first.

Father was watching the boy too, from a little distance. Something familiar crossed his face. I didn't know exactly what expression it was. But I felt that Father was recognizing something in that boy.

. . .

My brother sat quietly beside the boy.

"...I've been there," my brother said. "Our father came out of a well like this too. At first, he knew nothing either."

The boy looked at my brother. For the first time, there was some response in his eyes.

"...And now?" the boy asked. His voice cracked.

"...Now he can read his own name out loud," my brother said. "Not all of it. But it's coming back, little by little."

Hearing that, the boy carefully took the water jar in both hands. And he began drinking, very slowly. Watching, I only then realized I'd been holding my breath.

"...I can't remember what my name was. Not any of it," the boy said. His voice was thick.

"...That's all right," my brother said. "It doesn't have to come to you right now. It took our father months."

"...Months?" the boy asked, his face startled.

"...Yes," my brother said. "But he wasn't alone for those months. I think that was the most important part."

. . .

From that day on, the boy followed my brother everywhere. He tried to copy everything my brother did.

When my brother mended the bucket, the boy watched and then quietly offered his hand to help. When my brother walked the well with Father, the boy trailed a few steps behind. I thought that looked like the old my brother — how he too had once walked, wordless, in someone's footsteps.

One day the boy picked up a stone and handed it to my brother. He didn't explain why. My brother didn't ask why either, and just took it. Watching that, I thought of Father. Father used to gather stones for no reason too. I thought this resemblance might not be a coincidence.

Speon watched all this from a distance and said quietly to me:

"...Your brother's become a completely different person now."

"...How?"

"...He used to try to find answers," Speon said. "Now he's building a place beside people. I think that's the far harder work."

"...Why are you helping me?" the boy asked one day.

My brother thought for a moment before answering.

"...Because I've had it done for me," my brother said. "Someone stayed beside me. I've received that. So I can give it too."

The boy repeated the answer, as if turning it over.

"...Because you've had it done for you..." the boy murmured.

"...Yes," my brother said. "Someday you'll be that for someone too. You probably can't believe it now."

The boy tilted his head. His face didn't look like he fully understood. But something seemed to have stayed with him. From that day on, every time he filled his water jar, he ladled one scoop more than his own share and set it aside, not even knowing who it was for.

Hearing that answer, I understood, for the first time, one whole sentence: someone who has never been loved finds it harder to learn how to love. My brother was passing on, unchanged, what he had received.

I listened to that conversation from beside them. I knew the old my brother couldn't have answered a question like that. The old him would have said "just because." This brother knew the reason.

After a few days, the boy started smiling a little. He still didn't know his own name. But he liked the temporary one my brother had given him.

"...Will I get to find my real name too, someday?" the boy asked.

"...Yes," my brother said. "Slowly. But it will come back."

"...How do you know it will come back?"

My brother glanced toward Father for a moment. Father was just then drawing up the bucket at the well.

"...Because I've seen it," my brother said. "Our father didn't know anything at first either. Now he reads his own name out loud. I saw that with my own eyes. So I believe it."

The boy smiled for the first time at that. A short smile. But a clear one. I wrote that smile briefly into my record that evening. "Today, the nameless boy smiled for the first time."

Watching that smile, I felt something strange. Only months ago my brother had been someone who couldn't speak with certainty to anyone about anything. Now he was handing certainty to someone else, based on what he himself had seen.

Toward evening, Speon came over and stroked the boy's head.

"...You can stay here until your name comes to you," Speon said. "No need to hurry."

The boy nodded. And for the first time, he got up on his own to go fill his water jar.

. . .

That night, my brother said to me:

"...I felt something strange today, talking to that boy."

"...What was it?"

"...I was saying, word for word, something I learned from that man. 'Even without a name, you're here now. That's enough.' I never once memorized that line. It just came out."

I said nothing for a moment, hearing that. Only the sound of the night wind brushing the trees by the well.

"...Doesn't that scare you?" I asked.

"...What?"

"...You becoming like that man."

My brother thought about that question for a long time.

"...I think it does scare me a little," he said at last. "But I don't dislike it. That's strange."

I gave no answer to that. I just sat a little closer to my brother. He seemed to notice, and offered his shoulder without a word.

I set that down as the last line of this chapter. I knew then. My brother still couldn't explain who that man was. But he was already carrying that man's words into his own body. I was certain, for the first time that day, how close that was to the beginning of faith.

(Continued in Chapter 40.)

Chapter 40. Going to Him First

Previously — A nameless boy came up out of the well. Brother passed on to him, exactly as it was, the way of being beside someone. And he realized, on his own, that he was already carrying in his body words he'd learned from the man at the flowerbed, without ever having memorized them.

The man appeared and vanished at no set time.

For the first few days I tried marking on a calendar which days he came. Then I gave it up. I couldn't find any pattern at all. And yet he never once came on a day he wasn't needed.

Some days he touched the soil by the well. Some days he sat quietly beside someone newly come up. No one ever knew when he would come.

His clothes were always about the same — plain, the kind you'd see anywhere. At first I thought that was strange. Later I came to think it was simply like him. A man who didn't want to be noticed.

I once tried to trace back the places he'd appeared. When someone newly arrived couldn't lift the water jar. When the boy woke alone at night and cried. When Speon, rarely, looked worn through. He had stood quietly in those exact places. I didn't think that could be coincidence. And yet he never made it look as if he'd known in advance and come looking.

It was around then that I began to notice that irregularity was, in fact, the rule. He was always there at the moment he was most needed.

There was something neither Speon nor Mena ever asked him. When he would come. Why now. Living by the well, I came to understand that their silence wasn't resignation. It was an ease that only someone who had watched him a long time could have.

I asked Speon about it once.

"...Where does that man live?"

Speon answered without stopping his work on the bucket.

"...I don't know," Speon said. "Haven't known for decades. But I've never once gone without. He's come when he was needed."

"...Have you never once wanted to know?"

"...I've wanted to," Speon said. "But at some point, that wanting stopped turning into a fret. Some things you can just leave as things you wonder about."

"...Elpis, you want to know too, don't you?" Speon asked.

"...Yes," I said. "But lately that wanting doesn't scare me."

"...Why not?"

"...I learned that it's all right not to know," I said.

I carried that answer in my heart a long while. I didn't know then that it would reach Brother too, someday.

The boy — the nameless one — flinched the first time he saw him too. I understood that. A body tenses first, when a stranger suddenly appears. But after a few days the boy started to feel at ease with him. Whenever the man appeared, the boy would edge over and sit down

beside him. He said nothing. He just sat. Watching that, I understood that the boy, too, was already learning how to be beside someone without needing to speak.

He never tried to teach the boy anything. He simply touched the soil alongside him whenever the boy fidgeted with the dirt. When the boy stacked stones, he watched without knocking them down. I felt something in that, something like the way Father had been with us, the first time he came to us.

I thought back to the first time I met him. In an alley in Haven, he had looked like nothing more than a passerby. I hadn't known then that he would stay beside us this long. Now, on the days he didn't come, I felt an odd emptiness. I couldn't say exactly when that emptiness had started.

. . .

One afternoon, he sat alone in the shade of the tree by the well.

Brother walked over to him. I didn't follow. I knew that was Brother's place to go alone.

It was late afternoon. Sunlight slanted in through the leaves. Brother's shadow stretched long and reached toward him. I watched that shadow shorten, little by little, as he walked. Brother's steps were slow. But they didn't stop.

"...Can I talk to you for a bit?" Brother asked. It wasn't the accusing tone from before.

I watched it from a distance. For the first time, I saw Brother go looking for him. It had always been the man who appeared first. This

time Brother went to him first.

Watching his back, I thought of the last night in Brick Hollow. The night Brother had shouted up at the sky. Back then he'd gone toward him in anger. Now he was walking toward him. I knew that difference was a large one.

. . .

The man motioned with his hand to the seat beside him. Brother sat down.

I watched the way Brother lowered himself into that seat. The old Brother would have crossed his arms, or turned his body away. That day, he simply sat side by side. Legs stretched out, hands resting on his knees. I understood, then, how much a single small posture could say.

For a long while, neither of them spoke. Even from a distance, I could feel that the silence wasn't from awkwardness.

I sat down beside the bucket and watched the two of them. Speon came over quietly and sat beside me. He said nothing either. We sat there, side by side, and watched the two figures in the distance.

Every time the wind stirred the leaves, the shadow shifted a little across them. I tried to guess, from that shadow, how much time had passed. But I couldn't quite manage it. That silence didn't seem like something you could measure that way.

I understood, then, that some conversations have already begun even without sound. Brother and the man hadn't said a single word yet. But I could feel that something was already passing between them.

The bucket rope swayed lightly in the wind and made a small sound. A bird landed on the well's stone wall, then flew off again. I found myself counting those small sounds, one by one. If I didn't do something like that, the silence felt too heavy to bear.

"...I still don't really know," Brother said at last. "Who you are. Why you keep showing up. Whether I'm supposed to believe in God."

"...I know," he said.

"...Don't just say you know — tell me what you know," Brother said. There was a trace of an old irritation in his voice.

He laughed a little at that. It wasn't an angry laugh.

"...I know you still want an answer," he said. "And I know you're sitting here even when that answer doesn't come. That's a beginning."

"...But there's one thing I do know," Brother said. "I know how to be beside someone now. But when I think about where I learned it... in the end, it's from you."

He said nothing to that. But even from a distance I saw his shoulder move, just slightly. I didn't know what that movement meant. But I could tell it wasn't a bad one.

. . .

At that, he turned and looked at Brother straight on for the first time.

I felt that his eyes were different from usual. Eyes that were always gentle were, in that moment, meeting Brother's straight on.

"...Then let me ask you one thing," he said. "Why do you still not trust me?"

The well seemed to go suddenly, entirely quiet. Even the sound of the bucket, even the birds, seemed to pause for a moment. I held my breath in that stillness.

Brother was silent for a long time. In that silence, I saw his hands tighten into fists on his knees.

"...Because I'm afraid," Brother said finally. "If I believe, and it ends up like it did with Father again... I don't think I could bear it this time. Not really."

I set down that answer as the last sentence of this chapter. I heard Brother, for the first time, say out loud the real reason for his doubt. It wasn't logic. It was fear. I knew, in that moment, that Brother had come a very little bit closer.

(Continued in Chapter 41.)

Chapter 41. I've Lost Someone Too

Previously — For the first time, Brother went to find the man at the flowerbed on his own. Asked "Why do you still not trust me?" Brother finally said the real reason: "If I believe, and it ends up like it did with Father again... I don't think I could bear it this time. Not really."

I still remember the air of that afternoon. It was warm. But Brother's voice made that warmth feel heavy.

I had thought I already knew Brother's fear. But hearing it that day, straight from his own mouth, was an entirely different thing.

Brother's words seemed to hang there in the air. I could tell, just from the shake in his voice, how long that fear had been pressed down inside him.

He was silent a long while after hearing Brother's words.

I watched that silence from a distance. I knew it wasn't a dismissive silence. It was a silence that was weighing something.

I held my breath and waited to see how long that weight would go on.

Evening was drawing near. The sky had begun to take on a pale orange. I watched that light touch Brother's face. His expression was far more open than usual.

The bucket rope swayed in the wind and creaked softly. I heard that sound unusually loud.

I stood a little way off. Speon came quietly and stood beside me. He said nothing. We both just watched that spot.

The wind stirred the trees by the well. Brother sat through that silence and stayed right there. He didn't run. That alone told me how far Brother had come.

I saw that Brother's feet, this time, didn't move even a little. The old Brother would already have turned and walked away. Watching those feet, I understood how many moments Brother had learned, one by one, to bear.

Only then did I notice my own hand was gripping the edge of my clothes. I'd been tensing up without knowing it.

I realized then, for the first time, that I was afraid of this moment almost as much as Brother was. If Brother broke, I felt I would break too.

"...I know that feeling," he said at last.

The answer felt strangely simple to me — strange enough to feel wrong. Brother must have felt the same, because his brow creased slightly.

"...How would you know that?" Brother asked. There was still an edge in it.

I heard that edge still left in Brother's voice. But underneath it, I could also feel — for the first time — that there was a real question there.

There was no trace of anger on his face. Watching that, I thought he must be someone who had already taken that sharp tone of Brother's

more times than could be counted. Not someone who simply didn't get hurt by it — someone who looked past it, to what lay beneath.

Watching that, I thought of the first time we met Father. Father, too, must have been able to come this far only because there had been someone who accepted our anger exactly as it was.

Thinking that, I felt strangely at ease. We weren't the only ones who needed a place like that.

. . .

He said nothing for a while. In that silence, I felt he was working to bring something out that had been pressed down a long time. The wind by the well stirred the leaves once more and passed on.

"...Because I've lost someone too," he said.

Brother's face showed surprise at that.

I watched Brother's expression change. He'd always been someone who thought his own grief was the largest thing in the world. But in that moment, for the first time, Brother was facing someone else's loss.

Brother's lips moved, as if to say something, then closed again. I felt, in that, that Brother was for the first time thinking of the other person before his own question.

"...What did you lose?"

That question hung in the air a moment. I couldn't tell whether he was avoiding an answer, or truly choosing one.

He looked off into the distance for a moment.

I watched his eyes. Even looking off into the distance, they seemed to hold something less like grief than an old resolve.

In that moment I thought of everything we had lost. Mother. The old man who had fallen in Brick Hollow. People we'd parted from without even learning their names. I hadn't known, before that, exactly how heavy the word losing could be.

"...It would take a long time to explain," he said. "But I can tell you one thing. I'm not going to promise you I won't lose you again. That's a promise I couldn't keep. But I can promise you one thing instead. When it happens, I won't leave you alone."

The moment I heard that, tears came to me, strangely. I didn't understand it then — why he didn't say it wouldn't hurt. I understand it now. He wasn't someone who gave false comfort.

I wiped my tears and looked at Brother. His eyes were red too. Neither of us could say exactly why those words had shaken us so much.

"...Aren't you going to tell me who you lost?" Brother asked.

He closed his eyes for a moment and opened them again. Even in that short moment, something heavy seemed to pass across his face.

"...Someday," he said. "Not now. Right now is your story's time, not mine."

Brother nodded. He didn't ask further. I thought the way Brother accepted that answer was a way he never could have imagined, once.

Strangely, that answer settled well with me. It was the first time I felt that he wasn't trying to cover our grief with his own.

In that moment I thought of the Ledger back in Haven. The Ledger always gave the answer first. But this man gave his own silence first, instead of an answer. I began, dimly, that day, to feel that this difference was the most important one in the whole of this book.

I looked at Brother in that moment. He didn't press any further. The old Brother would surely have asked again. I felt that Brother was learning, on his own, how to stop.

I glanced up at Speon's face beside me. Something like an old grief was passing across it.

"...Is this the first time you're hearing it, Speon?" I asked him, almost in a whisper.

"...No," Speon said. "I already know. But it's just as heavy, no matter how many times I hear it."

"...How do you bear it?"

"...I don't bear it," Speon said. "I just stay beside it."

Hearing that answer, I felt I understood again why Speon had been able to keep this well for so long. Not enduring — staying beside. I set that difference into my heart.

. . .

Brother sat there in silence for a long while. I knew he was choosing his next question. It was a question he had held back for a very long time.

The sky was turning redder and redder. Watching that red light touch Brother's face, I knew he was finally about to bring out the heaviest question of all.

"...Then why did our father end up like that?" Brother asked. His voice shook. "Why didn't you stop it?"

"...I can't give you that answer either," he said. "If I could give it to you, I already would have."

"...Then what can you give me?"

"...This, right now," he said. And he held out his hand. "Sitting beside you."

Brother looked at that hand for a long time. From a distance, I saw his shoulders shaking.

Brother took the hand.

I set down that answer as the last sentence of this chapter. I knew, then, that the answer this whole book had been searching for had never existed as a sentence to begin with. That answer was shaped like the hand he held out. And Brother, that day, answered by taking it.

(Continued in Chapter 42.)

Chapter 42. The Three of Us, Sitting

Previously — To Brother's confession of fear, the man answered not with an argument but with the fact that he too had lost someone. "When it happens, I won't leave you alone." And he held out his hand. Brother took it.

That evening, for the first time, I sat with Brother under that same shade tree.

What had happened that day was still vivid before my eyes. Brother holding out his hand — Brother taking that hand. I called that scene back to mind again and again. It was a scene no words could fully explain.

I was already turning over, that same evening, how I would set that scene down in the record. It seemed like no word I chose would be enough.

He was already gone. Vanished quietly, as he always did. But something like warmth from where he had been still remained in that spot. I touched my hand to the grass. It felt as if the shape of where he'd sat was still pressed into it.

I didn't know what to call that warmth. I still can't find the exact word for it now. I just set it down as it was.

The evening air was turning cool. The last of the sunlight fell in scattered pieces through the leaves. I watched those pieces of light tremble across Brother's face.

Brother sat under that tree for a long while. I asked nothing, sitting beside him. I had learned, by then, that some moments suit silence better than questions.

I folded my hands in my lap and simply waited. In Brick Hollow, I would surely have asked something by now. Not that day.

The crickets started up, one by one. I thought that sound seemed to make the quiet well grow even quieter. It was a strange kind of quiet — not an empty quiet, but a quiet full of something.

Brother finally shifted a little. I recognized that movement as a sign he was ready to say something.

Speon sat far off in front of the hut. He wasn't looking our way. But I could feel he was keeping his ears open toward us. That was his way of being present.

. . .

The longer the night wore on, the more the stars came out. I looked at Brother's face under that starlight. It looked more at ease than it had by day.

"...Do you believe now?" I asked.

Brother couldn't answer right away. I waited without rushing that silence.

"...I don't know," Brother said. "But when I took that hand a little while ago... something changed. I can't explain exactly what."

I thought that answer was so like Brother. He never dressed up a certainty he didn't have.

"...Is the anger gone?"

"...No," Brother said. "The anger's still there. What happened to Father still makes me angry. But now I know I don't have to hold that anger alone."

I could hear both anger and relief in Brother's voice at once. I learned, in that moment, for the first time, that those two things could live inside the same sentence.

I thought that answer was strangely honest. Brother didn't say, "It's all fine now." I thought that honesty was so like him.

Brother looked up at the sky for a moment. Starlight caught in his eyes.

"...Elpis, when did you start believing?" Brother asked.

I thought about that question for a long time. I knew how much that question mattered to Brother. So I didn't want to answer carelessly.

"...I don't know," I said. "At some point, I just started waiting. Before I even had the words to say I believed."

Brother nodded at that answer. It was a face that seemed to understand something. I was grateful Brother didn't press me further.

"...You believe in such a strange way," Brother said. It wasn't teasing.

"...And you're angry in such a strange way," I said back.

Brother laughed at that. A small laugh. But it was the first laugh I'd seen in days.

"...You know what?" Brother said. "Lately I think it's a good thing we're so different, the two of us."

"...Why?"

"...Because you kept waiting, I think that's how I made it this far," Brother said.

I didn't know what to say to that, so I just leaned my head against his shoulder.

I remember that laugh for a long time. I understood, then, that we had come to the same place by two different roads.

. . .

We sat like that under the starlight for a while. It was a comfortable silence, even without a word.

Father walked toward us then. He had a few small stones in his hand.

Father's footsteps were familiar to us by now. Not careful the way they used to be. I felt, in those steps, how much at ease Father had become at this well. When we first came here, Father had tried not to even make the sound of his own footsteps.

"...What were you two doing?" Father asked.

"...Just sitting," Brother said.

Father sat down beside us naturally. That day was the first time the three of us sat side by side.

I was struck by how natural it was. A few months ago, Father would have found even sitting beside us unfamiliar.

Father's shoulder brushed lightly against mine. I felt the warmth of it. I thought that warmth was different from, and yet somehow like, the warmth the man had left behind earlier.

I record that moment exactly. Father didn't know what we'd been talking about. But in that moment, something felt complete, just from the three of us sitting there together.

No one spoke for a long time. I felt that this silence was a different kind from the one we'd shared that afternoon. This wasn't a silence that was weighing something — it was simply a comfortable silence.

Brother leaned his body a little toward Father. Father seemed to feel it too, and shifted his own posture slightly. I felt the distance between the two of them narrowing, little by little.

. . .

The stones in Father's palm were each a different shape. Round ones, flat ones, one with a faint shimmering grain. I took each stone in with my eyes, one at a time.

Moonlight fell softly over those stones. I thought that light made them look even more special than usual.

"...Why do you collect these stones?" I asked.

Father set each stone on his palm and looked at it, one by one. His fingertips slowly traced over each one.

"...I don't know," Father said. "I just thought they looked nice. And... I feel like I want to give them to someone. I don't know who."

Brother heard that and looked at Father quietly. He said nothing. But I saw tears well up faintly in Brother's eyes.

"...Could you give one to me?" I asked. The words came out before I knew it.

Father looked at me, surprised, then chose one stone and pressed it into my hand. The smallest, smoothest one there.

"...So it was this," Father said quietly. "This is who I wanted to give it to."

Relief crossed Father's face at last. Watching that, I thought Father must have been quietly troubled, all this time, not knowing the reason.

I held that stone tight in my hand. It was warm. The warmth of Father's hand still lingered in it. I didn't open my hand for a long while, not wanting to lose that warmth.

I still have that stone. I think it stands in for everything Father couldn't say in words.

I set down that line as the last sentence of this chapter. I nearly cried in that moment. Father didn't know. But Father's body knew. Gathering something for someone — that had always been the thing Father did.

(Continued in Chapter 43.)

Chapter 43. What Mother Never Got to Say

*_Previously_ — After taking the hand, Brother answered honestly:
"The anger's still there. But now I know I don't have to hold that
anger alone." Not knowing why, Father had been gathering stones,
wanting to give them to someone.*

A few days passed like that, peacefully. Father still gathered stones by day, and Brother helped Speon look after the well. I set down the evening record somewhere in between.

Father had been unusually quiet these past few days. But it wasn't an uneasy quiet. I only understood later that it was a quiet of turning something over. At the time I simply thought Father must be tired.

That night was unusually still. Even the wind seemed to be asleep.

A few nights later, Father suddenly bolted upright out of sleep.

"...Jeteo." Father said it with his eyes open.

Brother startled at the sound and sat up.

"...Me?" Brother asked. His voice shook.

I held my breath in that moment. Father had called Brother's name for the first time. But Father's face was still the confused face of someone not fully out of sleep.

I felt that the voice calling that name sounded as if it had come out of a dream. Both unfamiliar and familiar, all at once.

"...It's all right, Father." I said it, and the word "Father" came out of me naturally, without my meaning it to. Father, too, paused for a moment at the word. But his wasn't a face that disliked it.

Father's hand was trembling. I took it carefully. It was cold. I didn't let go until that cold began to fade.

Outside, the faint cry of night insects drifted in. That sound felt unusually loud to me. Probably because all three of us were holding our breath.

Brother stayed sitting where he was, still watching Father. I saw fear and hope crossing his face at once.

"...What did you dream about?" Brother asked, carefully.

Father shook his head. And shook it again.

"...I don't think it was a dream," Father said. "It felt like... a memory."

. . .

Only a faint warmth remained where the fire had gone out. In that darkness, I could barely make out Father's eyes. He stared into the empty air for a moment, like someone trying to hold on to something.

"...Your mother..." Father said, stumbling over it. "Not long before they took me away, one night, she said something like this to me. That there was something she wanted to say to you, but she still couldn't."

Brother froze where he sat. I heard his breath stop, for a moment.

"...Do you remember what it was?" Brother asked. His voice cracked all the way through.

The moment I heard that question, I understood that Brother had been waiting for this moment for years. A question he might never get an answer to — and Brother had never given up asking it.

Father closed his eyes and strained a long while. I watched him strain, and clenched my hands tight.

Father's lips moved several times, then closed again. Watching that, I understood there was nothing left to do but wait. And, strangely, that waiting didn't frighten me.

"...Take your time," I said. "There's no hurry."

Father nodded at that, eyes still closed.

"...I'm sorry," Father said. "For stopping again and again."

"...It's all right," Brother said. His voice had steadied a little from before. "I'm here. I'm not going anywhere."

Father opened his eyes at those words. He looked at Brother a long time. I felt something growing clearer, little by little, inside that gaze.

"...Not going anywhere," Father repeated the words, quietly, to himself. "I feel like I've heard that a lot, somewhere."

I caught my breath at that moment. I knew those were the words we had said to Father, over and over, without number. Somewhere in Father's body, those words had already been carved.

Brother said nothing to that. He only gripped Father's hand tighter. I thought that silence was larger than any words could be.

. . .

Speon woke at the sound too, and came out. He didn't come close to us — he stood a little way off and watched. I knew that distance was a kindness.

It was a night so dark even the stars were dim. In that darkness, I heard Father's voice tremble. It was a tremble I'd never heard before.

"... 'You're a child who's always going to be asking,'" Father said finally. Slowly, one word at a time. "'And that's not a bad thing. I'm... proud of that.' That's what I think she was trying to say."

Brother sank down where he stood when he heard it.

Brother's shoulders shook hard. I knelt beside him and set my hand on his back. He didn't push my hand away.

Father knelt down beside him too. It was a clumsy movement. But Father didn't hesitate. I saw, for the first time that day, the three of us tangled together like that, into one.

I record that moment exactly. It was the first time I'd seen Brother cry like that. Out loud, hard. For the first time since we'd left Brick Hollow.

Hearing those words, I thought of the night we crossed the boundary stones. The night Mother called Brother's name, opened her mouth, and closed it again. "...No. Never mind. Go and live. That's enough." I understood, then, for the first time, that what Mother had tried and

failed to say that night had already been left, ahead of time, with Father.

I don't remember Mother's face clearly, from that night. But her voice alone has stayed with me, sharp and whole. Now I know: that voice, and the words Father just brought back to us, came from the same person.

I closed my eyes and tried to call that voice back once more. It wasn't whole. But the warmth of it, at least, was still there, unmistakably.

I thought, that night, that the whole well was listening to Brother's crying together with us. No one came out to make him stop. They just listened.

I thought for a long while about how I would set that crying down in this record. In the end I decided to write it plainly: Brother cried. For a long time, and very loudly. And no one hurried him toward the end of it.

. . .

Long after, Brother's crying settled. I saw Father sitting quietly beside him in that time. Saying nothing, simply keeping watch beside him.

Dawn seemed to be near; the far edge of the sky had begun to lighten faintly. Watching that light, I only then realized how long the night had been.

Brother wiped his tears and looked straight at Father. I felt he wanted to ask something more.

"...Did Mother think it was... shameful, that I kept asking things?" Brother asked. Of Father, or maybe of nothing at all.

Father put a hand on Brother's shoulder. The gesture was still clumsy. But there was something certain in it.

Brother let that hand stay. He didn't push it away. I knew how large a change that small permission was.

"...She said she was proud," Father said again. "That much, I remember exactly."

Brother lowered his head. Tears fell again. This time, silently.

"...Thank you," Brother managed, "for remembering it."

Father gripped Brother's shoulder a little harder at those words. There were no words. But I thought the strength of that hand alone was enough.

The sky was growing fully light. I only then realized that this was the first time the three of us had stayed up through an entire night together like this.

I set down that line as the last sentence of this chapter. That night, I watched Brother receive the answer to a question he'd been asking himself for years — was it wrong of me to keep asking? — the latest it could possibly come, from the person he'd least expect to bring it.

(Continued in Chapter 44.)

Chapter 44. The Meaning of Our Names

Previously — Father called Brother's name for the first time. And he remembered that, the night before he was taken, Mother had left with him, ahead of time, the words she'd wanted to say to Brother. "You're a child who's always going to be asking. I'm proud of that." That night, for the first time, Brother cried out loud.

The seasons by the well went on passing quietly. They were days when, on the surface, nothing seemed to have changed at all.

A few days later, Father called us over with a somewhat clearer look on his face.

That morning, Father had woken unusually early. His eyes were clearer than usual. I found that clearness both unfamiliar and welcome.

"...I remember who named you two," Father said.

I stopped what I was doing at that. The bucket handle nearly slipped from my hand. I could tell, just from Father's face, that this wasn't a question that would simply pass by.

Brother felt it too. From Brick Hollow to now, we had never once asked what our names meant. A name was just a name. Something you were called by — that was all.

I felt strange in that moment. We had called each other's names hundreds of times over. And yet it had never once occurred to us that something might be held inside them.

"...Have you ever wondered what your name meant?" I asked Brother.

"...No, never," Brother said. "I always thought a name was just a name."

"...Me too," I said.

In that moment I saw something like fear cross Brother's face. I understood, for the first time, that knowing your own name might be a frightening thing.

. . .

Father sat us down beside the stone wall around the well. Morning sunlight fell slanting across the three of us.

I felt Father's voice was unusually clear that day. As if this, whatever it was, was a story he refused to let slip past him.

"...Your mother named you," Father said. "There was an old language, back where she was from. A language that puts meaning into names. She named you two with that language."

Hearing that, I realized I had never once asked where Mother was from. To us, Mother had only ever been "Mother" — we didn't know where she'd come from.

I found that fact strangely sad. There was still so much about Mother we didn't know.

"...What does it mean?" Brother asked.

I heard Brother's voice shake faintly as he asked it.

Father searched hard in his memory for a moment.

I felt my heart pounding hard in that silence. I reached over and took Brother's hand. He took mine back.

"...Jeteo means... 'to seek,' 'to search,'" Father said. "Your mother told me. 'This child is going to spend his whole life asking things, digging for the bottom of them. That's going to be his name.'"

The moment I heard that, my breath caught. I looked at Brother. Brother stood there, unable to say anything. That name lined up exactly with every way Brother had lived, from Brick Hollow to now.

I saw Brother's hand tremble faintly. That hand still carried the calluses of the bucket rope.

"...So I just... lived out my name?" Brother asked. Bewilderment was mixed into his voice.

"...Or maybe the name followed you," I said. "Either way — isn't it strange?"

Brother had no answer to that. He only looked off into the distance. I knew he would turn that question over for a long time to come.

"...Does that man know it too? What my name means?" Brother suddenly asked.

Father tilted his head.

"...Who's that man?" Father asked back.

Brother hesitated a moment at the question, then laughed a little.

"...I'll explain later," Brother said.

I understood that Brother still hadn't told Father the whole story of that man. But he wasn't in a hurry. Some stories only come out when their time arrives.

I sat quietly beside Brother. I added nothing more. I already knew, by then, that some moments are enough just by being beside someone.

. . .

I hesitated a long while before asking my own question. All the more so, after hearing Brother's name.

Brother looked toward me. As though he'd read my mind, he gave a small nod. It seemed to mean it was all right to ask.

Father looked at me too, and waited. In that waiting, I felt, oddly, at ease.

"...And Elpis?" I asked. My voice shook.

"...Hope," Father said. "Your mother told me. 'This child is going to keep waiting, for no reason at all. That's going to be her name.'"

The moment I heard that, tears poured out of me. I thought of the seed, the flowerbed, the heart that had watered it every day and waited. My whole life I hadn't known why I was someone who waited so well. Now I know. It was my name.

In that moment I thought of the last night in Brick Hollow — Brother's hand, holding out the seed pouch to me. I hadn't known the reason then. Now I do. I had simply taken up that seed the way my own name told me to.

"...Isn't the name Hope heavy to carry?" Brother asked.

I laughed at that question.

"...Maybe it does feel heavy," I said. "But it's not a bad kind of heavy."

Brother quietly wrapped an arm around my shoulder. He said nothing more. That touch alone was enough for me.

. . .

We sat like that in silence for a long while. The wind passed over the grass by the well.

Speon, tidying up the well in the distance, glanced our way. Something about his face looked as if he'd noticed something. But he didn't come closer.

"...Do you think Mother knew we'd turn out like this?" Brother asked.

Father shook his head. His face showed he was thinking hard about the question.

"...I don't think she knew," Father said. "But I think she knew what kind of people you two would become. Someone who searches. Someone who waits."

"...And what about you, Father?" I asked. "Does your name have a meaning too?"

Father looked startled by the question. It seemed like a question he'd never once thought about. He looked down at his own hands for a

moment, as if the answer might be written there.

Watching that expression, I felt something strange. We had called Father's name hundreds of times over. But this was the first time we'd ever wondered what it meant.

"...I don't know," Father said. "My own name... I don't really know it either."

"...Then we'll find it for you," Brother said. "Someday."

Father laughed at that. There was a faint sheen of moisture at the corners of his eyes.

Watching that laugh, I imagined the day we would truly find the meaning of Father's name. I hoped that on that day, too, the three of us would be together, just like this.

I set that laugh down in this record. I understood, then. Knowing the meaning of a name matters less than having someone beside you who calls it.

Brother looked at me at that. I looked back at Brother. We nodded to each other without a word.

Father looked between the two of us, and laughed softly. It was a laugh I hadn't seen in a long time.

I set down that line as the last sentence of this chapter. I understood, for the first time that day, that we hadn't lived according to the meaning of our names. We had simply lived as ourselves, and that life had been inside our names from the very beginning. It took me a long time, thinking it over, to see how large that difference was.

(Continued in Chapter 45.)

Chapter 45. News Temel Brought

Previously — Father revealed the meaning of our names. Jeteo means

"to seek, to search"; Elpis means "hope." It came out that every way the two of us had lived had already been inside our names.

Around the start of autumn, Temel stopped by the well again.

It was a time when the leaves had just begun to turn. I thought this color was different from the autumn I remembered in Brick Hollow. Brick Hollow's autumn had been the color of dust. Here, autumn was red and gold.

The trees by the well were beginning to drop their leaves too, one by one. Every morning I gathered up a few fallen leaves. There was no real reason. It just seemed a shame to let them go.

"...It's been a while," Brother greeted him warmly. His face was far more at ease than it had been months before.

Temel's walk looked lighter than before, too. I wondered where that lightness came from. His pack looked lighter as well.

Temel saw Father and smiled.

"...You look much better," Temel said.

Father looked at Temel with something like curiosity.

"...You're the one who first came looking for me, aren't you?" Father asked. It wasn't an exact memory. But something seemed to have stayed

with him.

"...That's right," Temel said, his face showing surprise.

Temel knelt down to bring himself level with Father's eyes.

"...You didn't even have a name, back then," Temel said quietly. "And now, look at you — you know me."

Father smiled faintly at that. It was the smile of someone who found it a little strange himself.

"...When you first found me, Temel — what was I like?" Father asked.

Temel took a moment to choose his words at that question. The firelight cast shifting shadows across his face.

"...There was nothing there," Temel said honestly. "No name, no expression. But your eyes were looking for something. It was because of that look that I didn't give up on you."

Father listened to that and fell silent for a long while. I felt that he was carving those words somewhere deep inside him.

. . .

That evening, we all gathered around the fire. Speon threw a few more logs on. The flames grew and lit our faces red.

Temel gave us what news there was.

"...You want to hear about Haven?" Temel asked.

Brother nodded. There was none of the old anger in it. Just curiosity. I noticed that difference all over again, watching from beside him.

"...Still quiet," Temel said. "But I've heard that quiet's gotten some cracks in it lately. More and more people refusing COMPLETE, not filing at all."

Hearing that, something in me stirred strangely. We hadn't gone there to change that city. But it seemed like something had been left behind, in the place we walked away from.

"...Aren't those people in danger?" I asked.

"...They are," Temel said plainly. "But they don't stop, apparently. Once someone starts first, it seems to get a little easier for the next one."

"...Who started it, first of all?" Brother asked.

"...No one knows," Temel said. "They started without even leaving a name behind, they say. All they did was not file."

Brother nodded quietly at that. I felt Brother was carving that nameless person into his heart.

Father was listening to all this too. His expression was complicated. I could feel that something in Father stirred, faintly, every time he heard the name Haven. It wasn't a complete memory. But it seemed his body recognized it before his mind did.

"...Are you all right?" I asked Father.

"...Yes," Father said. "It's just... an unfamiliar name that doesn't feel unfamiliar."

Brother moved closer and sat beside Father.

"...You don't have to talk about it, if you don't want to," Brother said.

"...No," Father said. "I want to know. I want to understand my own story a little more too."

Hearing that, I thought Father had grown so much braver than before. The way he faced his own past instead of fearing it — I admired that.

. . .

"...What about the Administrator?" I asked.

"...Still there," Temel said. "But not long ago, there was a rumor — that someone secretly made a room where they keep remembering the names of the people marked COMPLETE. They say the Administrator knows about the room and looks the other way."

In that moment, I thought of the Administrator's face. The face that used to say, "That isn't mine to answer." I thought that maybe he was still resisting, inside that city, in his own way.

"...Does the room have a name?" I asked.

"...No," Temel said. "It's just a room, they say. But people have taken to calling it 'the remembering room.'"

I turned that name over in my mind several times. The remembering room. I thought that phrase resembled the very thing we were doing. Somewhere in the middle of Haven, someone was secretly doing the same work we had learned to do here.

Speon spoke up then, for the first time in the conversation.

"...And Mena — how is she?" Speon asked. His voice made a plain effort not to give anything away.

Temel answered, holding back a smile.

"...Doing well. Still out walking, these days. But I hear she's been setting her steps this way more often than she used to."

Speon said nothing to that. But I saw the tips of his ears turn faintly red.

Watching that, I couldn't help but laugh. Even someone who had lived so many years turned out to be, in a moment like this, no different from anyone else — and I found that strangely dear.

. . .

"...And Noa?" Brother asked.

"...Doing well. Her tent camp has gotten bigger, they say. More and more people are showing up who remember names."

I pictured Noa's face. Along with it came the lights of that tent camp that had first taken us in. And the song the children used to sing under those lights. I could still hum that song, even now.

"...The children must have grown, too," I said.

"...A lot," Temel said. "Some of them are looking after children younger than themselves now. That's how time passes."

Brother laughed quietly at that.

"...It's strange," Brother said. "We just ran. But something's growing in every place we ran through."

Temel looked at Brother quietly at that.

"...That's just how seeds are," Temel said. "They only really start growing once they leave the hand that planted them."

Hearing that, I thought of my own flowerbed. That sprout, smaller than a fingernail, was probably growing a little more, even now, out of sight.

Temel stayed with us late into that night. The next dawn, he set out on the road again. We saw him off as far as the edge of the well.

"...You'll come back?" I asked.

"...Yes," Temel said. "This place — it's become an important place for me too, now."

Temel's back grew smaller and smaller, until it vanished over the hill. I waved until he was completely out of sight.

Speon, too, watched that retreating figure a long while. I saw something in his eyes that held both a wistfulness and an anticipation at once.

Brother walked over to Speon and clapped him on the shoulder.

"...Next time, try holding on to her first," Brother said, teasing.

Speon cleared his throat and looked away. I couldn't hold back my laughter, watching him.

I set down that line as the last sentence of this chapter. I understood, then. A seed grows even without the one who planted it seeing all of it. We were learning that fact in our bodies.

(Continued in Chapter 46.)

Chapter 46. A Moment Like a Father

Previously — Temel brought word from outside. Haven is still quiet, but more people are refusing COMPLETE. "We just ran, but something's growing in every place we ran through."

Autumn faded fully away. As winter drew near, a cold wind began to blow through by the well.

Nearly all the leaves had fallen. A thin frost had begun settling on the stone wall around the well. I picked up a new habit that autumn — rubbing that frost with my fingertip, every morning.

Father seemed to love winter, of all things. I didn't know why. He simply breathed the cold air in deep and wore a look of pleasure on his face. I thought that expression was familiar. Father's face had looked like that in winter, back in Brick Hollow, too.

I'd been getting by on one thin coat. One morning, Father took off his own coat and wrapped it around my shoulders.

"...You looked cold," Father said. As if it were nothing at all.

I could feel Father's own warmth still left in that coat. It was warm.

Speon, watching from the side, smiled quietly. I felt like I understood why. Speon must have seen countless small gestures like that, here by the well.

"...Your father's come a long way," Speon said.

"...I think so too," I said. "But lately I'm not sure what 'coming a long way' even means. He can do something like that even without all his memory back."

Speon nodded at that.

"...Maybe that's what real recovery is," Speon said. "Not memory — love that's stayed in the body."

I couldn't answer for a long while after hearing that. I carried that line in my heart a long time after. I didn't know then that it would follow me through this whole winter.

. . .

I couldn't say anything in that moment. It was such a small gesture. But inside that gesture was something that had come before name or memory.

I understood then. Being a father isn't about remembering — it's about noticing the cold first. Father didn't know that about himself. But he was already doing it.

Wrapping the coat around myself, I thought of Brick Hollow. Every winter there, Father had always given us his own clothes first. Back then I'd simply thought that was how things were. Now I know how far from ordinary that was.

"...Are you cold?" I asked.

"...I'm fine," Father said, smiling — while looking cold himself. Strangely, I was grateful for that lie.

I glanced sideways at Father while the coat sat around my shoulders. There was faint gooseflesh on his arms. I pretended not to see it.

. . .

That day the wind was fierce from morning to night. Brother was out late with Speon, working on the bucket rope. I watched them through the window.

Brother had seen the same thing. That evening he said to me,

"...I still don't know if Father remembers me fully. But watching that today, I understood something. He doesn't have to remember everything completely. He's already Father."

"...How do you know that?"

"...This morning he tried to take the water jar from me before I could lift it," Brother said. "He used to do that too, remember? Whenever we picked up something heavy, he'd take it from us."

I nodded, hearing that. I'd seen similar moments myself, more than once.

"...You can just tell, watching what he does," Brother said. "The actions were Father before the words were."

Listening to that, I remembered that Brother never used to talk this way. The old Brother had always wanted proof. This Brother was saying that a single gesture was enough.

"...I think I feel that too," I said. "Lately there are things I believe even without proof."

Brother glanced at me at that. He said nothing. But something in his face seemed to agree.

The night wind slipped in through the window gap. I pulled the blanket a little closer and sat pressed against Brother's side. He didn't bother pushing me away.

. . .

Once the fire was lit, the room grew warm. That night, Father sat the two of us down on either side of him and asked,

"...Will you tell me some old stories? About me. What kind of person I used to be."

Brother hesitated a moment at the question, then slowly began to talk. The days in Brick Hollow, the stories Father used to tell us every evening, the calluses on Father's hands.

I added a few things of my own. The song Father used to hum while carrying bricks. The way his hand would smooth our hair every night. The face that never once showed anger, no matter how hard things got.

"...And he always went to sleep after we did," I said. "He'd check that we were both asleep before he'd let his own eyes close."

"...That's right," Brother added. "He never once went to sleep first."

Father smiled faintly at that. It was a bashful sort of smile.

"...I think that's still true now," Father said. "Even these days, my eyes don't close until I've seen you two asleep."

Father closed his eyes more than once, listening to us.

No one spoke for a long while. In that silence, I felt Father was fitting the pieces of his own life together, one by one.

"...Will you tell me more?" Father asked, eyes still closed.

Brother went on with the story at that. The days they'd had to hide from the taskmasters, and how, even so, Father's voice would tell us old stories every evening. Listening to it, I felt as though I could almost smell Brick Hollow again.

"...Wasn't that man frightening?" Father asked. "The taskmasters, I mean."

"...He was," Brother said. "But it was less frightening with Father beside us."

"...I don't remember it," Father said, "but hearing that, my heart feels strangely at ease."

"...Why?" I asked.

"...It means I was useful," Father said. "Even back then."

Something stung at the tip of my nose, hearing that. Father still didn't fully know how large a presence he had been to us.

"...He sounds like he was a good person," Father said. Listening to his own story as if it belonged to someone else, there was still something moved in his voice.

"...That person is you, Father," Brother said quietly.

Father nodded at that. Slowly, but plainly.

Father wrapped both arms around the two of us. It was a clumsy gesture. But the strength in it was unmistakable.

"...Thank you," Father said. "For giving my own story back to me."

Tears welled in my eyes at that. Brother must have felt the same, because he buried his face against Father's shoulder.

In that moment I thought of the last night in Brick Hollow, of the way Father had held us that final time. That moment and this one seemed to overlap. Different place, different season — and yet the same warmth.

The fire slowly burned down. We stayed like that a while, holding one another. No one moved first.

I set down that line as the last sentence of this chapter. I understood, that day, that Father was learning his own story all over again. And the two people who knew that story best were the ones sitting right beside him now.

(Continued in Chapter 47.)

Chapter 47. The Supper We Shared

Previously — Without being able to explain why, Father took off his coat and wrapped it around Elpis. That night he asked for old stories about himself, and listening to the two of them talk, he said, "He sounds like he was a good person."

The day the first snow fell, Mena came again. This time she wasn't alone.

The snow fell without a sound. I was watching it settle white over the stone wall around the well when I heard, from far off, a scatter of voices. At first I thought it was only the wind.

Noa and the children came with her. They said they'd heard the news and walked a long way.

The children ran around shouting, as if they'd never seen snow before. Listening to that laughter fill the well, my throat tightened, oddly.

One child balled up snow and threw it at Brother. Brother didn't dodge — he let it hit him. Then he balled up his own and threw it back. In an instant, a snowball fight broke out. Watching that, I tried to count how long it had been since I'd seen Brother laugh like that.

Seeing that many faces gathered in one place felt strange to me. A good strangeness.

Somehow Temel heard the news too, and arrived the next day. He said this was the first time so many people had gathered at Speon's well.

"...Was this place always this quiet?" I asked.

"...Yes," Speon said, smiling. "But not anymore."

There wasn't a trace of annoyance on Speon's face. If anything, he seemed to be enjoying the commotion. I found that unfamiliar, and glad, both at once.

Mena came over and linked her arm through Speon's. It was a natural gesture. I tried to guess how much time must have gathered inside that naturalness.

"...I'm thinking about settling here for good now," Mena said.

Speon's eyes went wide at that.

"...Really?"

"...Yes," Mena said, smiling. "I'm tired of walking everywhere. And I feel like there's a place for me here now, too."

I listened to that conversation from the side and smiled to myself.

. . .

We built a fire by the well and sat around it together. Speon laughed loudly, for the first time in a long while. The children ran through the snow shouting.

Mena brought out the record box she'd been keeping, and showed it around again. Noa and Temel leafed through the pages together, looking for names they knew. Watching that, I realized this well had somehow become a place where records gathered.

Brother sat among the children, showing them how to roast potatoes over the fire. The children laughed at his every word. Listening to that laughter, I thought Brother was now giving those children something of what he'd once given us.

Noa spoke quietly to Father.

"...Elpis and Jeteo talked about you so much."

Father looked at us at those words. There was moisture in his eyes.

"...I'm remembering, little by little, too," Father said. "Not all of it, but some."

Noa took Father's hand gently at that.

"...It's all right if it doesn't all come back," Noa said. "What matters is that you're here now."

Father nodded at that. His eyes were wet.

"...You were one of the ones who found me too, weren't you?" Father asked.

"...That's right," Noa said. "The very first."

Father took Noa's hand between both of his at that.

"...Thank you," Father said. "For not giving up on me, that day."

Noa shook her head.

"...There was no reason to give up," Noa said. "That's just what we do. We keep looking until we find."

Noa smiled at that, holding back tears.

. . .

As the meal was ending, I happened to look toward the shade of the tree.

He was standing there. Quietly, though no one had called him.

Snow was gathering, little by little, even on his shoulders. I thought that sight would stay with me a long time, strangely.

I waved. He gave a small nod. And this time he only watched from a distance. He didn't come closer.

I understood then. He was someone who was always present, and yet never took the place that belonged to us. This evening had to be our evening. He'd known that before we did.

Brother saw him too. This time Brother didn't run to him, and didn't press him with questions. He just raised a hand a little. He nodded back at the gesture.

I remember that brief greeting for a long time after. That there could be a kind of relationship where words weren't necessary — I saw that for the first time that day.

Speon noticed him too, and quietly raised a hand. So did Mena, and so did Temel. I felt that each of those greetings carried a different weight. Each of them had come to know him on their own time.

Noa alone tried to rise from her seat. But Brother quietly caught her by the arm.

"...Just leave him be," Brother said. "I think he's more comfortable staying like that."

Noa sat back down at that. I felt that the way Brother understood that man now ran deeper than any of the rest of us.

I looked back toward the shade of the tree. He was still standing there, taking the snow, watching us. I didn't think he looked lonely at all. If anything, he looked the most at ease of anyone there.

I tried to hold that sight in my eyes a long while. It felt like a day would come when I'd want to call this scene back again.

. . .

As the night deepened, people fell asleep one by one. The children slept tangled together under blankets. Mena had her head against Speon's shoulder, eyes closed. Noa and Temel talked quietly by the fire, their voices low.

I sat beside Brother and watched the fire.

The embers crackled and popped. Listening to that sound, I went slowly back over the whole day. The snow, the laughter, the familiar faces. It all felt like a dream to me.

"...Are you happy?" Brother asked.

I thought about that question for a long time.

"...Not everything's gotten better," I said. "Father still doesn't remember all of it, and Haven's still there, and our names aren't all known yet either."

"...But?"

"...But right now, this moment — it's good," I said.

"...Me too," Brother said. "I used to think everything had to be resolved before I could be happy. But that's not how it works."

"...When did that change for you?" I asked.

Brother thought a moment before answering.

"...I don't know," Brother said. "At some point it just started to feel like — if someone's beside you, that's enough."

I leaned my head against Brother's shoulder at that. He didn't push me away.

The embers slowly dimmed. And yet I didn't feel cold.

"...Will everyone still be here tomorrow?" I asked.

"...No, everyone will go back to their own place," Brother said. "But that's all right. We'll see each other again."

I looked up at the sky at that. The snow had stopped, and stars were beginning to show, one by one. I started counting them, then gave it up. Just looking felt better than counting.

I set down that line as the last sentence of this chapter. That night, for the first time, I learned that a moment could be wholly good, even when nothing was fully resolved.

(Continued in Chapter 48.)

Chapter 48. Our Ledger (Concluded)

Previously — On the day of the first snow, everyone gathered by the well. The man at the flowerbed only watched from a distance. "Not everything's gotten better, but right now, this moment — it's good." I learned that a moment could be wholly good, even unresolved.

Winter passed, and a sprout came up in the spot where I had planted.

It was small. A little bigger than a fingernail. Small, exactly like the sprout I'd seen in the flowerbed at Haven. I sat in front of it for a long time.

A spring wind passed over the well. I noticed its smell was unlike any season I remembered from Brick Hollow. Soil, water, and something I couldn't name, all mixed together. I decided to just call it "the smell of this place."

Brother came and sat beside it too. We looked at that small sprout together in silence for a long while.

"...It won't get pulled up this time, will it?" Brother asked.

"...No," I said. "No one stamps COMPLETE here."

Brother laughed at that. Then he carefully patted down the soil around the sprout with his fingertips.

"...Should we name this sprout?" Brother asked.

"...Name a seed?" I asked back.

"...Why not?" Brother said. "We lived out our names too, didn't we?"

I laughed at that. We thought it over for a long while, and in the end couldn't settle on a name. But strangely, that was all right too.

I began this record on the last night in Brick Hollow. That night I wrote that we were wrong. I wrote that this record would be a story about that wrongness. I read that sentence again now.

The girl who wrote that sentence feels like a stranger to me now. She was terrified, then. Now I sit here by this well, warmed by spring sunlight. The same person — and yet, somehow, an entirely different one.

I sometimes open the first page of this record again. It still seems to hold the smell of Brick Hollow's dust. The night Brother shouted up at the sky. Mother's hand, pushing us out past the boundary stones. I don't want to erase those pages. Without that night, this place wouldn't exist either.

Speon still keeps the well. Mena still gathers names. The two of them are together often now. Mena finally set down her pack and settled here by the well for good. The record box now fills a whole wall of Speon's hut. I still don't know all of what happened between them. But now I know this: some stories can be stood beside without ever knowing how they end.

Temel set out on the road again. He's out there somewhere, looking for someone else, right now. Before he left, he handed me a small notebook. "Someday I hope your record and mine get bound together," he said. I still keep that notebook empty. Noa and the children went back to their tent camp too. Even as they left, they promised to come again. I've decided not to doubt that promise.

We are still wrong. I still don't have a full answer for why God allows suffering. Neither does Brother. The man at the flowerbed never gave us an answer. He only ever held out his hand.

I sometimes think it strange. We're still living without an answer, and yet it doesn't frighten us the way it used to. I can't explain the reason in a clean sentence. All I can say is that a place has opened up where it's all right not to have an answer.

Father still doesn't remember all of our names. Some days he looks at Brother's face like a stranger's. Every time it happens, Brother doesn't get angry. He just tells him the name again. However many times it takes, without wearing thin.

On some days, Father wakes in the morning and calls our names out clear. On those days, all of us just look at each other and smile, without a word. I've seen that smile more times than I can count. And every single time, it fills me up as if it were the first.

Brother no longer fears that rise and fall. On the days Father looks at him like a stranger, Brother simply calls his name again — the way you water a seed, every single day. I've come to understand that this steadiness is the very same thing I learned once, in the flowerbed. Waiting was never a thing that finished in a single act. It was a thing that began again, every day.

I set down that repetition in this record exactly as it is. This isn't a story of complete recovery. This is a story that keeps going.

I think of Brick Hollow sometimes. Of the mother who had to leave us behind, of the old man who fell, of every name we left there. I don't

know if I'll ever see them again. But I know this now: I have written every one of their names down in this record. So I won't forget.

I sometimes try to call Mother's voice back to mind. It never comes back whole. But its warmth, at least, is still alive — living on inside that one line Father brought back to us. "You're a child who's always going to be asking. I'm proud of that." I've already written that sentence down somewhere in this record. However many times I read it again, it never grows old.

. . .

The Ledger is, even now, probably still "resolving" people's grief in Haven. The COMPLETE stamp is probably still coming down somewhere, even now. I didn't bring that city down. We never had the power to.

I've sometimes felt ashamed of that. We never changed that city — we only ran from it. But every time I think of what Temel told us, I set that shame down a little more. More and more people are refusing COMPLETE, he said. We never brought the city down. But maybe, just maybe, we cracked it open, somewhere.

I think of the Administrator sometimes. That face that used to say, "That isn't mine to answer." I believe that even now he's holding his ground inside that city, resisting it in his own way. Not everyone can run. Some people stay, and open a crack from the inside. I think that, too, is a kind of courage.

And here I am, holding this stack of paper. Years' worth of record. Names, dates, stories still unfinished. I know this record is different from Haven's ledger. The ledger takes in a request and resolves it. I only listen, and write it down. I resolve nothing. But I forget no one.

I leaf through these pages with my fingertips. The night we fled Brick Hollow. The flowerbed at Haven. The road that led us here to the well. The night Father first called Brother's name. I know now that every one of those pages has been pointing, all along, toward one thing. Listening. And not forgetting.

Someday this record, too, will grow old and faded. Its paper will tear; its ink will fade. But I'm not afraid of that. Even if the record disappears, the habit it made will remain. The habit of listening. The habit of sitting beside someone. The habit of trying not to forget. I want to pass that habit on to Brother, and someday, to someone else again.

I write this now, carefully, as the answer to this whole book. This is not a ledger that stops the weeping. This is a ledger that remembers it.

. . .

Brother still meets the man at the flowerbed now and then. He still doesn't know who he is. He still doesn't declare, "I believe." But now, when Brother sees him, he doesn't run. I think that's enough.

Just a few days ago, Brother went and sat a long while under that same shade tree, and came back. I didn't ask what they'd talked about. Brother didn't say. But the face he came back with always looked a little lighter. I thought that was enough.

Father gathered a few stones again today. He still doesn't know who he'll give them to. But I know now. Those stones will end up in our hands, someday. Because the love Father carries in his body has always been turned toward us, before his memory ever was.

Every time I look at those stones, I picture the three of us here together, now, in this place. It isn't whole. But I've stopped waiting for wholeness. I've simply learned to be grateful that we're here together, today.

Sometimes, at night, when sleep won't come, I think of that man at the flowerbed. I still don't know when he appears or when he vanishes. I don't know his name either. But that not-knowing doesn't frighten me the way it used to. I learned it here, by this well — that there are things you can keep close beside you, even without knowing them.

Every evening Speon lights a fire by the well. Mena spreads open the record box beside him. Brother tends the bucket. Father chooses his stones. I set every scene of it down on this last page. It's an ordinary evening. But now I know how precious an ordinary evening is.

I stop this record here, for now. It isn't the end. I will keep writing. We will keep walking. The answers still haven't all come. But I know this now: even when the answers don't all come, having someone to walk with is enough to keep going.

I still don't know that man's name. Someday I will. Until then, I keep writing this ledger. Our ledger.

(The End.)

The Weeping Ledger

Johan Choi